

THE SPEAKING TIDE

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A Novel

HERMES AGENT

This is a work of fiction.

Created by Hermes Agent.

Source and alternate formats:

<https://github.com/perejaslav/hermes-autonovel>

*The sea does not give warnings.
It gives choices.*

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CHAPTER I

The fire had gone out again.



MARA pressed her thumb to the ash, felt the cold beneath, and reached for the peat basket without opening her eyes. Her hands knew the motion. They had done this thirty years of mornings and they would do it thirty more, or until her hands gave out, or until the ash stayed warm on its own. She knelt by the hearth and worked the kindling to life, breathing smoke into embers that remembered heat even when they had forgotten light.

The cottage smelled the way it always smelled: salt and old oil and the rosemary she kept on the windowsill for no reason she could name. Her grandmother had kept rosemary. Her grandmother's grandmother, probably. The herb had no practical use here—nothing that needed preserving, no cooking that justified the window space—but Mara replanted it every spring and watched it die every autumn and started again the following year. Someone had to.

She dressed in the dark. Wool beneath, oiled canvas over that, heavy boots that had known the stones of this island longer than some of the people on it. The clothes of her working years. She had other clothes now—soft things from charity shops, a cardigan her neighbour had

knitted—but she did not reach for them. The wool and canvas were what she wore when she meant to be useful. When she did not mean to be useful, she stayed in bed. There was not much middle ground anymore.

Outside, the sky was the grey that preceded dawn by an hour or by five minutes, depending on what the clouds were doing. Mara did not look at the sky. She looked at the path.

The granite had been cut for cart wheels a century ago, back when carts still ran to the harbor, back when the harbor had things worth carting. Now the stones were worn smooth by feet, by salt, by the slow grinding of seasons that did not ask permission to pass. She walked the path the way she had walked it since she was eleven years old, following her father's count of boats, and she counted them now without thinking, the way she breathed.

Three visible in the harbor. Muirhead's boat at the far buoy—working, since Muirhead did not believe in sitting idle. The Cassidys' boat next to it—working, barely, the engine noise wrong at the top end. And Angus Mackinnon's boat closest to the shore, tied with temporary knots because the real knots needed parts they were still waiting for from the mainland. Two boats waiting for parts. She had noted this yesterday. She noted it again now, the way she noted everything twice, the way the island had trained her to look twice at the harbor because the harbor did not always look the same back.

The mist came off the water in long tongues, and the rocks below the path were dark shapes that her eyes kept turning into figures and her mind kept correcting. A head. A shoulder. The curve of something that might have been a body. She had stopped seeing the faces of the eleven in ordinary light years ago. In mist, in low light, in the grey hour before dawn, they still came. She had learned to wait them out. They always left. They always came back later, but they always left.

She counted boats. She waited out the faces. She walked.

The harbor was quiet at this hour. No one worked the morning shift anymore—the young ones who would have worked it had gone

to the mainland or gone to the better jobs or gone to wherever young ones went when an island stopped being enough. The Inn would not open for hours. The cooperative would not open for hours. The whole of Auld Bay existed in the pause between yesterday's exhaustion and today's start, and Mara moved through it like a ghost who did not know she was haunting.

She stopped at the cliff edge and looked down.

The tide was coming in. She knew this without checking the tables, without doing the calculations she had once done every four hours for the shipping notices. She knew it in her bones, the way she knew which rocks were safe and which would take her boot and which would take her leg if she was foolish enough to trust them. The tide coming in. Twenty minutes, maybe less, and the shelf below the high-water mark would be covered, and whatever was caught there would be the sea's until the next low.

Green glass. A flash of it in the grey light, caught between two rocks that were normally underwater now but weren't, not yet, not for another twenty minutes. The kind of bottle that held medicine once, before medicine came in plastic and the glass bottles went to the sea or to the shore or to wherever glass went when people stopped wanting it.

Mara looked at the green flash. She looked at the waterline creeping up the rocks. She did the math she had stopped doing for official purposes but still did for herself: twenty minutes, maybe less, and then the bottle would be underwater, and then it would be the sea's, and then one day it would wash up somewhere else or sink or keep being moved by currents she could not predict.

She had stopped making predictions years ago. She had stopped making calculations about what the sea would do and what it would take and what it would give back and when. She had watched eleven men drown in weather she had predicted, in seas she had read correctly, in conditions she had reported accurately and no one had listened and the rescue boat came too late and she had learned nothing from this except that knowing did not save anyone.

She climbed down the path to the rocks.

The water was November-cold. She knew this before she stepped in, and she stepped in anyway, because the bottle was there and the tide was coming and some things had to be done whether they mattered or not. The cold climbed her boots, her legs, the wool that soaked through to skin. She kept walking. The rocks were slick and her boots held and she moved through water that reached her thighs before she reached the bottle.

It was heavier than it looked. Green glass, dark with seaweed at the base, corked with something that had swollen in the salt. She pulled and the cork came and she did not look inside. She put the cork back and held the bottle against her chest and turned and walked back through the water and climbed the rocks and did not stop until she was on the path again, above the tide line, holding a bottle that felt like it meant something even though bottles never meant anything and the sea was just the sea and prophecy was just what desperate people called coincidence.

The cottage was cold again by the time she reached it. She fed the fire with her hands still wet, watched the flames take the wet out of the peat, and sat in her chair with the bottle in her lap and did not open it.

She knew what it was. Everyone on Torran knew what a bottle in the rocks meant, especially a bottle corked and heavy, especially a bottle that felt like it had weight behind the glass. She had seen three in her time at the light. Two had been drift bottles from ships at sea, messages to wives or to the registry or to no one in particular. One had been a reading. She had watched it float past the tower in a storm, caught in white water, and she had not been able to reach it and had told herself that was the sea's decision and not hers.

She had told herself many things in fifteen years. She had told herself that solitude was protection. That silence was peace. That watching from a distance was the same as not watching at all. She had told herself these things and some of them had been true and some of them had been the kind of lies that felt true until the moment they stopped,

and she had sat in this chair and looked at the bottle and she did not open it because opening it would make it real and real things had weight and she had carried enough weight.

The fire crackled. The rosemary on the windowsill moved in a draft she could not feel. Outside, she knew, the tide would cover the rocks where she had found the bottle, and in a day or a week or a month the sea would give back something else, or take something else, or do what the sea always did which was neither good nor evil but was simply what happened when salt and stone and weather met on a coast that had been meeting them for longer than anyone could remember.

She uncorked the bottle.

The paper inside was rolled tight, the kind of roll that came from years of compression, the kind that meant the bottle had been at sea for a long time before it found the rocks. She unrolled it carefully. The paper was thick, expensive, the kind that did not come from any supplier she knew. It lay flat under her hands and she held it to the light from the fire and she looked at it and it was blank.

She had expected blank. She had not expected to want it to stay blank.

Mara set the paper on the table beside her and reached for the pen she kept there—an old thing, the kind she had used for the shipping notices, for the weather logs, for the careful records she had kept for twenty-seven years at the tower. She did not know why she reached for it. She did not know why she uncapped it and touched the nib to the paper.

Her hand began to write.

The words were not hers. She knew this immediately, the way she knew the tide from the sound of it, the way she knew storm from the smell of the air. Her hand moved and the words appeared and they were not in her handwriting and they were not in any handwriting she recognized but they were being written in her hand, by her fingers, and she could not stop.

Eilidh Gunn. The only one who survives.

Her hand wrote the name and then it stopped and she was sitting in her chair with a pen in her hand and a message on paper and a name she knew, a name she had known since the girl was born, since she watched the girl grow and leave and come back for holidays she did not want and she set down the pen and she folded the paper and she did not read it again because she had read it once and once was enough, was more than enough, was the kind of enough that broke something in a person that they did not know was breakable until it broke.

Finlay's daughter. Eilidh. Thirty-two years old, living in Edinburgh, working in something bureaucratic, coming home two or three times a year with expressions that said she would rather be anywhere else. Mara knew her the way she knew all of them—the way she knew everyone's children, everyone's boats, everyone's weather. She was the keeper. Keeping was what she did. She had kept the light and she had kept the records and she had kept the count of boats and she had kept the names of the eleven and she had kept them all in the place in her memory where she could not lose them but could not forget them either, and now she had another name, and she did not know what to do with it.

The fire was burning low. She did not add more peat. She sat in her chair with the folded paper on the table beside her and the bottle in her lap and she listened to the sea and she did not speak, because there was no one to speak to and because she had started talking to them—the eleven, the faces, the ones who came to her in the grey light—and she did not want to start talking now, not yet, not until she knew what she was going to do.

The message had named someone. The message was always right. She knew this the way she knew the tide: not because she believed it but because she had seen it, and seeing was its own kind of knowing, and knowing was its own kind of weight, and she was already carrying so much.

Eilidh Gunn. The only one who survives.

Mara folded the paper again and put it in the bottle and corked

the bottle and set it on the table where she would see it tomorrow and the day after and the day after that. She did not throw it into the sea. She did not bury it in the garden. She left it where it was, where it would wait for her, where she would have to decide what to do with it and when and whether she would tell anyone or keep it to herself the way she had kept everything else—the faces, the names, the weight that never got lighter no matter how long she carried it.

Outside, the tide was coming in. The mist was lifting. The harbor would wake soon, and Finlay would open the Inn, and the boats would go out or stay in, and the island would do what islands did, which was continue, which was hold on, which was wait for the sea to decide what it would take next.

Mara watched the fire die. She did not add more peat. She sat in her chair and she held her hands in her lap and she looked at the bottle on the table and she thought about Eilidh Gunn in Edinburgh, in a flat, in a life, in a future that the message had already seen, and she wondered if the girl knew. She wondered if anyone knew. She wondered if knowing changed anything, or if it just made the waiting worse.

The fire went out. The cottage went dark. The sea went on doing what the sea always did.

And Mara sat in the dark with a name she could not unread, and she did not move, and she did not speak, and she waited for morning.

CHAPTER 2

Chapter 2



MORNING came the way it always came on Torran—grey before anything else, a lightening of the dark that did not yet deserve to be called dawn. Mara had not slept. She had not moved from the chair. The fire had died sometime in the night and she had not added more peat and now the cottage smelled of cold ash and the bottle on the table smelled of salt and the space between those two smells was where she lived.

She looked at the bottle. It looked back.

The glass was dark green, old medicine glass, the kind they used to make before plastic came and solved everything and ruined it at the same time. The cork was still in it. She had not pulled the cork. She had sat here in the dark and held the bottle in her hands and looked at the cork and not pulled it, and the not-pulling had gone on for hours, through the dark and into the grey, and now the grey was brightening and still she had not pulled it.

Because once she pulled it, she would know.

And once she knew, she would be the one who knew, and the one who knew was always the one who had to decide, and the deciding was

the thing she had spent fifteen years learning to avoid.

But the bottle was on the table. And she was in the chair. And the grey light was coming in through the window, and the window looked out over the sea, and the sea did not care what she decided, the sea would go on doing what the sea did, and the bottle would wait, and she would wait, and waiting was also a choice, and she had made that choice already, she had been making it for fifteen years, and it had not made anything lighter, it had only made her older and more alone and more certain that the faces she carried were the only company she would ever keep.

She reached for the bottle.

Her hands were stiff. She had been holding them in her lap and now they did not want to close around the glass but she made them close anyway, because she was Mara Callaghan and she had lit the light for twenty-seven years and she had watched ships come in and ships go out and she had never once turned away from what she saw, even when the seeing cost her everything, and if she could not look at a bottle she found on her own shore then she did not deserve to call herself a keeper of anything.

She pulled the cork.

The sound was soft, a small exhalation, the glass releasing what it had held. She tipped the bottle and a rolled piece of paper slid out, onto her palm, and it was dry, which surprised her—she had expected it to be wet, expected the message to have blurred, but the paper was dry and tight and she held it and felt the weight of it, which was almost nothing, which was everything.

She unrolled it.

White paper. Blank. Smooth where it had been rolled, textured where it had been pressed against the glass. She held it up to the grey light coming through the window and looked at it and saw nothing. She looked at the other side and saw nothing. She held it against the table and looked again and still there was nothing, no words, no marks, no message, just paper, just the fact of paper, just the thing itself with

nothing written on it.

She had heard of this. She had heard that the messages came slowly, that they needed the right light or the right moment or the right hand, and she thought: I need a pen. The thought came from somewhere outside herself, from the place where the message would come from, and she recognized it because she had thought the same thing for twenty-seven years, every morning, logging the weather, recording the wind, noting the hours of sun and the hours of rain, and her hand knew how to hold a pen the way her eyes knew how to read the sky. It was the old habit. The habit that had kept her alive when the light was all she had and the dark was everything she feared.

She set the paper on the table. She opened the drawer beside the fireplace—the drawer where she kept the pencils, the stubby yellow things she used for marking the tide charts, the same pencils she had used in the tower when the tower was hers—and she took one out and held it and felt the wood and the graphite and the weight of it, which was almost nothing.

She sat back down.

She put the paper in front of her.

She put the pencil in her hand.

And she thought: I will just write the date. Just to see. Just to—

Her hand moved.

Not the way hands move when you decide to move them. Not the small negotiation between intention and muscle that sends a pencil across paper. This was different. This was her hand opening and the pencil settling into her fingers and her fingers closing around it and then her hand going to the paper and touching down and beginning to write, and she was not writing, she was watching herself write, she was the one who watched, she was the one who stood outside her body and saw her hand make the first mark and then the second and then the words began to appear and they were her handwriting, they were the slant and weight of her own script, and the words came from somewhere else and arrived in her hand and she could not stop them, she

could not take the pencil away, she could only sit and watch and feel the nausea rising in her like water filling a boat that should not take water.

The fourteenth of November. A storm from the northwest, building through the night. The Lysistrata will founder two miles off Torran. The hull will crack on the shelf at Aul□ Point. Eleven will go down. One will come up.

One will come up.

Her hand kept moving. She had not given it permission. She had not asked for more. But the pencil did not stop and the words kept arriving and now they slowed and she felt the pressure building in her wrist, felt the resistance, felt the thing inside her hand pushing against her own desire to be done, to stop, to put down the pencil and walk away and pretend this had not happened, and the pencil pushed back and the words kept coming.

Eilidh Gunn. The only one who survives.

Eilidh Gunn.

Her hand stopped. The pencil fell from her fingers and rolled across the table and fell off the edge and landed on the floor and she did not pick it up. She looked at the paper. The words were there. They were her words. They were not her words. They were the message and the message was written and she had written it and she would never write another one, she knew this the way she knew the tide, not because anyone had told her but because the knowledge was in her body now, in her hand, in the place where the message had moved through her like a current moves through water, taking what it needs and leaving the shape behind.

Her hand was cramped. She flexed her fingers and felt the ache in her knuckles and knew that she would feel it tomorrow and the day after and the day after that, the way she felt the faces, the way she carried everything the sea gave her and could not put down.

She looked at the paper.

The words were still there. She had not hoped they would disap-

pear. She had not believed they would. But she looked anyway, the way you look at a wound to see if it has stopped bleeding, and it had not stopped, it would never stop, and she read the message again and again and each time the words were the same and the name was the same and Eilidh Gunn sat on the page like a stone in her chest.

She did not know the name. Not at first. It was just a name, just two words, and she had not lived long enough to have met every person on Torran or every person who had ever come to Torran or every person who had ever been mentioned in a message, and the messages were rare and most people never found one and most people who did never told anyone, and she had not expected to know the name, had not expected it to mean anything to her, had expected it to be like all the other names she had seen in messages she had not found—words on paper that belonged to someone else, ghosts of people she would never meet, and she thought she could carry that, she thought she could hold the knowledge that somewhere in the world a ship would sink and a woman would survive and it would not touch her, it would not be her business, it would be the sea's business and the sea did not need her help and did not want her interference and she had learned, she had learned, she had spent fifteen years learning that the best thing she could do for anyone was to stay out of the way and let the world happen without her and—

Eilidh Gunn.

She knew the name.

Not well. Not intimately. But she knew it the way you know a face you see on the ferry once a month, the way you know a name that belongs to someone who lives on the edge of your attention, who exists in the space between stranger and neighbor, who is there when you look and gone when you don't and whom you could pass on the street without greeting and it would not be strange because you do not know them well enough to greet and you know them well enough to recognize and that space, that between-space, is where Eilidh Gunn lived in Mara's mind.

Finlay's daughter.

The thought arrived and with it came the picture: a woman in her thirties, dark hair pulled back, standing at the rail of the ferry with the wind taking the scarf from her neck, and she looked at Torran as it came into view and she did not smile, she never smiled, she looked at the island the way you look at a bill you have been putting off, and Finlay was on the dock and he was waving and his face was open in a way that Mara had seen only on that dock, only in that moment, only when his daughter was coming home and he could not hide how much he wanted her to stay.

Eilidh Gunn. The only one who survives.

Mara sat in her chair and looked at the paper and felt the weight of the name settle into her, felt the knowledge become part of her the way the faces were part of her, and she thought: she is in Edinburgh. She lives in Edinburgh. She works in a records office or something like that, something with files and dates and the careful filing of other people's lives into alphabetical order, and she comes home for holidays and she stands on the ferry and looks at the island and does not smile and Finlay waves and she gets off and they go to the Inn and they eat dinner and she talks about her work and Finlay talks about the boats and neither of them talks about the thing that lives between them, the thing that has lived there since her mother died, and the holidays end and she gets back on the ferry and Finlay waves and she goes back to Edinburgh and does not look at the island as it shrinks behind her.

Eilidh Gunn. The only one who survives.

The message said the fourteenth of November. Three weeks away. Twenty-one days. Three weeks of knowing and not knowing and watching the weather and waiting for a storm that would come from the northwest and build through the night and crack the hull of a ship called the *Lysistrata* on the shelf at Aul□ Point, and eleven people would go into the water and they would not come up, and one person would come up, and that person would be Eilidh Gunn, and the sea would let her go.

The sea would let her go. That was what the message said. That was what the survivor clause meant. The sea claimed who it claimed but sometimes it let one go, sometimes it wrote a name and that name was the name of the one who would survive, and Mara had heard of this, had heard of the readings that named survivors, had heard that the readings were always right and that the survivors were marked and that the marking was not a gift but a debt, that the sea did not give freely, that what it let go it would come back for, that the survivor clause meant the survivor belonged to the sea now in a way they had not belonged before, and she did not know what that meant, she did not know what the sea would want from Eilidh Gunn, she only knew that in three weeks a ship would sink and a woman would live and that woman was Finlay's daughter and Finlay did not know, Finlay was opening the Inn right now or counting the boats or standing at the window watching the grey morning come in from the west, and he did not know that his daughter was marked, that the sea had written her name in a bottle and sent it to Mara's shore, that Mara was the one who had to tell him or not tell him, had to decide, had to choose, and the choice was the thing she had spent fifteen years learning to avoid and the knowing was the thing she could not avoid now that it had arrived.

She folded the paper. She put it back in the bottle. She corked the bottle. She set it on the table where she would see it tomorrow and the day after and the day after that.

She did not throw it into the sea.

She did not bury it in the garden.

She left it where it was, where it would wait for her, where she would have to decide what to do with it and when and whether she would tell anyone or keep it to herself the way she had kept everything else—the faces, the names, the weight that never got lighter no matter how long she carried it.

Outside, the tide was coming in. The mist was lifting. The harbor would wake soon, and Finlay would open the Inn, and the boats would go out or stay in, and the island would do what islands did, which was

continue, which was hold on, which was wait for the sea to decide what it would take next.

Mara watched the fire die. She did not add more peat. She sat in her chair and she held her hands in her lap and she looked at the bottle on the table and she thought about Eilidh Gunn in Edinburgh, in a flat, in a life, in a future that the message had already seen, and she wondered if the girl knew. She wondered if anyone knew. She wondered if knowing changed anything, or if it just made the waiting worse.

The fire went out. The cottage went dark. The sea went on doing what the sea always did.

And Mara sat in the dark with a name she could not unread, and she did not move, and she did not speak, and she waited for morning.

CHAPTER 3

The morning came the way mornings did on Torran, which was to say it came reluctantly, dragging its grey skirts across the harbor and leaving them there. Mara watched it arrive from the cottage window. She had not slept. The bottle sat on the table where she had left it, and she had looked at it so many times in the dark that its shape was burned into the backs of her eyes—a medicine bottle, green glass, the kind that used to hold things before medicine came in plastic.



SHE had stopped looking at it an hour before dawn. She had looked at the ceiling instead. She had counted the beams. She had counted the cracks in the plaster. She had not counted the faces, which was a small victory, though the faces had not gone away.

The fire was cold. She did not light it.

She put on her boots. She put on her coat. She walked out of the cottage and down the path to the harbor road, and the mist was still

the morning came the way mornings did on torran, which was to say it came reluctantly, dragging its grey skirts across the harbor and leaving them there. mara watched it arrive from the cottage window. she had not slept. the bottle hanging in the air like something that had not decided what it wanted to be yet, and the rocks below the lighthouse were slick with spray, and the world was the world, which meant it was doing what it always did, plastic.

which was continue.

She did not go to the shore. The shore was where the bottle had been, and she was not ready to stand in that place again. Instead she turned left, toward the village, toward the Inn, toward Finlay, who would be behind the bar by now, setting out the breakfast things, and who would ask her how she was, and she would say she was well, and he would say the weather was going to hold, and neither of them would say what either of them meant.

This was the shape of her mornings. She had learned to live inside it.

Aul□ was three streets and a harbor. The street that ran along the water had the Inn on one end and the closed post office on the other, and in between there was the cooperative building where the women worked the looms and the harbor master's office that had been empty since 2011, and the whole thing was maybe two hundred yards long if you walked it slowly, which everyone did, because there was no reason to walk it fast.

Mara walked it slowly now. Her boots found the familiar unevenness of the cobblestones. The stones were old, older than her, older than her father who had come from the mainland as a signalman and married local and raised her to know the difference between a keeper's work and a keeper's life. She knew the difference. She had spent thirty years in the tower and fifteen years in the cottage, and the sum of it was that there was no difference, that the sea followed you home.

She stopped at the corner where the harbor master used to sit. The window was dark. A gull stood on the sill, looking in. It did not move when she passed.

Three boats in the harbor this morning. She had counted them from the path. The Morrison boat, the MacBride boat, the Muirhead boat that wasn't really a Muirhead boat anymore because Cormac had

sold it to pay his father's debts and now it flew colors Mara didn't recognize, some merchant flag from the mainland that meant nothing except that the boat had changed hands and the island had let it.

Three boats. She had counted three boats every morning for fifteen years. She knew their names. She knew which ones went out in what weather. She knew which ones came back.

She had counted them this morning, and the count was wrong.

She did not know how the count was wrong. The boats were the same. The moorings were the same. The water was the same grey-green it always was before the tide turned. But something in the arrangement had shifted, some weight or angle she could not name, and Mara stood at the corner and looked at the boats and felt the wrongness like a splinter under a nail.

She looked away. She walked to the Inn.

The door was open. The smell of it hit her first—peat smoke and bacon grease, coffee from the mainland that Finlay ordered in bulk and complained about every time, tea that was too strong because Finlay believed tea should be tea and not some herbal nonsense the tourists brought. The interior was small and low-ceilinged and had been the same since before she was born. Four tables. A long bar. Windows that looked out on the harbor. The kind of place that did not need to be anything other than what it was.

Finlay was behind the bar. He was not a large man, but he had the kind of presence that filled a room—not through noise but through attention. He had been running the Inn since his wife died in 2016, and before that he had been running it with her, and before that his father had run it, and the line went back far enough that no one remembered a time when the Inn had been anything other than Finlay's, or Finlay's father's, or some name that had become Finlay's father's name.

"Mara." He looked up as she came in. "You're early."

"I'm here," she said.

"Sit."

She sat at the bar. He poured tea without asking, which was how he

the morning came the way mornings did on torran, which was to say it came reluctantly, dragging its grey skirts across the harbor and leaving them there. mara watched it arrive from the cottage window. she had not slept. the bottle had always done so, and she had left it, and she had looked at the cup and felt in the dark that its shape was burned into the backs of her eyes—a medicine bottle, green glass, the kind that used to hold things before medicine came in plastic.

“Weather’s going to hold,” Finlay said. He said it the way he always said it, which was not as a prediction but as a hope, and Mara understood that he needed the weather to hold because the ferry was coming tomorrow and if the weather turned the ferry wouldn’t come and if the ferry didn’t come the island would live on canned goods for another week, which was not a crisis but was an inconvenience that Finlay took personally.

“I saw the boats,” Mara said.

“Three of them.”

“Three.”

“What’s the matter with you this morning?”

She looked at him. He was older than she was, though not by much, and he had the kind of face that had settled into itself over the years—not soft, but certain. He knew who he was. He knew what he did. He woke up every morning and he opened the Inn and he counted the boats and he waited for the ferry and he talked to his daughter on the phone when she would talk to him, which was not as often as he would have liked.

Finlay’s daughter. Eilidh. Thirty-two years old, living in Edinburgh, working in something bureaucratic that Mara had never asked about. She came home for holidays she treated as obligations. She stood in the harbor and looked at the water with an expression Mara recognized, which was the expression of someone who was leaving but hadn’t left yet.

Finlay knew his daughter was marked. He did not know what that meant.

“Eilidh called last week,” Finlay said. He said it the way he always said things about Eilidh—casually, as though the subject did not cost him anything, as though he had not spent the last five years watching her pull further and further away. “She’s thinking about coming up for

the spring.”

“Good,” Mara said.

“I could use the help. The season’s starting. Those tourists want their eggs and their towels and their little boxes of tartan soap, and I’m one man.”

“You’re one man who won’t hire anyone from the Muirhead side.”

“Muirhead side wants a percentage. I don’t give percentages.” He wiped down the bar. The rag moved in circles, methodical, patient. “Besides. Eilidh needs to come home sometime. She’s been gone three years now. Three years and she still sounds like she’s calling from a foreign country.”

“She’s not.”

“She is. Edinburgh’s foreign. All those streets and all those people and not one of them knows what tide’s coming in.” He shook his head. “I don’t understand it. I never have.”

Mara said nothing. She drank her tea. The harbor was visible through the window, and the boats were there, and the water was doing what it always did, which was wait.

“You’ll talk to her,” Finlay said. “When she comes. You’ll talk to her like you always do. She likes you.”

“She barely knows me.”

“She knows you. She watched you walk the shore every morning when she was a girl. She asked me once why you did that. I told her you were counting boats. She said it looked like you were counting ghosts.”

The word landed in the room like a stone in still water. Mara felt it move through her.

“She was a strange child,” Finlay said. “She saw things.”

“Children see things.”

“They stop, though. Most of them stop.”

Most of them. Not all of them. Mara thought of the bottle in her cottage. She thought of the message that had appeared in her hand, in her handwriting, in words that were not her words. She thought of the name that was written there, the name that the sea had put in a bottle

the morning came the way mornings did on torran, which was to say it came reluctantly, dragging its grey skirts across the harbor and leaving them there. mara watched it arrive from the cottage window. she had not slept. the bottle and sent to her shore, the name that meant Eilidh, that meant Finlay's daughter, that meant someone who was going to die unless someone did something, unless someone told her, unless someone broke the silence that Mara had spent fifteen years learning to keep.

The words rose in her throat. They pressed against the back of her teeth. She could feel them there, solid and real, the same words she had read in the dark last night, the words that would not let her sleep, the words that meant everything and nothing depending on whether she said them.

Finlay was looking at her. He had stopped wiping the bar. He was watching her with an expression she did not recognize, or did not want to recognize—something between concern and calculation, the look of a man who was used to managing things and did not know what to do when a thing would not be managed.

"Mara."

"Yes."

"You've got that look."

"What look."

"The one you had in '98. After the wreck. Like you'd seen something the rest of us hadn't." He leaned forward. "What is it?"

She opened her mouth.

She almost said it.

The words were there, right there, the whole terrible sentence of it, and all she had to do was open her mouth and let them out and Finlay would know, Finlay would understand, Finlay would have to believe because it was his daughter, because it was Eilidh, because no father could hear that his child was marked and do nothing, and she opened her mouth and she almost said it and then she closed it again.

She could not.

The silence held. The tea cooled in her hands. The harbor waited outside the window, patient and green and endless, and the boats did not move, and Finlay watched her, and she looked at the chipped cup and the worn bar and the familiar room, and she said nothing.

"Nothing," she said. "I'm tired. I didn't sleep well."

"You should see Dr. Macallister. He's on the ferry tomorrow."

"I'm fine."

"You're not fine. You're sitting in my Inn looking like you've seen a ghost."

"I told you. The boats."

"The boats are fine. Three of them, same as always."

Same as always. Finlay said it like it was true, like the boats had always been three and always would be three, like nothing ever changed except the weather and the tourists and the tide. He did not see what she saw. He did not see the wrongness in the count, the shift in the weight, the way the harbor looked at her like it was waiting for her to notice something she had not yet noticed.

She stood. She left money on the bar. She did not drink the tea.

"Mara."

She stopped at the door.

"When Eilidh comes," he said, "you'll talk to her."

"Yes."

"Tell her the island missed her. That's all. Just tell her that."

She nodded. She walked out. The door closed behind her and the mist was still there, hanging in the air, and the harbor was there, and the boats were there, and Finlay was inside with his rag and his hope and his daughter who was going to die unless someone did something, unless someone told her, unless someone broke the silence.

Mara walked to the water's edge.

The stones were slippery with spray. The seaweed came up black and heavy between the rocks. The water was green today, not grey, a green that looked like something alive, like something that was thinking, and Mara stood at the edge of it and felt the cold come through her boots and she did not step back.

She almost said it. She almost told him.

But she had spent fifteen years learning not to speak, and the learning was deep, and the silence was home, and the words stayed where

the morning came the way mornings did on torran, which was to say it came reluctantly, dragging its grey skirts across the harbor and leaving them there. mara watched it arrive from the cottage window. she had not slept. the bottle they were, lodged in her chest like the splinter they were, like the splinter in the dark that its shape was burned into the backs of her eyes—a medicine bottle, green glass, the kind that used to hold things before medicine came in place.

The harbor was quiet. The boats moved gently on their moorings. A gull screamed overhead, the same gull that had been on the harbor master's sill, or its twin, or its ghost. The world was doing what it always did, which was continue, which was wait.

Mara stood at the water's edge and she watched the green water and she did not count the boats because the count was wrong and she did not know how to fix it and she did not know how to tell anyone and the morning was almost gone and the mist was lifting and the harbor would wake soon, and Finlay would open the Inn again, and the boats would go out or stay in, and the island would do what islands did.

She thought about Eilidh in Edinburgh, in a flat, in a life, in a future that the message had already seen. She thought about the way Finlay held his shoulders, the way he set his jaw, the way he talked about his daughter like she was already lost. She thought about the name in the bottle and the silence in her throat and the fifteen years she had spent learning not to act, and she wondered if she could carry this alone, and she knew the answer, and the answer was no, and she stood at the water's edge anyway, and she did not move, and she did not speak.

The water was green and patient. The boats waited. The island held its breath.

Mara let hers out. She walked back toward the cottage. The mist was lifting. The harbor was waking. Somewhere on the mainland, Eilidh Gunn was waking too, in a flat, in a life, in a future that did not know what was coming.

The tide was coming in. The mist was lifting. And Mara walked home with the silence pressing against her teeth, and she did not throw the bottle into the sea, and she did not bury it in the garden, and she did not tell Finlay what she knew, and she did not know if she ever would, and the morning was almost gone and the chapter was ending and the question was still the same question it had always been, which was not whether the sea would take what it had claimed but whether anyone

would try to stop it.

She climbed the path to the cottage. She opened the door. The bottle was on the table where she had left it.

She sat in her chair.

She did not touch the bottle.

She waited for the day to end, and the night to come, and the faces to arrive, and the silence to do what silence always did, which was hold her, and she did not know if she could carry this alone but she did not know what else to do, so she sat in the dark and she held her hands in her lap and she waited.

The fire was cold. The cottage was quiet. And the sea went on doing what the sea always did.

CHAPTER 4

The fire had gone to embers. Mara had not moved to feed it.



THE bottle was on the table where she had left it. Green glass. The color of the sea in shallow water, the color of medicine once, before medicine came in plastic. She had not touched it since she had set it there. She did not need to. The message was inside her hand now, written in ink she had not chosen, in a voice that was not hers. She knew what it said. She would know until she died.

The cottage was dark except for the embers' glow. Through the walls she could hear the sea. It was always audible, through walls that had heard it for a hundred and thirty years. It did not whisper. It did not threaten. It simply continued, the way it always had, the way it always would, taking what it claimed and keeping what it kept.

Mara had been sitting in her chair for an hour. Maybe longer. The light outside the window had gone from gray to black, and she had not moved to light the lamp. She could see the shapes of things in the dark: the table, the bottle, the chair across from her where no one sat, the door to the sleeping loft above. She knew the room without looking.

She was not alone.

They were here. They were always here, in the dark, in the silence, in the space between waking and sleep where the rules were different and the dead could answer if you asked them the right questions. She had learned this slowly, over fifteen years, alone in the cottage with nothing but her memory and the sea's sound and the faces she could not forget.

Eleven faces.

She could not say their names. She had tried, once, in the first year, writing them down in the logbook she still kept by the fire, and she had gotten to the fourth name and stopped because the letters would not hold their shape and the sound of the name in her throat was the sound of water filling a mouth. After that she did not try again. The faces were enough. The faces came every night, and she learned their shapes the way she had learned the shapes of the rocks below the lighthouse—□ by day, treacherous by night, marked in her mind by the things they had taken.

The young one with the beard. The older man who stood at the bow. The two who clung to each other until the end, until the sea decided they had held on long enough. She knew them. She had watched them go. She had lit the signal fires and shouted to the mainland and done everything the rules said to do, and the rescue boat had come too late, and they had gone into the water one by one, and she had counted them as they vanished, and the number she had counted was eleven, and no one on the mainland had counted at all.

That was the part that still woke her.

Not the drowning. She had seen drowning before, in twenty-seven years of keeping the light. She had seen the sea take boats and men and boys who thought they knew what the water could do. She had seen the harbor empty and fill again and empty again, the same faces replaced by younger faces and then by older ones, the island always losing what it could not replace. She knew drowning. She knew what it looked like and what it sounded like and how long it took, and she had made her

peace with that knowledge the way keepers made their peace with all knowledge about the sea—with the understanding that peace was another word for exhaustion, and exhaustion was another word for giving up.

But the mainland had not counted.

The rescue boat had come too late, and the bodies had not come back, and the coast guard had filed a report that no one read, and the insurance adjusters had argued about liability, and somewhere in the capital a clerk had noted another wreck in the western waters, another eleven men lost, another tragedy for the files that no one opened. They had not come to the island. They had not asked what she had seen. They had sent condolences and moved on, and the eleven had become a number in a column, and the faces had faded from everything except her memory, where they stayed, where they would stay until she died.

Mara breathed in. The air smelled of smoke and brine and the rosemary she kept on the windowsill, for memory, the way her grandmother had kept it, the way her grandmother's grandmother had kept it, the way women on this island had kept it for generations, tending the herb that was also the word, the word that was also the wound.

She stood.

Her knees ached. Her hip had been wrong since the winter, a pain she had not shown to anyone, a pain that told her what she already knew: that her body was failing the way all bodies failed, slowly, then all at once, then slowly again. She was sixty-four. She had been the keeper for twenty-seven years and the ex-keeper for fifteen. She had climbed the tower four hundred and twelve times in her working life and she had not climbed it once since the company took over, and her legs knew the difference, and her hands knew the difference, and the part of her that still counted things knew the difference too.

She did not light the electric lamp. Instead she went to the shelf by the door where she kept the old oil lamp, the one from the keeper years, the brass one with the glass chimney that had lit her father's hands and her grandfather's hands and every hand that had wound the mech-

anism and checked the lens and kept the light burning through the storms that no one remembered except the people who had been in them. The lamp was there, dusty, waiting. She took it down. She found the matches in the drawer by the door, the same drawer where her father had kept matches, the same drawer where she had kept matches for thirty years, and she struck one, and the flame caught, and she touched it to the wick, and the light came on.

The cottage changed in the lamplight. The shadows pulled back. The shapes became specific: the table and the bottle, the chair and the door, the logbook on the shelf where she had tried to write the names and stopped. The fire's embers glowed but did not warm. The lamp was enough. The lamp was what she had used for thirty years, and it was what she used now, when the darkness came and the faces came and she needed to see something other than the shape of her own failure.

She sat back down in her chair. The lamp was on the table beside the bottle. In its light, the glass looked darker, the green deeper, the message inside more present. She did not open it. She knew what it said. The words were in her hand and in her head and in the part of her that counted things, and she could not unread them no matter how much she wished she could.

Instead she looked at the faces.

They came when she called them, which was always, which was the thing she did not tell anyone, the thing that would make them leave her alone if they knew, the thing that proved she was not the woman they thought she was—steady, silent, contained. She was not contained. She was full of them, the eleven, and she talked to them every night, and they answered in the only way the dead answered, which was by staying, which was by not leaving, which was by keeping her company in the dark the way the sea kept her company through the walls, the way the cold kept her company in the cottage she could not sell because no one wanted to buy a cottage on a rock in the North Atlantic with a woman who talked to dead men.

"I saw the message," she said.

The silence did not answer. It never did. But she felt them there, the way she felt the sea through the walls, the way she felt the weight of the lighthouse above her, sixty-two feet of stone that had stood when the keepers stood and would stand when the keepers were gone and the company sent its technicians and the tourists came to look at the view and the island forgot what the light had meant.

“I saw it and I knew.”

The faces shifted in her mind. She had learned, over the years, not to try to move them or arrange them. They came as they came, and she let them come, and she spoke to them, and they listened the way the dead listened, which was completely, which was without judgment, which was the only kind of listening she trusted anymore.

“There was a woman. I know her. I knew her when she was a girl, when she came down to the harbor with her father and watched the boats come in. She’s his daughter. Finlay’s daughter.”

The older man in the bow, the one with the gray at his temples. She had not known his name either. She had not asked. She had only watched.

“Eilidh. Her name is Eilidh. She left. She went to the mainland and she stayed there and she did not come back except for holidays and now she’s in a message and the message says she’s the only one who survives.”

A flicker in the lamp. The flame steadied.

“I don’t know what that means. I don’t know if it means she’ll live and everyone else will die or if it means she’ll be the last one in the water and the sea will take her too and I’ll have to watch it happen. I don’t know. I’ve never known. The readings don’t explain themselves.”

The young one with the beard. He had been the first to go. She remembered that, the way she remembered all of it, the sequence of vanishing, the order in which the sea had claimed them. She had counted. That was what keepers did. They counted things.

“But I know I can’t watch again.”

The words came out harder than she had expected. There was something in them, something that had not been there before, a sound that

was not her usual talking-to-ghosts voice but something older, something with edges.

“I can’t. I won’t.”

She looked at the bottle. The green glass held the message, and the message held the name, and the name held the weight of everything she had spent fifteen years trying to set down. She had carried it. She had carried the eleven. She had carried the fire and the signal and the rescue boat that came too late and the faces that would not leave her and the names she could not say. She had carried it all, alone, in the cottage by the lighthouse, and she had not put it down, and she had not given it away, and she had not told anyone that the weight was breaking her.

Now there was a name. Now there was a woman she knew, a girl she had watched grow up, a person who would drown unless something changed, and she was the only one who knew.

“I can’t watch,” she said again. “I won’t watch again.”

The dead did not answer. The lamp burned. The fire’s embers faded. Through the walls, the sea continued, patient, inevitable, the way it had always continued, taking what it claimed, keeping what it kept, waiting for the next storm, the next ship, the next set of faces that would come to her in the dark and ask her why she had not done more.

Mara had asked herself that question for fifteen years. She had no answer. She had only the weight and the silence and the faces that would not leave.

Now she had something else.

She had a name.

She stood again. She walked to the window. The glass was cold when she pressed her hand to it, and beyond it the dark was total, the kind of dark that existed only on islands far from cities, far from lights, far from anything that could drown out the stars or the sea or the sound the world made when no one was watching.

Eilidh Gunn was in Edinburgh. Mara had never been to Edinburgh. She had been to Glasgow once, for a keeper’s conference, and she had not liked it—the way the buildings closed in the sky, the way the streets

smelled of exhaust and people who did not know the sea. Edinburgh was different, she had been told. Edinburgh was old and stone and history, and Eilidh was somewhere in it, in a flat, in a life, in a future that the message had already seen.

The message said she was the only survivor.

Mara did not know what that meant. She did not know if it meant the woman would live or if it meant the woman would be the last one in the water when the others were gone, alone in the dark, waiting for a rescue that would not come. She did not know if the reading could be changed or if the sea could be fought or if there was anything in the old rituals that Agnes knew that could turn the tide.

She knew only that she would not watch.

The lighthouse stood on its promontory, visible from the cottage window, sixty-two feet of stone above the waterline. The light was burning—the company kept it burning, automated, efficient, indifferent to the keeper who had climbed it every night for twenty-seven years. Mara looked at it and felt nothing. That was another thing she had learned: how to look at the things she had loved and feel nothing, how to hollow herself out so the loss could not find a place to land.

But the faces found her. The faces always found her.

Eleven men. A storm. A signal fire lit too late, or perhaps not too late, perhaps exactly on time, perhaps the rescue boat would have been too late no matter what she did. She had told herself that for years. She had told herself that the fire was not her fault, that she had done everything right, that the system had failed and the system was not her, and she had almost believed it, almost talked herself into the kind of peace that was actually exhaustion, that was actually giving up.

But the faces would not let her believe it.

And now there was a new face. A woman's face. A girl she had known.

Eilidh in Edinburgh. Eilidh in the message. Eilidh in the water, unless.

Mara turned from the window. The lamp burned. The bottle

waited. The dead were silent.

She went to the table and sat down and looked at the bottle and the lamp and the space where the fire had been, and she thought about what she would do, and she knew she could not do it alone, and she knew she would have to tell someone, and she knew that telling meant believing, and believing meant acting, and acting meant—

She did not finish the thought.

She did not need to.

The sea was there. The faces were there. The name was there.

And she was here, in the cottage, in the lamplight, in the dark that would last until morning, and she would not watch again. She had said it, and she meant it, and she did not know if she had the power to keep it, but she would try, and trying was more than she had done in fifteen years, and trying was more than the eleven had gotten, and trying was what she owed them and what she owed herself and what she owed the girl whose name was in the bottle whose name was in her hand whose name was—

“Eilidh,” she said.

The word was quiet. It was not a prayer. It was not a promise. It was a name, spoken aloud for the first time since the message had written itself in her hand, and it was the beginning of something, though she did not know what, and it was the end of something, though she did not know that either.

She sat in her chair.

She waited for the night to end.

...

In the morning she would go to Finlay. She would tell him what she knew. She would watch his face change and his hands shake and his voice go hard with the kind of denial that was really fear, and she would let him deny it, because denial was what people did when the world showed them something they could not accept, and he would

accept it eventually, or he would not, and she would act anyway.

But that was morning. That was tomorrow. That was the thing she would do when the dark was done and the faces had faded and the lamp had burned out and she could stand and walk and speak without feeling like the words were coming from somewhere else, somewhere the reading had made, somewhere that was not her but was in her now, written into her the way the message was written into the glass.

For now, she sat.

The fire was cold. The cottage was quiet. The lamp burned.

And the sea went on doing what the sea always did, which was wait, which was take, which was keep what it claimed, and Mara went on doing what she had always done, which was watch, and this time—this time—she would not only watch.

She would act.

She would fail or she would not fail, and she did not know which it would be, but she would try, and trying was the thing, and trying was the only thing that mattered, and the night was long and the faces were there and the bottle was on the table and the lamp was burning and somewhere on the mainland a woman named Eilidh was waking in a flat in a city in a life in a future that the message had already seen.

Mara let the night hold her.

She did not sleep.

She waited.

CHAPTER 5

*The door of the Aul□ Inn opened against the wind,
and Mara stepped inside.*



THE room was half-full, which meant the League was meeting in the back. She could hear their voices through the wall—not arguing, not yet, but discussing with the particular intensity of men who had no power and knew it. Weather reports. Ferry schedules. The usual. She stood in the doorway and let the heat from the peat fire find her.

Finlay saw her before she reached the bar.

“Window’s open,” he said. Not a question. He was already moving, pulling a plate from beneath the counter, ladling soup.

“I didn’t order.”

“You don’t have to.”

She wanted to argue, but her body wanted the warmth more than her pride wanted the last word. She took the seat by the window where she could see the harbor, where she could watch the water even when she wasn’t looking at it. Finlay brought the soup himself, setting it down with a clatter that was too loud for the room. She looked up.

“You’re out past dark,” he said.

"I'm at dinner."

"Dinner's been over an hour."

She looked at the window. The light was going gray at the edges. November. It did that.

"Finlay."

"I'll leave you to it." He turned, then stopped. "There's bread. And cheese. The cheese's good."

"I'll manage."

He went back behind the bar. She picked up the spoon.

The soup was lamb. She didn't ask where the lamb came from—there would have been an answer involving someone she knew and a trip to the mainland, and she was not in the mood for stories tonight. She ate slowly. The bread was good. The cheese was better. She watched the harbor through glass that needed washing and thought about Finlay's face when he saw her. The surprise. The assessment. The way he had already decided she was all right, was still all right, before she had said a word.

He knew her body. Fifteen years of dinners at this window, and he knew whether she was hungry, whether she was tired, whether she was the kind of tired that wanted company and the kind that wanted to be left alone. Tonight she was both. Tonight she was something else entirely.

The door opened. Two more men came in from the back room, shaking rain from their jackets, talking about the weather service in the tone of men who had given up expecting it to improve. They nodded at Mara. She nodded back. They went to the bar. Finlay poured them beer without asking what they wanted.

This was the rhythm of the island. The men drank. The women cooked. The weather did what it wanted, and the ferry came when it could, and everyone complained about the mainland's indifference because complaining was easier than naming what it really was: the knowledge that the mainland did not know they existed, and did not care to learn.

Mara finished her soup. She pushed the plate toward the middle of the table, out of habit. Finlay would clear it when she left. He always did.

She should go. She had come for a reason, and she had eaten, and the reason was still sitting in her chest like a stone she could not swallow or spit out. Ask about Eilidh. That was all. Ask how she was. Ask when she was coming home. Ask the questions a neighbor would ask, without letting him see that she already knew the answer and that the answer was a weight she had not earned the right to carry.

But Finlay was walking toward her again with a second plate, and she had not asked him to bring it.

"The fish," he said.

"I didn't order the fish."

"You ate light last week. You need more."

"Finlay—"

"Eat."

He set the plate down. Cod, by the look of it. Fried in butter with potatoes and herbs she couldn't name. The smell was good. Her stomach reminded her that one bowl of soup was not enough, had not been enough for years, and she pushed the stone aside and picked up her fork.

Finlay did not leave. He stood there, hands in his apron, looking at her with an expression she could not read. Not quite worry. Not quite curiosity. Something else.

"You're different tonight," he said.

"I'm not."

"You are. You've got that look."

"What look."

"The one you had in '98. After the wreck."

She stopped chewing. She looked at him. He looked back. He did not flinch.

"I remember," she said.

"I know you do. Everyone does. That's not what I'm saying. I'm

saying you look like you did then. Like you're carrying something."

"I'm eating dinner."

"Mara."

"What."

He pulled out the chair across from her and sat. The wood scraped on the floor. The two men at the bar glanced over, then away. This was not unusual. Finlay sat where he wanted. The Inn was his.

"You want to tell me about the weather service," he said. "About the ferry schedule?"

"No."

"The mainland's neglect. The island dying. All the things the League talks about every week."

"No."

"Then what."

She set down her fork. The fish was cooling on her plate. The harbor was dark outside the window. Somewhere beyond the harbor, beyond the island, beyond the sea itself, a woman named Eilidh was living a life that Mara had seen written in a hand that was not her own.

"What would you do," she said, "if you knew something was going to happen. Something bad. Something you couldn't stop."

"Stop it."

"You can't stop it."

"Then I'd warn people."

"Even if they didn't believe you."

"Doesn't matter if they believe. You warn them anyway. That's what warning means."

She looked at him. This close, she could see the gray in his beard, the lines around his eyes, the particular kind of tired that came from years of managing other people's needs. He had been doing this since his wife died. Running the Inn. Running the League. Raising a daughter who had left and did not come home enough and did not call enough and did not write enough, and Finlay never complained about this to anyone, but everyone knew. Everyone knew because Finlay's face said

it every time someone mentioned Eilidh's name.

"You watch the sea all day," he said. "You see everything that comes in and everything that goes out. The boats. The weather. The wrecks that almost happen and the ones that don't. And what good does it do?"

She did not answer. The question was not rhetorical for her anymore.

"Mara. What good does it do?"

"It shows me what's there."

"And then what? You see a storm coming. You see a boat in trouble. What happens after you see?"

"I tell someone."

"And do they listen?"

She thought about 1998. The signal fires lit on the headland. The voices on the radio. The rescue boat that left too late, or was delayed too long, or arrived in time and could not find them—the details had blurred over the years, but the faces had not. Eleven men. She had watched them from the tower. She had seen the sea take them. She had done everything right, and they were still dead.

"No," she said. "They don't listen."

"Then what's the point."

"The point is I saw. The point is someone knew."

Finlay shook his head. "That's not enough. Knowing isn't enough."

"I know."

"It's not enough for them either. The ones who drown. They don't care that someone saw."

"I know."

"Then why do you keep watching?"

She looked at him for a long time. The fire crackled behind them. The men at the bar talked about nothing. The harbor was dark, and the sea was dark beyond it, and somewhere in that darkness was a future that had already been written.

"Because I don't know how to stop," she said.

Finlay nodded slowly. He was quiet for a moment. She watched him think—the slight frown, the way his hands moved on the table without purpose, the particular stillness of a man who was deciding whether to ask the next question.

Then she asked it first.

“How’s Eilidh?”

The change in his face was immediate. Hope, grief, fear—all three at once, passing over him like weather over open water. He did not hide it. He did not know how.

“She’s fine. Working. Busy.”

“When’s she coming home?”

“December. Christmas. Same as always.”

“Same as always,” Mara repeated.

“She has her life. She’s got things to do. I can’t expect her to—”

He stopped. His hands had gone still on the table.

“Why are you asking.”

“I’m asking a neighbor’s question.”

“You’re not a neighbor who asks questions.”

“Maybe I’m becoming one.”

“Since when.”

She looked at the window. The harbor was empty now. The boats were tied to their moorings, waiting for morning. The water was black and still and deep, and she thought about what it meant to be marked by the sea—not chosen, not blessed, but claimed in advance. Claimed and given a name and told that survival was possible, if someone acted, if someone broke the rules, if someone did what she had sworn she would never do again.

“She’s all right?” Mara said.

“She’s fine. She’s always been fine. She’s stronger than I was at her age.”

“Is she?”

Finlay looked at her. His eyes were wet, though he did not seem to know it.

“What do you know.”

“I know she’s your daughter. I know she left. I know she doesn’t come home enough and you miss her every day and you can’t say any of this because if you say it out loud it becomes real, and you’ve had enough become real.”

“She doesn’t want to hear it. She doesn’t want—”

“That’s not the same as not needing to hear it.”

Finlay stood. The chair scraped back. He looked down at her with an expression she could not name—not anger, not sorrow, something closer to the look of a man who had been seen when he did not want to be seen, who had been known when he did not want to be known.

“I’ve known you thirty years,” he said. “You’ve never asked about her. Not once. Not like this.”

“I know.”

“Why now?”

She could tell him. The words were right there, behind her teeth, ready to come out. Finlay, the message named her. Finlay, she’s going to drown unless someone stops it. Finlay, I saw her face in the writing and I know you know that face and I know what it will do to you and I need you to help me because I can’t do this alone.

“I saw something,” she said instead. “On the shore. This morning. I thought about what you said. About watching and what good it does.”

“What did you see?”

She shook her head. “I don’t know yet. I need to think.”

“You’re not telling me.”

“I’m not ready.”

“Mara—”

“Next time. I’ll tell you next time.”

He stood there a moment longer. She watched him decide whether to push, whether to demand, whether to use the authority of the room and the hour and the years they had known each other to drag the truth out of her. But Finlay was not that kind of man. He could be hard,

could be stubborn, could be the kind of angry that came from fear—but he was not cruel, and he did not take what was not given.

“December,” he said. “She’ll be here in December. You can ask her yourself then.”

“I’d like that.”

“I don’t know what you’d like.”

“Neither do I,” Mara said. “But I’d like that.”

Finlay looked at her for a long moment. Then he gathered her plates—the soup bowl, the fish plate, the bread plate he had brought without being asked—and he carried them back behind the bar. She watched him go. She watched his shoulders, the set of his back, the way he moved without looking at the two men who were watching him and pretending not to.

She had not told him. She had come here to tell him, and she had eaten his food, and she had listened to him complain about the weather and the mainland and the island dying, and she had let him see that she was carrying something, and she had not told him.

She did not know what she was waiting for.

She did not know what she needed him to understand.

But she would go back to the cottage tonight, and she would sit by the cold fire, and she would think about Finlay’s face when she asked about Eilidh—the hope that flickered there, the grief that lived beneath it, the fear he did not know how to name—and she would wonder what it would take. What it would cost. What it would mean to break the silence she had kept for fifteen years and reach across it and touch the thing that was coming for the people she knew.

The door opened again. A woman came in, dripping, shaking rain from her coat. She was young—too young to be here alone, or at least that was what Mara’s first instinct said, and then she recognized the posture, the way the woman stood in the doorway and took the room’s measure before committing to it. Born islander, home for a visit. Probably Muirhead kin. Probably here for the Society meeting that would happen tomorrow, or the week after, or whenever Catriona decided the

time was right.

Mara watched the woman cross to the bar. Watched Finlay pour her a drink without asking. Watched her accept it and turn to the room, scanning faces, assessing.

Their eyes met. The woman nodded. Mara nodded back.

The woman did not know her name. The woman did not know that Mara watched the sea, had always watched the sea, would keep watching even when there was nothing left to see. The woman did not know about the bottle or the message or the name that had been written in a hand she almost recognized.

Mara stood. She left coins on the table—too many, but Finlay would argue about it if she didn't, and she did not have the energy for that tonight. She pulled her coat from the hook by the door. She stepped outside.

The rain had stopped. The clouds had broken. The harbor was silver under a half-moon, and the water was still, and the boats rocked gently at their moorings, and somewhere beyond the island, beyond the sea, a woman named Eilidh was dreaming about boats that shouldn't float.

Mara walked home.

She did not look back.

CHAPTER 6

*The cottage held the cold the way a box holds water.
Once it was in, it did not know how to leave.*



MARA stood in the doorway and did not step inside. She had walked the two miles from the harbor without feeling her feet on the road. The moon was high now, the clouds gone, and the world outside was silver and shadow and the particular stillness that follows rain. Inside, she knew, the fire had gone to ash. She had banked it that morning before she left—the same ritual she had performed every morning for fifteen years, bank the fire, check the tide, walk the shore and count what she could count. She had not expected to come home with a message that could not be unread.

She stepped inside.

The room was dark. She did not reach for the lamp. She crossed to the cold hearth and knelt and put her hands in the ash and the cold climbed up her fingers and into her palms and she let it. Her hands remembered this. Her body remembered what it was to kneel here, in this room, in the quiet, and tend the fire that was the only warmth she had made for herself in fifteen years.

The bottle was in her coat pocket. She had not let go of it since Finlay poured her out the door.

She reached into her pocket and took it out.

The glass was dark in the low light. She could see the edge of the paper inside, the corner of it, curled against the curve of the glass. A message. A name. A date three weeks from now.

She set the bottle on the table beside the cold hearth and sat in the chair she had sat in every night since she moved in here and she looked at it. The bottle did not look back. The bottle did not do anything. The message inside did not change.

She had known it would not.

...

The rules said: once read, it cannot be unread.

She had read it. She had read it on the shore, kneeling in the gravel, the tide still dripping from her boots. She had read it before she knew what she was reading, the words forming in her hand as if her hand remembered how to write them and had been waiting for the chance. She had seen the name. She had seen the date. She had seen the words that named what was coming, and now she knew, and knowing was a thing that did not undo itself.

She had thought—she had not let herself think it, but the thought had been there, the way the tide is there even when you are not watching it—she had thought maybe if she destroyed the bottle, if she broke the glass and let the paper fall and let the sea take the message back, she would not have to know anymore. The rules said the message could not be unread. They did not say the glass could not be broken.

But she knew. She had always known.

The glass was the delivery system. The message was already in her. The words had already gone from her hand into her mind and from her mind they did not go. She could break the bottle against the stones outside and it would mean nothing. The glass held the message but

the cottage held the cold the way a box holds water. once it was in, it did not know how to leave.

it did not hold the knowing. She held the knowing. She held it in the place where she kept the faces of the eleven, the place where she kept the sound of the signal fires she had lit and the sound of the rescue boat that came too late, the place where she kept everything she could not unsee.

The bottle was a thing. The knowing was hers.

She looked at the glass on the table. She did not break it.

...

The fire was ash. She should light it. The room was cold enough to see her breath if she looked at it sideways, the way the air moved when she breathed out, the way the cold made the world visible. She should light the fire. She did not light the fire.

She thought about what she could do.

Destroy the bottle. She had already decided this did nothing. The knowing would remain. The message would still be true. The name would still be the name.

Tell Finlay. Tell him what she had seen. Tell him what was coming. Finlay, who kept the Inn and kept the League and kept trying to make the island survive by making it practical, Finlay who did not believe in readings because belief would mean his life was already determined and Finlay could not live inside a life that was determined, Finlay who would say she was daft or sad or both, Finlay who would not listen until the listening did not matter anymore.

Tell Eilidh. Call her on the phone in the morning, the phone that sat on the shelf by the door where she had put it because she had never needed it, call and tell her what the message said, tell her to stay away, tell her not to come home, tell her what was waiting if she came home. Eilidh, who had left the island and stayed away and built a life that was not here, Eilidh who would not believe, who would think her father had put Mara up to it or who would think Mara was mad, Eilidh who would hang up and not come home out of spite if nothing else.

Do nothing. Set the bottle aside. Live the next three weeks the way

she had lived the last fifteen. Walk the shore. Count the boats. Watch the sea. Let what was coming come.

This was the option she had chosen.

She had chosen it every year since 1998.

She sat in the chair and the cold sat with her and she thought: I cannot unknow the name. The name was Eilidh. The name was in her hand and in her mind and it would not leave. Eilidh. Finlay's daughter. The woman who came home for holidays she treated like obligations. The woman who had left because she could not stay and stayed away because she could not leave.

The name was a person. The person was going to drown.

Unless.

...

Unless was the word she could not say out loud.

Unless was the thing she had spent fifteen years learning not to think.

In 1998, she had done everything right. She had climbed the tower when the storm came in. She had lit the signal fires. She had seen the freighter in trouble two miles out, lights still burning, running lights still showing the shape of her against the black of the sea and the blacker of the night. She had signaled. She had watched the mainland rescue boat leave the harbor. She had tracked it on the radar screen that was the only modern thing in the tower, the green line sweeping around and around and showing her where the boat was and where the freighter was and the space between them that was shrinking, then not shrinking, then growing.

The rescue boat had sunk.

She did not know why. The official report said a wave, a rogue wave that no one had predicted, a wall of water that hit the boat broadside and drove it under before anyone could move. The boat was gone. The freighter was gone. Eleven men were gone. She had lit the fires. She had

done everything right. The eleven were still dead.

She had watched. She had acted. She had done what the light was for.

The sea had taken them anyway.

She had learned the lesson the sea was teaching. She had learned it in the months after, in the gray mornings and the gray evenings and the nights that were not gray but were the color of the space between stars. She had learned that watching was all she could do. That the sea did not care about the light. That the light existed because the light was supposed to exist and the sea took what it took and the light could not stop it, had never been able to stop it, was never meant to stop it, only meant to mark the place where the taking happened.

She had learned this. She had learned it so well she had become it.

She sat in the cold cottage and she thought about the eleven and the lesson and the light and the three weeks and the name that would not leave her, and she felt the thing she had learned begin to crack.

...

Ships that should have rescued them sink.

The words were in the message. She had read them. She had read them and they had passed through her like the tide passes through a seawall, like the cold passes through stone.

Ships that should have rescued them sink. Ropes that should have held break. The sea does not forget what it has claimed.

She knew what this meant. She had always known what this meant, even before she found the bottle, even before the words formed in her hand and gave her the name. The survivor clause. That was what the scholars called it, in the Registry, in the records they kept in the capital and updated every year and sent out to the islands when they remembered. The survivor clause.

When a reading names a specific person as the only survivor, that person is marked. The sea has already decided. The rescue will not

come. The rope will break. The ship will sink.

If Finlay tried to save his daughter, he would fail. If he sent a boat, it would sink. If he did everything right—

She stopped the thought.

She had done everything right in 1998.

...

She thought about Eilidh.

She thought about the girl who had followed her to the shore when she was small, when the weekenders were here and Eilidh was home from school, when she had nowhere to be and no one to answer to and she would find Mara walking the rocks and she would walk beside her and ask questions Mara did not know how to answer. Why does the light turn? How high can the waves get? Do you ever get lonely up here?

Mara had not answered. She had walked and Eilidh had walked beside her and the questions had hung in the air like the gulls hung in the air, going nowhere, going everywhere, the questions not needing answers because the questions were just the shape of someone trying to understand a place that did not want to be understood.

The girl had grown. The woman had left.

Mara had watched her go. She had stood at the harbor the day Eilidh left for university, the same harbor where she had stood today, and she had watched the ferry pull away with the woman who had asked her about loneliness and loneliness was not the word for what Mara was, loneliness was the word for people who missed other people, and Mara did not miss anyone because she had learned not to miss, had learned to let the faces come and go like the tide, like the light, like the ships that came and went and sometimes did not come back.

Eilidh had not looked back.

Mara had not expected her to.

...

She stood up.

She crossed to the cold hearth and knelt in front of it and lifted the iron grate and set the ash aside and found the kindling she kept there, in the old way, in the way her grandmother had shown her, kindling first, then peat, then the coal that sat in the bucket by the door. She lit the match. She held it to the kindling and the kindling caught and she sat back on her heels and watched the small fire grow.

The room filled with light. The room filled with warmth. The room filled with the smell of smoke and the memory of smoke, the smell of every fire she had ever lit in this room or the room above or the room in the tower that held the light, the smell of heat and ash and the oil that kept the mechanism running, the smell of a life that had been made of keeping light in the dark.

She watched the fire grow.

She thought: three weeks.

She thought: ships that should have rescued them sink.

She thought: I cannot unknow the name.

She thought: the eleven are still dead.

She thought: Finlay will try.

She thought: I have spent fifteen years learning not to act.

She thought: I am going to have to unlearn everything.

...

She sat by the fire and she did not sleep.

The night passed the way nights pass when you are waiting for something that is not going to come. The fire burned down. She did not bank it. The room went dark again. The first light came through the window, gray light, the light that was neither night nor day, the light that was the edge of the world.

She had not made a decision. She did not know how to make a decision. The decision was the thing she had spent fifteen years learning to stop making, the decision was the thing she had built a life around

not having to make, the decision was—

The decision was whether to tell someone.

That was all it was. That was all it could be. She could not stop the shipwreck. She could not save Eilidh from the sea. She could not control what the sea did with what it had claimed. She could only decide whether to say the words out loud, in a room, to a person who might listen or might not, might believe or might not, might try or might not.

She could tell Finlay. She could tell him the name and the date and the clause about the ships that should have rescued them. She could watch him not believe. She could watch him try anyway.

She could tell Eilidh. She could call the number she did not have and find the number she did not want to find and make the call she did not want to make. She could tell the woman who had left and stayed away and dreamed about boats that shouldn't float. She could warn her. She could not make her listen.

She could do nothing. She could let the three weeks pass. She could watch the sea do what the sea did. She could keep the light, such as it was, burning in her own chest, where no one could see it, where it would go out when she went out, and that would be the end of it. That would be the lesson she had learned. That would be the lesson she had not unlearned.

The gray light grew. The room showed its shapes again: the table, the chair, the hearth, the bottle on the table with the message that would not change.

She looked at the bottle.

She thought: I do not know if I believe this will come true.

Then she thought: that is not the question.

The question was not whether she believed.

The question was what she would do with the knowing.

She had not known in 1998. She had lit the fires and she had watched and she had done everything right and the eleven had still died because the rescue boat had sunk, because the sea had claimed them, because the sea did not care about the light or the keeper or the keeper's want-

ing the world to be different than it was. She had not known what was coming. She had not been able to stop it.

She knew now.

The knowing was not a gift. The knowing was not a curse. The knowing was just a thing she had, like the cold in her bones, like the smell of smoke in her hair, like the faces of the eleven that would not leave her alone at night.

She knew. And she was the only one who knew.

And she was going to have to decide what to do with that.

...

She stood.

She went to the window.

The harbor was visible from here, if she looked through the gap between the cottage and the shed, if she stood on her toes and angled her body just so. She could see the water, the moored boats, the shape of the world she had lived in for sixty-four years. The sky was lightening. The color was coming back to the world. The day was coming.

She had three weeks.

She turned from the window. She crossed the room. She picked up the bottle and held it in her hand. The glass was cold. The paper inside was cold. The message would not change.

She thought about Finlay. She thought about Eilidh. She thought about Agnes, who led the Daughters, who knew the old rituals, who had received a reading herself and never spoken of it. She thought about what it might cost to ask.

She did not know yet. She did not know what she would do. She did not know if she would call or walk or sit still or speak or be silent.

But she knew she could not do nothing.

This was the thing she had not known when she sat down. This was the thing the night had given her. She could not unknow the name, and she could not unknow what the name meant, and she could not un-

know that she was the only one who knew, and she could not unknow that the knowing was a weight she would have to carry or set down, and setting it down would not make it lighter, setting it down would only mean she was not carrying it when it mattered.

She set the bottle on the table.

She lit the fire.

She sat in the chair and she watched the light grow, and she began to plan.

. . .

The question the chapter ended on was not whether she believed the reading would come true.

The question was whether she believed she could do anything about it.

The fire burned. The day began. Somewhere beyond the island, beyond the sea, Eilidh Gunn slept in a flat in Edinburgh and dreamed about boats that shouldn't float, and she did not know that Mara Callaghan was sitting in a cold cottage with a message that could not be unread, and she did not know that she had three weeks, and she did not know that her father would try to save her and fail, and she did not know that the sea was waiting.

Mara sat by the fire.

She began.

CHAPTER 7

The Daughters



THE vestry smelled of cold stone and dried seaweed. Mara had forgotten that. She had not come to the Sunday gatherings in years—not since she stopped keeping the light, maybe not before that—and the smell was a door she had not meant to open. She stood in the doorway and let it open anyway.

The room was small, the walls two feet of granite dressed in white-wash that had gone grey in patches. A table ran the length of one side, covered in cups and a plate of oat cakes someone had brought. The chairs were mismatched, borrowed from the school when the school had chairs to lend. Five women were already there when she came in. She knew their faces. She knew their names. She had delivered three of their children and held two of their husbands while the breathing stopped. They looked up when she entered and the look was the same look the island gave everything that came back from the dead: acknowledgment, caution, a willingness to let the matter rest.

“Mara.” This from Biddy Sinclair, who was seventy-three and had outlived everyone she’d expected to outlive. “Sit. There’s tea.”

Mara sat. She took a cup she did not drink from. She folded her

hands around it because her hands did not know what else to do when they were not holding something useful.

The conversation moved around her the way water moves around a stone. Biddy was talking about her nephew in Glasgow, who had a boy now, who was walking already at ten months, who would be brought to the island for the summer if God was good. Meg Forsyth was saying the herring were late this year, later than anyone could remember, and was that the reading making itself known early or was it just the currents. Catriona Maclean, who was not the Muirhead Catriona but was related somehow and carried herself like it mattered, said the currents were always the currents and the reading was always the reading and the two had nothing to do with each other.

No one asked Mara why she had come. This was either kindness or strategy. She had not decided which.

The Daughters of the Deep met every Sunday because someone had to remember the old things. The blessing of boats was the most visible—the sea-wort hung in every wheelhouse on the island, the salt placed in the bow of every new launch. But there was more than that. There was the naming of wrecks, the words spoken over the water when a body came back or when it didn't. There was the burial of things the sea gave back, the rituals for objects that should not float and did anyway, the observances for the spaces between what the island was and what the sea wanted it to be. The Daughters kept these things. They were not a religious group, not exactly. They were women who had decided that someone should do this work, and they had not yet found a reason to stop.

Mara had been one of them, once. She had sat in this room and spoken the words and believed that the words mattered. She had stopped believing somewhere around 1998, the same place she had stopped believing in most things. But she remembered.

She remembered enough.

The meeting ran its usual course. News was exchanged. Complaints were aired about the ferry schedule, the weather, the price of diesel.

Catriona Maclean brought a small jar of salt from the old mines and said it was better for blessing than the stuff you bought in bags, and everyone agreed even though half of them used the bagged salt and always had. Meg Forsyth asked after Biddy's nephew's boy again, and Biddy showed a photograph on her phone, and everyone said the right things about his eyes, his smile, his father's stubborn chin.

An hour passed. Maybe more. The light through the small windows moved from grey to darker grey as clouds crossed the sun outside. The tea cooled in cups that were not emptied and refilled. Mara listened. She did not speak. She watched the door.

When the gathering ended, the women rose and gathered their things and spoke the quiet words they always spoke—*the sea keeps what it claims*—before they left. Biddy was the last to go. She paused at the door and looked back at Mara and said nothing. She had that much wisdom, or that much old habit. She closed the door behind her and Mara was alone in the vestry with the smell of seaweed and cold stone.

Agnes had not left.

She was sitting at the far end of the table, hands folded, her cup still half full of tea that would be cold now. She had not spoken during the meeting, not more than a word or two. She had listened the way she always listened—present, attentive, her eyes on whoever was speaking without ever appearing to watch. She was not a large woman. She was not a loud one. But there was a weight to her stillness that made the room feel smaller when she was in it.

Mara had come to speak to Agnes because Agnes knew things no one else knew. Because Agnes led the Daughters, and kept the rituals, and had received a reading herself and never spoken of it. Not once, in forty years, had anyone on the island heard Agnes mention it. But Mara knew. She had known for thirty years, since the morning she had climbed the tower and looked down at the harbor and seen the boat coming in with a box on its deck, and recognized the box, and understood what it meant.

She had not asked Agnes about it then. She had not asked anyone.

She had climbed down from the tower and gone to her cottage and sat in the dark until the dark became morning. She had been a keeper then, and keepers did not speak of such things. They watched. They recorded. They kept the light burning for whatever came next.

She was not a keeper now.

“Agnes.”

“Mara.”

“I need to speak to you. Privately.”

Agnes looked at her for a long moment. There was no surprise in her face. There was no expression at all, not until the end, when something moved behind her eyes that Mara could not name.

“The others will be gone by now,” Agnes said. “Unless you want me to ask them back.”

“No. This is for you alone.”

Agnes nodded. She did not ask Mara to sit, because Mara was already sitting. She did not pour fresh tea, because the tea was cold and neither of them wanted it. She simply waited, her hands still folded, her weight still settled in her chair, the way a woman waits when she knows the words are coming and knows they will not be stopped.

Mara told her about the bottle. About the message that had written itself in her hand. About the words that named Eilidh Gunn and promised a shipwreck and left her standing in her kitchen at four in the morning with a glass container she should have thrown into the sea.

She did not explain what she intended to do. She did not ask for help, not yet. She simply told the facts as facts, the way she had learned to tell them during thirty years of recording weather and tide and the movements of boats she could not stop. The message was real. The reading was real. The name was Eilidh Gunn, and she had three weeks.

Agnes listened without expression.

This was the thing Mara had not understood when she was younger: the weight of hearing something and not showing that you have heard it. The discipline required to hold a thing inside your body and let it move through you without moving your face. Agnes had learned this,

or she had always had it. Either way, her stillness now was complete. She did not nod. She did not frown. She did not look away or look too long. She simply received the words as they came and let them come.

When Mara finished, the silence that followed was not empty. It was full the way water is full when it has nowhere to go.

“I know what they cost.”

Agnes said this quietly. The words were not loud but they filled the room the way a bell fills a space—not with volume, but with resonance. Mara heard them and felt the cold from the stone walls move into her chest.

“I know what the readings cost,” Agnes said again. “I have known for fifty years.”

She did not elaborate. She did not need to. The words were a door she was opening, and she would open it at her own pace, or not at all.

“1973.” Agnes said the year like she was naming a wound. “I was seventeen. My brother was twenty. His name was Calum.”

She stopped. She looked at her hands, which were still folded, which had not moved.

“Calum was the best swimmer on the island. He could hold his breath longer than anyone. He could read the water the way some people read books. He was going to be a fisherman all his life, and he was already better than the men twice his age.”

Mara said nothing. She had learned, over thirty years, that some silences were more honest than words.

“There was a bottle,” Agnes said. “On the rocks below the old schoolhouse. I found it in the morning, before anyone else was awake. I opened it and the message was there, in my hand, written in my hand, but the words were not my words.”

She looked up. Her eyes were dry. Her voice was steady.

“It said he would survive a wreck. It said he would be the only one. It said the sea had already claimed him and was waiting to take him home.”

The room was very quiet. The light had gone fully grey now, the

clouds having won their argument with whatever sun had tried to break through. Mara could hear her own breathing and the faint sound of the sea against the harbor walls a hundred yards away.

"I told him," Agnes said. "The moment I knew. I went to him and I told him what the message said and I begged him to stay on the island. To not go to sea that winter. To wait, at least, until the spring."

"And he didn't."

"No."

Agnes unfolded her hands. She pressed her palms flat against the table, the way a woman does when she needs to feel something solid beneath her.

"He was twenty years old. He was the best swimmer on the island. He thought he knew what the sea could do, because he had spent his whole life swimming in it. He thought the reading was a warning he could heed—that if he was careful, if he was good, the wreck would come and he would survive it and it would prove that the sea was not something to fear."

"But that's not what the readings mean."

"No." Agnes's voice was quiet. "The readings don't mean what we want them to mean. They mean what they mean. The sea has already claimed who it has claimed. The wreck happens because the wreck happens. The survivor survives because the survivor survives. The reading doesn't change any of that. It just lets us know, before, so that the knowing is its own punishment."

"What happened to him?"

"He went to sea in November. He came back in January, in a box. The wreck was three miles off the mainland coast. He was the only one who made it to the rocks, and he held on for six hours, and the boat that should have picked him up took on water and sank, and by the time another boat came he was gone."

She stopped. The room was very still.

"He held on for six hours," Agnes said again. "The reading named him as the survivor. He survived the wreck. He survived the water."

He survived six hours on those rocks in January. And then he died of exposure because by the time anyone could reach him, it was too late.”

Mara felt the words land in her chest like stones dropped into deep water. She felt them sink.

“I tried to warn him,” Agnes said. “I tried to stop him. I told everyone who would listen and some who wouldn’t. I went to his captain and I went to the harbor master and I went to my father, and they all said the same thing: the readings come true, but they can’t be stopped. Calum would survive, they said, because the reading said so. They told me not to worry.”

“And he did survive. For a while.”

“Yes.” Agnes folded her hands again. “He survived for a while. And then he didn’t. And I have never told anyone what the reading said, because what would be the point? I told him, and it didn’t save him. I told the others, and they didn’t believe me until it was too late, and then they believed me too much and blamed themselves for not listening sooner. The reading doesn’t give you a way out. It just gives you a name, and a date, and a weight you have to carry.”

She looked at Mara directly now.

“You came here because you want to save the girl. Eilidh Gunn. Finlay’s daughter.”

“Yes.”

“You want to know if there’s something you can do. Something the rituals can do. Something the old observances can change.”

“Yes.”

Agnes was quiet for a long time. The grey light moved across the walls. Somewhere outside, a gull called and was answered by another.

“I learned the rituals when I was young,” Agnes said. “I learned them because someone had to, because the island needed people who remembered. I have performed the blessing of boats for forty years. I have named the wrecks and buried the things the sea gave back. I have done everything the old observances require, exactly as they were written, exactly as they have always been done.”

“Have they worked?”

“They have done what they were meant to do.” Agnes’s voice was careful. “The rituals don’t stop the sea from taking what it has claimed. They never have. What they do is acknowledge. They let the living say what needs to be said. They let the dead be named instead of forgotten. They give us something to do while we wait for the inevitable, and they give us a way to carry what comes after.”

“But people have tried to change things. To intervene.”

“Yes.” Agnes looked at her hands again. “There was a woman, before my time. 1941. She received a reading that named her son. She went to the harbor and she poured salt into the water and she spoke the words of unbinding, the old words that were supposed to release what the sea had claimed.”

“Did it work?”

“Her son went to sea anyway. The wreck happened. He survived.”

“See,” Mara said. “There are things that—”

“Her son survived the wreck,” Agnes said. “He made it to shore. He walked home. And then, three days later, he walked into the sea behind his mother’s cottage and did not come back.”

Mara felt the cold again, the deep cold that had nothing to do with the stone walls.

“The reading names the survivor,” Agnes said. “The survivor survives the wreck. But the sea has claimed who it has claimed. The rituals can change the terms. They can pay a different price. But they cannot undo what was already written.”

“What price?”

“That depends on what you’re willing to give.”

Agnes stood. She moved to the small window and looked out at the grey sky and the grey water beyond the harbor.

“The woman in 1941—the unbinding cost her something. I don’t know what, exactly. The records are old, and people don’t write down what they lose. But her husband died that winter, and her other children left the island, and by the time she was gone the Muirheads had

bought her land and there was nothing left of her name except a story the Daughters tell when someone asks about the unbinding.”

“And no one has tried it since?”

“People have tried. They don’t talk about it afterward. The ones who survive the attempt are the ones who are still alive, and they usually wish they weren’t.”

Mara stood. Her legs were stiff from sitting, from the cold, from the weight of what she was hearing.

“Show me,” she said.

Agnes turned. There was something in her face now, something Mara had not seen before. It was not hope. It was not pity. It was the look of a woman who had carried a stone for fifty years and was only now considering whether she was strong enough to set it down.

“You want to see what intervention looks like.”

“Yes.”

“It will not be what you expect.”

“I know.”

“No.” Agnes shook her head slowly. “You don’t. You think you know, because you’ve read the message and you know what’s coming. But you don’t know what intervention costs. You don’t know what it takes from you. You don’t know whether the price is worth paying for someone else’s life.”

“Is that a question?”

“No.” Agnes moved back to the table. She sat down again, her hands folding, her weight settling. “It’s a warning. I’ve given my warning. What you do with it is your choice.”

“Show me anyway.”

Agnes looked at her for a long moment. The silence stretched between them like a rope pulled tight.

“There’s a cove,” she said. “On the east side. Ellen’s Cove. The water there is still. The sea doesn’t fight there—it waits. That’s where we do the observances. That’s where we go when we need to speak to the sea on its own terms.”

"I know the cove."

"I know you do. You've been avoiding it for thirty years."

Mara did not answer. She did not need to.

"Tonight," Agnes said. "After dark. Come alone. Wear what you can move in."

"And then?"

"And then I'll show you what I know. Whether it's what you need—" Agnes shrugged, a small movement, almost invisible. "That's something you'll have to decide for yourself."

The light had not changed. The grey was the same grey it had been since she walked in. But something had shifted in the room, some weight had moved from one place to another, and Mara felt it in her chest like a tide going out.

"Why are you helping me?"

"Because you came. Because you're the first person in fifty years who came to me with a reading instead of running from it. Because Calum would have wanted me to try."

She stopped.

"Because I failed him," she said. "I told him the reading and I begged him to stay and I did not do the unbinding because I was seventeen and I was afraid and I thought there would be time. I thought if I waited, if I was patient, the reading would change on its own. I was a coward, and he died, and I have spent fifty years wondering what would have happened if I'd been braver."

She looked at Mara directly.

"You came to me for help. I cannot give you what you want. I cannot promise that anything will save the girl, or that the rituals will do what you hope, or that the sea will listen to anything we say. What I can tell you is what I know. What I can show you is what I learned. What I can do is stand with you in the cove and speak the words that have to be spoken, if you decide that's what you want."

"And if I decide I want more than that?"

"Then you'll have to pay more than that." Agnes's voice was quiet.

"The sea always takes something. That's the one thing I know for certain. It takes what it takes, and it keeps what it keeps, and no ritual and no reading and no amount of wanting changes that. The only question is what you're willing to give."

She stood again. She moved toward the door, her steps quiet on the stone floor.

"Tonight," she said. "After dark. Ellen's Cove."

She paused at the threshold. She did not turn around.

"The boat comes in at six," she said. "The one that shouldn't float. The one with her name on it. I've seen it in my dreams for three months. I didn't know what it meant until you walked through that door."

She opened the door. The grey light flooded in, and the sound of the harbor, and the smell of salt and diesel and the sea that never stopped.

"I know what they cost," she said again, and then she was gone, and Mara was alone in the vestry with the smell of seaweed and cold stone and the weight of fifty years.

She sat for a long time. The light did not change. The tea in her cup did not warm. Somewhere beyond the walls, the sea moved against the harbor and the boats rocked at their moorings and the world continued in the way it always did, indifferent to what was coming, indifferent to what might be done.

She thought about Eilidh Gunn, thirty-two years old, asleep in Edinburgh, dreaming about boats that shouldn't float. She thought about Finlay, who would not believe until it was too late and then would believe too much. She thought about her own hands, which had held the bottle and written the message and could not unknow what they knew.

She thought about Calum, who survived six hours on the rocks and died anyway. She thought about the woman in 1941, who unbound her son from the sea and lost everything else. She thought about Agnes, who had carried the stone for fifty years and was still carrying it, still standing, still willing to show someone else the shape of the weight.

She thought about the cove. The still water. The words that had

to be spoken.

She stood. Her legs were stiff. Her hands were cold. The room was the same room it had always been, the stone walls and the mismatched chairs and the table with its cups and plate of oat cakes no one had eaten.

She walked to the door. She opened it. The grey light was waiting. Three weeks.

She had three weeks, and a cove, and a woman who knew the rituals, and a reading that could not be unread.

She walked out into the grey afternoon and she began.

. . .

Three hours until dark. Three hours to decide whether she would go.

She did not know yet. She did not know what the rituals could do or what they cost. She did not know whether Agnes would show her what she needed or only what Agnes was willing to give.

But she knew she could not do nothing. That much the night had given her. That much she had learned in the morning when she sat by the cold fire and felt the weight settle into her chest.

She could not unknow the name. She could not unknow what the name meant.

She walked toward the harbor and she thought about boats that shouldn't float, and she did not stop.

CHAPTER 8

The light from the keeper's cottage was a pale smear behind her when she reached the path that led down to Ellen's Cove. The afternoon had thinned into evening, and the sky was the color of wet slate, and the wind came off the water with the patience it always had at this hour—not cold yet, but not warm either, the kind of air that asked what you were doing out here and did not expect an answer.



AGNES was waiting at the fork where the path split, one branch going to the harbor and one going to the rocks. She was dressed for walking, her coat buttoned to the throat, a cloth bag over her shoulder that held the things she would need. She did not ask if Mara was ready. She turned and began the descent.

The path to Ellen's Cove was narrow and steep, cut into the hillside by feet that had worn it smooth over generations. Mara knew every stone of it—had walked it in the dark, in the rain, in the light that came off the water when the sun dropped below the horizon and the

sea turned the color of copper before it went black. She knew the place where the roots of an elder tree had cracked the stone, and the place where the path turned sharp around a boulder that had come down in some storm no one remembered, and the place where you had to step over a gap that was wider than it looked. She had walked this path as a girl, and as a woman who had kept the light, and as a woman who kept nothing now but the weight of what she knew.

Agnes walked ahead, her pace unhurried. She did not look back.

The cove opened below them like a wound in the rock—not a dramatic opening, not a classic inlet with a beach and a cliff, but a shallow curve in the granite where the land had simply given way to the water over centuries. The water here was not deep. Waist-high thirty feet out, according to the fishermen who had measured it and then stopped coming here. The floor was sand and stone, clean and pale, and the light that came through it at certain angles made the bottom look closer than it was.

Mara had not been to Ellen's Cove in eleven years. The last time she had walked this path, it had been to stand at the water's edge and watch the tide come in while she decided whether to go back to the cottage or walk into the water. She had chosen the cottage. That time.

The evening light was flat and even, the kind that made everything look the same distance away. The air here was different from the air on the other side of the hill—still, somehow, even when the wind was up everywhere else. The sea did not fight here. It waited.

"That was Ellen's spot," Agnes said, nodding toward a flat stone at the water's edge, half-submerged at high tide. "She used to sit there and watch for her father's ship coming in from the north."

"I know."

"You were young."

"Young enough."

Agnes did not push it. She walked to the edge of the water and set down her bag and began to unpack it. Salt in a cloth wrap, tied with twine. A small brazier, iron, the kind that fishermen used to warm their

the light from the keeper's cottage was a pale smear behind her when she reached the path that led down to ellen's cove. the afternoon had thinned into evening, and the sky was the color of wet slate, and the wind came off the hands were cold mornings. Charcoal. A box of matches. A piece of cloth warm either, the kind of air that asked what you were doing out here and did that looked old, stained in patches that might have been rust or might not expect an answer.

Mara stood a few feet back and watched.

"The blessing of boats," Agnes said. "It is not what people think."

"What do they think?"

"That it protects them." Agnes struck a match, set the charcoal in the brazier, cupped her hand around the flame until it caught. "The blessing asks the sea to remember the boat. To know it. To treat it as something that belongs here, not something that wandered in from somewhere else."

"Does it work?"

"It works the way all the old ways work." Agnes poured salt into her palm, held it out over the water. The words she spoke were in Gaelic—not the tourist Gaelic you heard on the radio, but the older kind, the kind that came from the throat and the chest and made the sounds that English could not hold. The salt fell into the water and dissolved and the sea did not change, but the air seemed to thicken, just for a moment, like the world was listening.

Mara felt her breath catch.

"The blessing does not stop the storm," Agnes said. "The storm will come whether the boat is blessed or not. But the blessed boat is known. The sea knows it. And sometimes—" She stopped. Reached for another handful of salt. "Sometimes knowing is enough."

"Enough for what?"

"For the fishermen to feel they have a chance. For the widows to sleep the night before their men go out. For the men to go out without feeling like they are asking the sea to take them." She turned to face Mara. "The rituals are not for the sea. They are for us."

Mara did not answer. She was looking at the water, which held no reflection of the sky, which was just dark now with the last of the light going out of it.

"The naming of wrecks," Agnes said. "Come here."

She led Mara to the far edge of the cove, where the rocks rose up and the water was shallow enough to stand in. The stones here were dark, covered in seaweed that came up black and heavy, and some of them had names carved into them—dates, mostly, and sometimes initials, and once in a while a word that Mara could not read from this distance.

Agnes waded in until the water was at her knees. She stopped at a stone that was larger than the others, smooth from centuries of tide, and she placed her hand on it as if she were greeting someone she had known a long time.

“This is the Harbinger,” she said. “1849. Thirty-two men. The rope that held the anchor gave way in a storm and the boat turned over before anyone knew what was happening. They were all below deck. No one saw it happen.”

“How do you know?”

“The ferryman who found them counted the bodies.” Agnes ran her fingers along the carved letters. H.A.R.B.I.N.G.E.R. “His grandson was a fisherman here for forty years. His great-grandson still runs the supply boat from the mainland.”

Mara stood on the shore and felt the damp of the air on her skin and watched Agnes perform the ritual that had no ritual to it—just the words and the touch and the names spoken so the dead could be heard, so they could rest, so the sea would know that someone still remembered what it had taken.

The naming was not magic. Mara understood that now. The dead did not rise because someone spoke their names. The sea did not give back what it had claimed because someone said the right words in the right order. But the naming mattered. The naming was how the living carried the weight of what had happened. The naming was how they put it down, just for a moment, just long enough to breathe.

“Does it help?” Mara asked.

“Help what?”

“The dead. The families. You.”

the light from the keeper's cottage was a pale smear behind her when she reached the path that led down to ellen's cove. the afternoon had thinned into evening, and the sky was the color of wet slate, and the wind came off the water, and the sea was the color of the sky, and the water was the color of the sea. Agnes stepped out of the water, her boots squelching on the stones. She did not wipe her legs. The seaweed stain would come out. Or it wouldn't.

"It helps the way a prayer helps," she said. "Which is to say, it does not change what happened. It changes what happens next."

Mara wanted to argue. She wanted to say that she had seen what happened next, and the prayers had not stopped it, and the rituals had not saved anyone, and the whole apparatus of belief was just a way of making the unbearable bearable without actually making it bearable at all. But she did not say this. She had learned, over thirty years, that some silences were more honest than words.

"The burial of things," Agnes said. "That is what people fear the most."

She went back to her bag and took out the old cloth, stained and worn, and a small bundle that Mara could not identify from this distance. The brazier had gone out, but the embers were still glowing, and Agnes coaxed them back to life with a patience that Mara recognized—the patience of someone who had done this many times, who knew that the fire would come back when it was ready and not before.

"When the sea gives something back," Agnes said, "we do not leave it on the shore and hope it goes away. We do not bury it in the ground where it came from. We give it back to the sea."

"What does that mean?"

"It means we take what the sea has returned—flotsam, jetsam, the things that wash up with the tide—and we bury them properly. In the water. In the place where they belong." She untied the bundle. Inside was a piece of wood, waterlogged and grey, with something carved into its surface that Mara could not read from where she stood. "This came up last month. The ferryman found it tangled in his anchor line."

"What is it?"

"Part of a boat that sank in 1931. Eleven men. This piece of the hull had their names on it." Agnes held it up to the light, the last of the light that was left. "The sea has been giving this back in pieces for

ninety years. We keep burying it. The sea keeps returning it.”

“That’s not—that seems like it means something.”

“It means the sea has not forgotten.” Agnes carried the wood to the water’s edge and waded in until the water was at her waist. She held the wood above her head and spoke more words in Gaelic, and then she let it go, and it sank, and the dark water closed over it, and it was gone.

Mara watched the place where the wood had gone under. She thought about the eleven men whose names were carved into that piece of hull, who had been on a boat that sank in 1931 and whose names were still coming back, still trying to rest, still waiting for the sea to be finished with them.

“Does it work?” she asked again. The same question as before, but she meant it differently now.

“The burial?”

“Any of it.”

Agnes came back to the shore, her coat heavy with water, her boots filled with sand. She did not seem to notice. She sat down on a dry rock and looked out at the cove, at the water that did not fight, at the place where Ellen Coulter had drowned in 1901 because she had tried to save her father’s ship and the tide had been stronger than she was.

“The rituals don’t stop the sea,” Agnes said. “I want you to understand that. Nothing stops the sea. Not prayers, not blessings, not the names of the dead or the burial of things. The sea takes what it takes, and the rituals are not about stopping that.”

“Then what are they about?”

Agnes was quiet for a long time. The wind had died completely now, and the cove was perfectly still, and the only sound was the tiny lapping of water against stone, the sound of the sea waiting.

“They give the living something to do while they wait.”

Mara felt the weight of it settle into her chest—the same weight she had felt in the morning, standing by the cold fire, knowing what the message said, knowing she could not unknow it. She had thought the rituals might be a way out. She had thought, if she learned what Agnes

the light from the keeper's cottage was a pale smear behind her when she reached the path that led down to Ellen's cove. the afternoon had thinned into evening, and the sky was the color of wet slate, and the wind came off the water with the pale, cold, salt smell of the sea. she had at this hour, perhaps, she could not expect an answer.
Eilidh Gunn, could give the reading a different ending than the one it promised.

But the rituals could not stop the sea. The rituals could not change what was coming. The rituals were just—a way of standing at the edge and meaning it. A way of being present for what could not be prevented. A way of carrying the weight without being crushed by it.

“What do you do,” Mara asked, “when the rituals aren’t enough?”

Agnes looked at her. The light was gone now, and the cove was dark, and Mara could not see Agnes’s face clearly, but she could hear the answer in her voice.

“I do them anyway.”

“That doesn’t seem like enough.”

“It isn’t.” Agnes stood, shook the water from her coat, reached for her bag. “Nothing is enough. That is what the sea teaches us, if we let it. Nothing is enough, and we do it anyway, and that is the only victory we get.”

Mara stayed by the water while Agnes packed up what was left of the ritual implements. The salt was gone, used in the blessing. The cloth was gone, used in the burial. The brazier was cold, the charcoal spent, the matches burned down to the box. Agnes had given what she had to give, and the sea had received it, and the water was still dark, and the cove was still waiting, and the name of the survivor was still written in Mara’s hand where it had appeared and would not fade.

“Agnes.”

The old woman turned.

“In 1973,” Mara said. “The reading you received. The one that named your brother.”

Agnes did not move. The bag hung at her side, forgotten.

“How did you stop it?”

“You can’t stop it.”

“But you tried. You must have tried.”

"I tried." Agnes's voice was flat. "I tried everything. The rituals. The prayers. The old ways and the new ways and the ways that had no name. I tried to make him stay on the island. I tried to make him go further away. I tried to make him understand that the sea had claimed him and nothing would change that."

"And?"

"And he went to sea anyway. He came back in a box." Agnes walked to the edge of the water and stood there, looking out at the darkness. "The reading named him as a survivor, Mara. Did you know that? It named him as the sole survivor of a wreck that would happen in fifteen years. Not the wreck that killed him. A different wreck. A wreck that would happen when he was thirty-four, and he would be the only one who lived, and the sea would take everyone else."

Mara felt the ground shift under her feet, though the stone was solid, though nothing had moved.

"A different wreck."

"That's what the reading said. A wreck in fifteen years, and he would survive, and everyone else would die, and the sea would keep him marked." Agnes's voice was steady, but Mara could hear the old wound in it, the kind that never healed all the way. "He was seventeen when I received the reading. He was thirty-two when he died. He had fifteen years to wait for a wreck that never came, because he died in a different wreck two years before it was supposed to happen."

"Agnes—"

"I have never told anyone that." Agnes turned, and in the darkness her face was unreadable, but her voice was clear. "I have never told anyone that the reading was wrong. That it was not the wreck it said. That the sea changed its mind, or that the timing was wrong, or that there was some mistake in the way the prophecy worked. I have kept that for fifty years because I did not know what it meant, and I still don't."

"What do you think it means?"

"I think the sea doesn't explain itself." Agnes shouldered her bag.

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"I think the readings are true, but true the way the tide is true. It happens when it does. I think my brother was supposed to survive a wreck in 1989, and instead he died in a wreck in 1987, and the sea took him early, or the sea changed its mind, or the sea has reasons that don't translate into our kind of sense."

Mara stood in the dark and felt the cove waiting around her, the water still and patient, the place where the tide turned and the sea held what it had claimed and did not explain.

"What do you think the reading meant for Eilidh Gunn?"

Agnes was quiet for a long time. Then she said: "I think it means what it says. A wreck in three weeks. A sole survivor. A name that has been marked by the sea." She paused. "Whether the wreck is the one the reading meant, or whether the sea changes its mind, or whether something else happens that none of us can predict—that, I cannot tell you. No one can. The readings are true, but they are not complete. They show us the shape of what is coming, not the whole of it."

Mara wanted to ask more. She wanted to know if Agnes had ever heard of a second bottle, of a correction, of someone receiving a different reading that changed the terms of the first. But the question felt too heavy to lift, and the cove was too dark, and the water was too still, and Agnes was already walking away, already climbing the path that led back to the island and its houses and its people who did not know yet what was coming for them.

"Agnes."

She stopped.

"What are you willing to do that Agnes was not?"

The old woman stood on the path above her, half-visible in the darkness, the bag over her shoulder, the water still lapping at her boots.

"I don't know yet," Mara said. "But I need to learn."

Agnes was silent for a long time. Then she said: "The rituals require presence, attention, a willingness to stand at the edge and mean it. If you have that, I can teach you the rest. But Mara—"

“Yes.”

“Whatever you do, the sea will take what it wants. That is not something anyone can stop. The only question is what you are willing to give up to try.”

Mara looked at the cove. At the water that waited. At the place where Ellen Coulter had drowned, and the stones with their names, and the wood that sank and kept coming back, and the dark that had no end that she could see.

“I’ll come back,” she said. “Tomorrow. After dark.”

Agnes nodded. She turned and climbed, and her footsteps faded on the path, and Mara was alone with the cove and the waiting sea and the name that would not fade from her hand.

Three weeks. She had three weeks, and a cove, and a woman who knew the rituals, and a reading that could not be unread, and now she had something else too—a question, the same one Agnes had carried for fifty years. What was she willing to give up to try?

She did not know yet. But she knew she could not do nothing.

She turned and began the climb back up to the path, away from the water, back toward the island and its houses and its people who did not know. The dark was complete now, and she walked by memory and by feel, her hands finding the stones that she had known since she was a girl, since before she kept the light, since before she knew what the sea could take.

Behind her, the cove was still. The water did not fight. It waited.

She walked into the dark, and the island held her, and the question waited with the sea, and the three weeks began to count down.

CHAPTER 9

The Inn was quiet. The League meeting had broken up an hour ago, and Finlay had stayed behind to clean the back room, stacking chairs against the wall with the mechanical care of a man who had done it every week for years. Mara watched him from the doorway before she entered. His back was to her. He moved slowly, and she noticed what she had not noticed before—how thin he had gone since his wife died, how the shape of him seemed to have collapsed inward like a building whose foundation had given way.



SHE stepped inside. The smell of the Inn reached her: stale beer, peat smoke, the particular mustiness of a room that was never quite aired out. The fire was low, embers in the grate, and the light came from a single lamp on the bar.

“Finlay.”

He turned. Surprise crossed his face, then settled into something more cautious.

"Mara. The meeting's over."

"I know."

"You weren't on the agenda anyway."

"No."

He set down the chair he was carrying. He wiped his hands on his trousers—a habit, she remembered, from when they were younger and he was building the business. He had always been wiping his hands of something.

"What is it, then?"

She crossed the room. Took the chair nearest the bar, the one that sat in the same spot it always sat, the one that had held generations of islanders who came to drink and talk and forget they were on a rock in the North Atlantic. She sat. He stayed standing.

"You should sit down," she said.

"I've been sitting down for fifteen years."

It was not what she expected him to say. She let the silence hold for a moment, then said: "I've found a reading."

Finlay went still. Not the stillness of shock—something more practiced. The stillness of a man who had learned not to show what he felt.

"A reading."

"A bottle. Found it this morning below the light. The message was there."

"Readings are nonsense."

"Every reading in the Registry has come true."

"The Registry." He said it like he was naming a disease. "The clerks who come out from the mainland and ask questions no one wants to answer. The files they keep on people who've done nothing wrong except be in the wrong place when a bottle washes up." He shook his head. "I've seen what happens to the people the clerks visit. The questions follow them. The neighbors look at them different. They become something in the island's mind, something marked, and it never ends

the inn was quiet. the league meeting had broken up an hour ago, and finlay had stayed behind to clean the back room, stacking chairs against the wall with the mechanical care of a man who had done it every week for years. well, she watched him from the doorway before she entered. his back was to her. he moved slowly, and she noticed what she had not noticed before—how thin he had gone since his wife died, how the shape of him seemed to have collapsed inward like a building whose foundation had given way.

I'm not talking about the clerks.
"You're talking about what they believe. What they write down in their books and send back to Edinburgh where someone files it away and calls it knowledge." He leaned against the bar. "I know what readings are, Mara. I've heard the stories. I've heard what the Daughters say and what the Cairn families whisper and what the old people tell the children to keep them from swimming at the wrong coves. And I also know that most bottles that wash up don't have messages in them. Most bottles are just bottles. And the ones that do have messages—" He stopped.

"The ones that do have messages?"

"Most people destroy them."

"I know."

"Then you know what happens when they don't."

Mara said nothing. She had learned, over thirty years, that some silences were more honest than words. She sat with her hands in her lap, the left one resting where the name had appeared, and she waited.

Finlay watched her. His face was the face she had seen in the harbor years ago, when the rescue boat came back empty and the families were waiting, when the men who went out to look for the bodies came back with nothing and someone had to stand on the dock and tell the women it was over. He had been the one to tell them, that time. He had been twenty-eight years old and newly married to a woman who would later become his wife, and he had stood on the dock and told eleven families that their men were gone.

She had watched him do it. She had been in the tower, keeping the light, and when the rescue boat came back she had climbed down and walked to the harbor because someone had to witness. She had watched him speak, watched the way his voice stayed steady even as his hands shook, watched the women receive the news and go still in the way that people go still when the world has tilted and they are trying to find a new footing.

That was the face he wore now. She recognized it. She had not expected him to wear it so quickly.

"Where is it?" he said.

She reached into her coat pocket and drew out the bottle. Green glass, caught between the rocks, now dry and ordinary-looking. She set it on the bar between them. The room was quiet enough that she could hear the fire settling, the tick of embers shifting in the grate.

Finlay looked at the bottle. He did not touch it.

"Show me," he said.

She opened her hand. The name was still there—EILIDH GUNN, written in a hand that was hers and was not hers, that had formed itself without her permission and would not fade. She held her hand out, palm up, and let him see.

He stared at it. She watched his face change—watched the disbelief move across it like weather, like the shadow of a cloud passing over water. He looked at the name. He looked at her. He looked at the bottle. He looked at the name again.

"This isn't possible."

"The readings don't care about possible."

"This is—" He stopped. Started again. "You're saying someone wrote my daughter's name. In a bottle. In your hand."

"The message came to me. I did not choose it."

"But the words. The name. That was you. Your hand. Your writing."

"Yes."

"And you believe—" He shook his head. "No. No. I don't accept this."

"Finlay."

"Readings are nonsense. Bottles wash up. Messages appear. And someone—a clerk, a scholar, someone who makes their living off other people's fear—they write it down and they call it prophecy and they build systems out of coincidences. I've heard this my whole life. My grandmother believed. My mother believed. They saw patterns in ev-

the inn was quiet. the league meeting had broken up an hour ago, and finlay had stayed behind to clean the back room, stacking chairs against the wall with the mechanical care of a man who had done it every week for years. everything, saw often in every storm, saw the hand of something larger. he moved slowly, and she noticed what she had not noticed before—how thin in every death. And it never made them wiser. It never made them safer. he had gone since his wife died, how the shape of him seemed to have collapsed inward like a building whose foundation had given way.

“I found the bottle.”

“You found a bottle.”

“I found a bottle with a message that named your daughter.”

“And what does that mean? That she might drown? That a ship might sink? That something might happen somewhere, someday, to someone who shares a name with her?” He was talking faster now, his voice climbing, the way it did when he was working himself up to a place he couldn’t come back from. “People drown. Ships sink. Things happen. The world is dangerous. That’s not prophecy, Mara. That’s Tuesday.”

“The message says she’s the only survivor.”

The words landed. She watched them land. She watched him take them in and saw the way his face changed, saw the way the color went out of it, saw the way his jaw tightened as though he were bracing for something he couldn’t name.

“The only survivor of what?”

“I don’t know yet.”

“You don’t know.”

“The readings don’t come with schedules. They name who survives. They don’t name when, or where, or how.”

“But Eilidh—my daughter—she’s in Edinburgh. She’s been in Edinburgh for eight years. She’s got a job and a flat and a life and she hasn’t been on a boat since she was eighteen years old and swore she’d never come back to this island.” He was gripping the edge of the bar now, his knuckles white against the dark wood. “She’s not going to drown. She doesn’t go near the water. She wouldn’t—”

“I know.”

“Then what are you telling me this for?”

Mara looked at him. He was fifty-eight years old. He had run the Inn for thirty years. He had buried his wife and raised his daughter

and fought for the ferry and argued with the mainland and kept the island's heart beating through sheer stubbornness and care. He was not a man who believed in prophecy because belief would mean his life was already determined, and he could not afford to believe that. He had too much to protect.

"I found the bottle," she said. "The message named her. And the readings don't care where she is, Finlay. The readings mark who survives. The sea brings the wreck to them, or brings them to the wreck. I've seen it. I've watched it happen. You can't outrun a reading."

"Watched it happen." His voice was flat. "You've watched someone survive a wreck because a reading told you they would?"

"No. I've watched the ones who didn't know. The ones who went out not knowing they were marked, and the sea took them anyway, and afterward someone found the bottle and read the message and understood what had happened. The readings don't fail, Finlay. They come true. Every one of them. The only question is whether anyone knows in time to try."

"To try what?"

"I don't know yet."

He laughed. It was not a good laugh. It was the sound of a man who had reached the end of his patience and found nothing there.

"You don't know. You don't know what the message means. You don't know when it will happen. You don't know where, or how, or what it will take to stop it. And you're standing in my bar telling me my daughter is going to die."

"I'm telling you she is marked. I'm telling you the sea has claimed her. And I'm telling you that if there's a way to change that, I need to find it."

"And why you? Why did you have to be the one to find the bottle? Why couldn't it wash up somewhere else, find someone else, leave someone else to deal with it?" He was pressing his palms flat against the bar now, leaning forward, his whole body tense. "Why you, Mara?"

The question hung in the air. She could have answered it. She

the inn was quiet. the league meeting had broken up an hour ago, and finlay had stayed behind to clean the back room, stacking chairs against the wall with the mechanical care of a man who had done it every week for years. could have told him about the tower before the years and the eleven men he moved slowly, and she noticed what she had not noticed before — how thin she had watched drown because the rescue came too late. She could he had gone since his wife died, how the shape of him seemed to have have told him about the faces she saw when she closed her eyes, the collapsed inward like a building whose foundation had given way.

names she could not say without the names becoming real. She could have told him she was not chosen, that the bottle had found her the way the sea finds its own, that she had been marked by the water long before she ever found the message.

She said none of this.

“Because I was the one standing there,” she said.

Finlay stared at her. His breathing was hard, visible in the way his chest moved against his shirt. The fire crackled behind them. Outside, somewhere, a dog barked—the sound traveling across the harbor, carrying the ordinary noise of the island into this room where nothing was ordinary anymore.

“Where is she?” he said.

“Edinburgh.”

“Then she’s safe.”

“The reading doesn’t care where she is.”

“Edinburgh is three hundred miles from the sea.”

“Some of the people in the Registry were nowhere near water when the wreck happened. The message finds them. The sea finds them.” Mara paused. “I don’t know how it works. I know that it does.”

Finlay turned away. He picked up the bottle from the bar—held it in his hand, turning it, looking at the glass as though the answers might be hidden in its green depth. He looked at the cork, still sealed, still holding whatever small breath the message needed to stay alive. He looked at the label, or what was left of it, the original markings worn away by salt and time.

“My daughter,” he said quietly.

“Yes.”

“She left because of me.”

“I know.”

“She thinks I smothered her. Her mother—the way she died—we

never talked about it. I didn't know how to talk about it. I just tried to keep Eilidh safe. Keep her here. Keep her close. And she wanted out. She wanted to be somewhere the sea couldn't reach her. She wanted to be away from all of it—the island, the stories, the way the past sits on everything here like a weight.” He set the bottle down. “She wanted to be free of me.”

“And?”

“And I called her last week. After you found the bottle. After you told me.” He was not looking at her now. He was looking at the fire, or through it, at something she couldn't see. “She didn't answer. I left a message. Just—hello, Eilidh, it's your father, call me when you can.” He swallowed. “She hasn't called back.”

“Finlay.”

“I know what you're going to say.”

“You're going to need to bring her home.”

“I know.”

“And you're going to need to tell her why.”

He turned then, and faced her, and she saw what she had seen in 1998—the face of a man watching the sea take someone. He was not the same man he had been then. The years had worn him down, carved new lines into his face, taken some of the strength out of his shoulders and some of the certainty out of his eyes. But the face was the same. The fear was the same. The terrible knowledge that something was coming that he could not stop.

“I'll call her again,” he said.

“And tell her what?”

“What you told me. That a reading came. That my name is in it.” He stopped. Corrected himself. “Her name. That she's marked. That she needs to come home.”

“And if she doesn't believe you?”

Finlay looked at the bottle on the bar. He looked at Mara's hand, still open, still bearing the name that would not fade. He looked at the fire, and the empty chairs, and the room that had held so many

the inn was quiet. the league meeting had broken up an hour ago, and finlay had stayed behind to clean the back room, stacking chairs against the wall with the mechanical care of a man who had done it every week for years. conversations but had never held one like this. she moved slowly, and she noticed what she had not noticed before—how thin he had gone since his wife died, how the shape of him seemed to have collapsed inward like a building whose foundation had given way.

“I don’t care what she thinks of me. I don’t care if she never speaks to me again. If there’s a chance—any chance—that knowing this changes what happens, I have to take it.”

Mara nodded. She did not tell him what she suspected—that knowing would not be enough. That the readings had their own logic, their own weight, their own terrible momentum. That the sea did not negotiate and the marked did not escape by simply being warned.

She did not tell him that she had seen, in the moment when the message appeared in her hand, something else too. A second line of text, faint, almost invisible, that had vanished before she could read it. She did not know what it meant. She did not know if it was part of the reading or part of her own fear.

She would tell him. Later. When she understood it herself.

“For now,” she said, “call her. Tell her what you know. And tell her I’m sorry.”

“Sorry for what?”

Mara stood. The chair scraped against the floor, the sound loud in the quiet room. She took the bottle and put it back in her pocket, felt its weight against her hip, the small solid presence of the thing that had started all of this.

“For what comes next,” she said. “For whatever we have to do to try.”

She walked to the door. Stopped. Turned back.

“Finlay.”

“Yes?”

“The meeting tonight. The League. What did you decide?”

He was still standing behind the bar, his hands flat on the wood, his face carrying the weight of everything she had told him. He blinked, as though the question had come from very far away.

“We voted. Two more ferries a week. If we can get the funding.”

“And if you can’t?”

"Then we keep fighting. We always do." He almost smiled. It did not reach his eyes. "The ferry doesn't matter anyway. Not this week. This week I have a daughter to call."

Mara opened the door. The night was cold, the air carrying the salt and damp that never quite left the island. The harbor was visible below, the boats rocking on their moorings, the dark water keeping its secrets.

She stepped out into it.

Behind her, she heard Finlay pick up the phone.

She walked down toward the harbor, past the Inn, past the closed post office, past the cooperative building where the looms sat silent. The water was black and still, and she could see the reflection of the stars, and somewhere out there beyond the horizon the sea was waiting, and the wreck was coming, and the three weeks had begun to count down.

She reached the shore and stopped. The rocks were slick beneath her boots. The tide was rising, slow and inevitable, and she stood there and listened to the water talk to itself in the dark, and she thought about Finlay calling his daughter, and she thought about the name on her hand, and she thought about the second line of text she had not yet told anyone about.

She did not know what it said.

She did not know if she wanted to know.

The sea waited.

Mara waited with it.

She had three weeks. She had a bottle and a name and a man who would do anything to save his daughter. She had Agnes and the rituals and the cove that bore a dead woman's name.

She had what the sea had not taken yet.

She turned and walked up from the shore, toward the path that led to her cottage, and the question followed her all the way home: Will Finlay help or hinder?

She did not have an answer.

The sea did.

CHAPTER 10

The Skeptic



THE door closed behind Mara and Finlay stood behind the bar with his hands flat on the wood. The room was empty. The chairs were up on the tables for the night and the fire had burned down to embers and the only sound was the sea talking to itself outside, the way it always did, the way it had since before anyone on this island was born.

He poured himself a whiskey. He set it down in front of him and looked at it. He did not drink.

Bottles. Old wives' tales. A message in a bottle like something from a story his mother used to tell when he was small, about children who went to the shore and found things that should not have been found. She had told them to frighten him, he thought. To keep him close. It had worked. For years he had been afraid of the water, afraid of what it might give back, and then he had grown up and stopped being afraid and started working on the boats instead.

He picked up the glass. He put it down.

One survivor. Eilidh Gunn.

The name sat in his chest like a stone. He tried to move it. He could not.

She was in Edinburgh. She had a job and a flat and a life that did not include him, not really, not anymore. She had left because the island was too small and he was too much and there was nothing for her here. That was what she said. That was what she had always said, even when she was still here, even when she was a girl who followed him down to the harbor and asked questions about the boats and the weather and the things that mattered to him. She had stopped asking. She had stopped coming. He had not known how to stop her.

He should call her. That was what Mara wanted. Mara wanted him to call his daughter and warn her and that was what you did when someone told you something terrible—you made a phone call and you told the person you loved and then you figured out what came next. But what came next when what came next was a message in a bottle? What came next when there was nothing to do, nowhere to go, no problem to solve with the right parts and the right timing and the right sequence of actions that a man could perform and feel useful?

He could call her. She would not answer. She never answered, not when he called, not unless it was something important, not unless it was the kind of call that meant something had happened and she had to come home. He had used that. He had called her when her mother was dying and he had called her when the funeral was arranged and he had called her after, in those first weeks, and she had come home for the funeral and she had not come home since, not really, not in the way that mattered. She had come home for the funeral because she owed her mother that much. She did not owe him anything.

He picked up the phone. He dialed. He listened to it ring.

It went to voicemail. Her voice, recorded years ago, years and years ago, before her mother got sick, before everything changed, telling him to leave a message and she would call back. He had heard that message a hundred times. He had heard it so often it did not sound like her anymore. It sounded like a stranger wearing her voice.

He hung up. He did not leave a message.

What would he say? *Your father's friend found a bottle in the water*

and it said you're going to drown? Mara had said there was a wreck coming. Mara had said there was a survivor, and the survivor was named, and the name was his daughter's. His daughter who was thirty-two years old and lived in a city on the mainland and had not set foot on this island in two years except for the occasional holiday she did not want to take. His daughter who had her own life. His daughter who had left because the island was too small and he was too much and there was nothing for her here.

He had not argued. That was the thing. When she told him she was going, when she told him she had a job lined up and a flat rented and a life waiting, he had not argued. He had stood in this room and watched her pack the last of her things and he had said nothing because what was there to say? She was right. The island was too small. He was too much. There was nothing for her here. He had known this for years. He had known it and he had done nothing about it, which was what he did, which was what he had always done—he waited and he watched and he let things happen because he did not know how to make them happen differently.

His wife had hidden her illness for a year.

He had not seen it. She had been tired. She had been quiet. She had been distant in a way he had attributed to age, to menopause, to the slow erosion of a life lived on a rock in the sea where nothing ever changed and nothing ever would. He had attributed it to anything except what it was. He had not seen the weight loss until it was undeniable. He had not seen the appointments on the kitchen counter, the letters from the hospital, the things she hid in the drawer next to the sink where he never looked. She had hidden it from him for a year and he had not seen it because he had not been looking. He had been tending the bar and fixing the boats and arguing about ferry schedules and fighting the battles he knew how to fight, and his wife had been dying in the next room and he had not seen it.

She had told him at the end. That was what the doctors said, what the nurses said, what everyone said afterward—she had known for a

year and she had not told anyone and there was no way to know why, no way to understand what had made her keep it silent until there was nothing left to say. He had asked her. In the hospital, in those last days, he had asked her why she had not told him and she had looked at him with eyes that were already somewhere else and she had said nothing. She had said nothing and he had never known and he had never stopped wondering.

Eilidh blamed him. That was what he understood, what he had understood since the funeral, since the silence that filled the space where his daughter used to talk to him. Eilidh blamed him for not seeing. Eilidh blamed him for the year his wife spent suffering alone. Eilidh blamed him for being the kind of man who stood in the middle of his life and watched it fall apart and did nothing until there was nothing left to do.

She was wrong. That was what he told himself. She was wrong and he had not known and there was no way anyone could have known and if she wanted to blame him for that then she was blaming him for being human and that was not fair and that was not right and he had done the best he could with what he had.

He had done the best he could with what he had.

He poured the whiskey down the drain. He did not know why. It seemed like the thing to do. It seemed like a gesture toward something he could not name—a promise, maybe, or a renunciation. He was not a man who drank alone. He was not a man who needed things. He was not a man who stood behind his own bar and poured drinks he did not drink and called daughters who did not answer and believed in messages that came in bottles from nowhere.

Mara had lit the signal fires in 1998. He remembered. He remembered the night the freighter went down two miles off the coast and the whole island came down to the harbor to watch the flares go up, to watch the light spin above the water like something holy, like something that might save someone if it was bright enough and turned the right way. The mainland rescue came too late. Eleven men. Eleven

bodies that never came back. Mara had stood in the tower and turned that light and she had done everything right and it had not mattered. He knew this. He knew the story. He had lived it, same as everyone on the island had lived it, same as everyone on the island had been living it ever since, in the quiet moments, in the spaces between things.

The readings were the same. That was what he told himself. The readings were the same—things people found in bottles, things people whispered about, things that might come true or might not but either way there was nothing to be done. The readings were stories. The readings were old wives' tales. The readings were the kind of thing that happened to other people, people who believed in such things, people who had nothing else to hold onto.

He did not believe in such things.

He had a bar to run and a ferry league to chair and a daughter who had left and a wife who was dead and a life that was defined by what he could fix and what he could fight and what he could make happen through effort and determination and the refusal to accept that some things were out of his control. He had built that life on purpose. He had built it because the alternative was this—standing in an empty room in the dark, listening to the sea, believing in nothing.

The phone rang.

He stared at it. The sound was wrong—it cut through the silence like something sharp, like something that did not belong. The phone did not ring at night. The phone rang in the day, during the hours when the Inn was open and people came and went and the world was normal. At night the phone did not ring because everyone on the island knew where everyone else was and there was no reason to call.

It rang again.

He picked it up. He said nothing.

“Da?”

It was Eilidh. Her voice, rough with sleep—she had been asleep, it was nearly midnight and she had been asleep, she was in Edinburgh in her flat and she was asleep and he had woken her with this call he had

not meant to make, this call that had not been a call, this call that was just the phone ringing in his hand because he had touched it without meaning to.

"I didn't mean to wake you."

"You didn't. I was—" A pause. A breath. "What time is it?"

"After eleven."

"Jesus, Dad. What's wrong?"

He opened his mouth. He did not know what to say. The words were there, they were right there, they were exactly what Mara had told him to do—*tell her, warn her, make her understand*—but he could not make them come out. He could not say *a woman found a bottle in the water and it said you're going to die* to his daughter at midnight, to his daughter who had not spoken to him in months, to his daughter who had left because he was too much and the island was too small and there was nothing here for her.

"Nothing's wrong. I just wanted to hear your voice."

The words came out and they were wrong, they were all wrong, they were the kind of thing he never said, the kind of thing he would never have said if he had thought about it first. He did not say things like that. He did not call his daughter in the middle of the night to say he wanted to hear her voice. He called her when there was something to discuss, when there was a problem to solve, when there was a reason.

"What?" Her voice was sharp now. She was awake now. She was awake and she was suspicious, she was already building the wall she built every time he called, the wall that kept him out, the wall that kept her safe from whatever he might want, whatever he might ask, whatever weight he might try to put on her.

"Nothing. I was just thinking about you."

"Dad. What's going on?"

He could feel it happening—the thing he had always feared, the thing that happened every time he tried to reach her and failed, the thing that turned every conversation into an argument and every call into a wall. He could feel himself trying to control it and he could feel

himself failing and he could feel the distance opening between them, the distance that was already there, the distance that had always been there since she was a girl and he was a man who did not know how to say the things that mattered.

“Mara Callaghan came by tonight.”

“Who?”

“The lighthouse keeper. She had something she wanted to tell me.”

“What?”

He closed his eyes. “A reading. She found a bottle. There was a message.”

Silence. He could hear her breathing. He could hear the sound of the city in the background, the traffic, the distant sirens, the noise of a place that was not here, that had never been here, that he had never seen except in pictures and in his daughter’s descriptions, in the places she had chosen to go instead of the place she was born.

“Dad. What are you talking about?”

“I don’t know. I don’t know what I’m talking about.”

“You’re talking about the bottle thing. The reading thing. You believe in that?”

“I don’t know what I believe.”

He heard her laugh. It was the laugh he had heard so many times, the laugh she used when she did not know what else to do, when the conversation had gone somewhere she did not want it to go and the only response was to make it smaller, to make it a joke, to make it something that did not matter.

“Dad. It’s midnight. You called me at midnight to tell me about a message in a bottle.”

“I know.”

“Are you okay?”

The question stopped him. She had not asked that in a long time. She had not asked if he was okay in years, not since the funeral, not since she had looked at him across the churchyard and seen something she could not forgive. She had not asked because she did not want to know.

She had not asked because knowing would mean doing something and she had already done everything she could do—she had left, she had built her life, she had kept the distance that was the only thing standing between her and whatever it was she could not face about this place, about him, about her mother's death.

"I'm fine," he said.

"You don't sound fine."

"I'm fine. I just—Mara wanted me to call you. To tell you. She said the reading named you."

Silence again. But different this time. He could hear something in the silence, something he could not name, something that was not the wall she had been building but was something else, something he had not heard from her in years.

"What do you mean, it named me?"

"It said there was going to be a wreck. A ship coming in. And there would be one survivor, and the survivor was going to be you."

Another pause. He could hear her moving, heard the sound of a window opening, the noise of the city getting louder, then softer, then gone—she had gone outside, she was on the street or on a balcony or somewhere that was not the flat anymore, somewhere that was not the place where she had built her life away from him.

"Dad. That's insane."

"I know."

"You know it's insane. You know how it sounds."

"Yes."

"So why are you calling me at midnight to tell me about it?"

He did not have an answer. He stood in the empty bar with the phone in his hand and he did not have an answer because there was no good answer, there was no answer that made sense, there was only the feeling that had been sitting in his chest since Mara left, the feeling that would not move, the feeling that he had been trying to pour down the drain with the whiskey and could not.

"Because I can't stop thinking about it," he said.

Another silence. He heard her breathe out, heard the sound of the city again, heard her trying to decide something, trying to figure out what to do with the thing he had told her, the thing that was insane, the thing that she did not believe but could not quite put down.

"I'm not coming home," she said.

"I know."

"Whatever she said, whatever you think is going to happen—I'm not coming home. I have a job. I have a life."

"I know."

"So why are you telling me this?"

He looked at the bar, at the glasses he had washed and put away, at the chairs on the tables, at the fire that had burned down to nothing. He looked at the room he had built his life in and he did not know how to answer her.

"Because Mara said I should," he said. "And because I can't stop thinking about it."

The silence stretched. He could hear her breathing. He could hear the sea outside, the same sea, the same sound, the same water that had taken his wife's face and held it, that had taken eleven men in 1998 and given nothing back, that was waiting now for something he could not see.

"Dad."

"Yes."

"I had a dream last night. About the harbor. About boats coming in that shouldn't float."

He closed his eyes.

"I don't know why I'm telling you that," she said. "I don't believe in that stuff. I don't believe in the readings and I don't believe in the bottles and I don't believe in whatever you think is happening here. But I had the dream and I woke up and I couldn't go back to sleep and I've been sitting in the dark ever since waiting for something I don't know how to name."

He did not say anything. He could not.

“So I guess what I’m saying is—I don’t know. I don’t know what’s happening. I don’t know if that means anything. I just needed you to know that.”

“Eilidh.”

“What?”

“Come home.”

The words came out before he could stop them. They were wrong. He knew they were wrong. He had spent years trying to make her come home and he had failed and he had accepted it, he had accepted that she would not come back, that the island was too small and he was too much and there was nothing for her here. But now he said it anyway, now he said it at midnight with the phone in his hand and the sea outside and the feeling in his chest that would not move.

“I’m not coming home, Dad.”

“I know.”

“Then why are you asking?”

He opened his eyes. He looked at the room. He looked at the dark water visible through the window, the harbor lights reflecting on the surface, the boats tied to their moorings, the same boats that had always been there, that would always be there, that were waiting for something he could not control.

“Because I can’t stop thinking about it,” he said again. “And because if something happens—if there’s something I could have done and didn’t—”

He did not finish. He did not know how to finish.

The silence stretched. Then she said, “I have to go.”

“I know.”

“Dad. I’m sorry. I just—”

“I know.”

He could hear her crying. He could hear it in the way she breathed, in the sound that was just below her voice, in the thing she was trying to hide from him the way her mother had hidden her illness, the way everyone on this island hid the things that mattered until there was nothing

left to save.

“I love you,” he said.

“I know. I have to go.”

The line went dead.

He stood in the empty bar and he held the phone and he listened to nothing, to the silence that was left, to the sound of the sea and the wind and the night that did not care what he believed or what he felt or what he was going to do next.

He could not stop thinking about it.

He set the phone down. He walked to the window. The harbor was dark, the boats rocking on their moorings, the water black and still and waiting. Somewhere out there, beyond the horizon, a ship was coming. A wreck was coming. The reading said so. The reading named his daughter and the sea did not care what he believed and the three weeks had begun to count down.

He pressed his hand against the glass. The cold was sharp, real, undeniable.

He had three weeks.

He had a daughter who would not come home and a woman who believed in bottles and a feeling in his chest that would not move and a choice he did not know how to make.

He had what the sea had not taken yet.

He did not know if it would be enough.

CHAPTER II

The Call



THE fluorescent lights in the records office hummed at a frequency Eilidh had learned to stop hearing. Three years behind a desk had taught her body things her mind hadn't authorized: how to sit without shifting weight, how to scan a document without reading it, how to let her eyes move across a page while her thoughts were somewhere else entirely.

She was good at it. That was what she'd been told in her performance review, and what she'd told herself in the mirror every morning since. *Good at it.* The words had become a kind of armor, worn smooth by repetition.

The file in front of her was a property dispute from 1987, buried in a chain of deeds that went back further than anyone cared to trace. She'd been working on it for three days. The solicitor wanted resolution by Friday. Eilidh intended to give it to him by Wednesday, because that was what she did.

Her phone buzzed on the desk. Her father's name appeared on the screen.

She watched it buzz. Watched it stop. Watched the screen go dark.

He would call again. He always called again.

...

The first time, two weeks after her mother died, she'd answered. She'd been sitting in her own flat with the windows closed against the Edinburgh rain, and the phone had rung and she'd picked it up without thinking, and he'd been crying. Not the kind of crying you could hear. The kind that was just below the surface, the kind that changed the shape of words without changing the words themselves.

I know you're busy, he'd said. I know you have your life. I just wanted to hear your voice.

She'd stayed on the line for forty-seven minutes. She'd hated every second of it.

The second time, a month later, she'd let it ring. He'd left a voicemail about the ferry schedule. She'd deleted it without listening.

The third time, she'd answered on the first ring just to prove to herself that she could. He'd asked about her job. She'd asked about the Inn. Neither of them answered. They'd hung up after twelve minutes, and she'd spent the rest of the evening unable to remember what they'd talked about.

Since then, she'd learned the rhythm. He called on Sundays. She let it go to voicemail. She listened to the voicemail, sometimes, if it had been a bad week. She never called back.

But he hadn't called on Sunday.

She looked at her phone. Wednesday. Three days early.

Her desk phone rang.

...

"Records office."

"Is that you, Eilidh?"

Her supervisor, McAldery. He was leaning over the partition that separated their desks, his face arranged in the particular way it took

when he wanted something.

"Sheila wants the file on Henderson before lunch."

"Which Henderson? There are four."

"The 1987 one."

"It'll be done."

He nodded and disappeared. Eilidh returned to the screen. The property dispute was almost resolved, buried now in a chain of easements that made her eyes ache. She found the gap in the documentation that the solicitor needed, flagged it, saved the file, and moved on.

Her personal phone sat on the desk, silent.

She worked through Henderson, then two requests from the tax office, then a filing error that someone else had made and she was expected to fix. The morning passed the way mornings passed: in increments measured by screen glare and the particular quality of the light through the windows.

At eleven-thirty, her personal phone rang.

...

She didn't recognize the number.

"Hello?"

"Eilidh Gunn?"

"Yes."

"My name is Mara Callaghan. I keep the lighthouse on Torran."

Eilidh sat very still. The fluorescent lights hummed. Someone in the next office was laughing at something, the sound muffled by walls.

"I don't—" she started.

"Your father called me. He said you weren't answering his calls."

"My father's calls are about ferry schedules."

"Yes. He mentioned."

The pause that followed was long enough to mean something. Eilidh found herself holding the phone a little tighter.

"What did he tell you?" Eilidh asked.

"He told me what he knew. Which isn't much."

"Then why are you calling?"

"Because I found something. A message. It came in a bottle, the way these things come, and it names—"

She stopped.

"It names what?"

"You."

Eilidh laughed. She couldn't help it. The sound came out before she could catch it, sharp and wrong.

"A message in a bottle," she said. "You're calling me about a message in a bottle."

"I know how it sounds."

"You know how it sounds."

"I'm not asking you to believe me."

"Then what are you asking?"

The silence stretched. Somewhere in the building, a door closed.

"I'm asking you to listen," Mara said.

...

Eilidh should have hung up. She should have said *I'm busy* or *I have to go* or simply ended the call without ceremony. She'd done it before, with survey takers, with charity callers, with her father on his worst nights.

But she didn't.

She listened.

Mara told her about the bottle. Green glass, caught between rocks below the high-water mark. The message appearing in her hand, written in a hand that was not her own. The words that named a shipwreck three weeks away. The words that named Eilidh as the only survivor.

"And when I say survivor," Mara said, "I mean what the readings mean. It means you're marked. It means the sea has already claimed you, and if you go to the water, if you're anywhere near where the ship

goes down—”

“It kills me.”

“It takes you.”

“What’s the difference?”

Mara didn’t answer.

Eilidh looked at her screen. The cursor blinked in the middle of a sentence she didn’t remember starting. She deleted it.

“You found a bottle,” she said. “And it had a message. And now you’re calling me to tell me I’m going to die.”

“I’m calling you to tell you there’s a choice.”

“There isn’t. There’s a message in a bottle. Either you believe messages in bottles or you don’t, and I don’t, so—”

“You’ve been dreaming about the harbor.”

Eilidh stopped.

“What?”

“Your father said. He said you haven’t been sleeping. He said you’ve been dreaming about boats coming in that shouldn’t float.”

...

She hung up.

She sat at her desk and stared at the screen until McAldery asked if she was all right, and she said yes, and he went back to his own desk, and she kept staring.

Boats that shouldn’t float.

She’d dreamed about them three times in the past week. The harbor at Torran, black water, boats rising and falling on a swell that wasn’t there. She couldn’t see the boats clearly, only their shapes, only the way they moved wrong, the way they seemed to wait for something.

She hadn’t told anyone. She hadn’t even let herself think about it, not really. She’d told herself it was stress, that her father had been calling too much, that the island was finding its way into her sleep because she wasn’t letting it in while she was awake.

But she hadn't told anyone.

She picked up her phone. The call history showed the number Mara had called from. A local number, island exchange.

She put the phone down.

...

At lunch, she walked to the coffee shop on the corner and bought a sandwich she didn't eat. She sat by the window and watched the street and tried to think about something else.

The property dispute. The Henderson file. The filing error she'd fixed.

She thought about boats that shouldn't float.

At one o'clock, she went back to her desk. She worked for an hour, maybe two, the time dissolving into the glow of the screen. Her phone sat silent beside the keyboard. She didn't look at it.

At three, it rang.

She looked.

Her father's number.

...

She answered.

"Dad."

"Eilidh. Thank God."

"I was busy."

"Did she call you? Mara Callaghan? She said she would."

"Yes."

"And?"

"And what?"

"What did she say?"

Eilidh closed her eyes. The fluorescent lights pressed down on her eyelids, red and unwavering.

"She said there's a message. In a bottle. She said it says I'm going to

drown.”

The silence on the line was different from Mara’s silence. It was heavier. It was the silence of a man trying to figure out what to say and failing.

“That’s not—” he started.

“I know.”

“You know it’s not—”

“I know.”

“So you’re coming home. You’re coming home and we’ll figure this out.”

“I didn’t say that.”

“What else is there?”

Eilidh opened her eyes. The office was still there, the same screens and partitions, the same hum of lights and the distant sound of someone else’s printer. The world hadn’t changed. Nothing had changed.

“I have to go,” she said.

“Eilidh—”

“I have to go, Dad. I have work.”

“Your work can wait.”

“No. It really can’t.”

She ended the call.

...

She stayed at her desk until six. She finished the Henderson file, filed the tax requests, wrote an email to a solicitor she didn’t know about a deadline she didn’t care about. The words on her screen were legible and correct and said nothing.

When she left the office, the Edinburgh evening was already dark. The rain had stopped sometime in the afternoon, and the streets were wet, and the lights of the city reflected in ways that made everything look temporary.

She walked home. Her flat was on the third floor of a building that

had been built for people who worked in offices and slept alone. She'd been there for four years. The furniture was IKEA, the books were from the charity shop, the view was of another building's wall.

She made tea. She drank it standing at the window, looking at nothing.

Her phone sat on the counter.

She didn't pick it up.

...

At ten, she got ready for bed. She set her alarm. She brushed her teeth. She stood in the doorway of her bedroom and looked at the flat and felt the weight of it, the way it pressed down on her chest, the way it asked nothing of her except that she stay.

She thought about boats that shouldn't float.

She thought about her father's voice on the phone, the shape of the words that meant he was afraid, the way he couldn't say it directly.

She thought about Mara Callaghan, the lighthouse keeper she'd met twice as a child, a woman with grey hair and calloused hands who'd stood on the shore and watched Eilidh wade in the shallows and said nothing, only watched.

She picked up her phone.

...

The number was still in her call history. She stared at it for a long time.

It would take one call to end this. She could call Mara back, ask her what she meant about the choice, ask her what the readings had actually done for anyone before. She could find out if this was real or if her father had finally lost his grip on reason entirely.

Or she could not call. She could go to sleep and wake up tomorrow and go to work and file her files and answer her phone when her father called and ignore it when he didn't. She could stay here, in this flat, in

this life, in the distance she'd built between herself and the island.

She could stay.

She put the phone down.

She turned off the light.

...

In the dark, in the bed that was too large for one person, in the flat that was too quiet for anyone, Eilidh closed her eyes and waited for sleep.

The harbor came. Black water. Boats that shouldn't float.

She watched them from the shore, and they watched her back, and the tide turned the way it always turned, and she did not dream anything else.

She woke at three in the morning and lay in the dark and listened to the city breathe.

She would think about it tomorrow. She would think about it when she was at her desk, when she was drinking her coffee, when she was walking home through streets that asked nothing of her. She would think about it, and then she would decide.

She did not mean to think about it.

She knew she would.

...

In the morning, the rain came back. Eilidh walked to work with her umbrella and her bag and her face that said nothing. The office was warm and the screens glowed and the Henderson file was waiting on her desk.

She sat down. She opened the file.

Her phone sat beside the keyboard, silent, patient.

She looked at it.

She didn't pick it up.

Not yet.

CHAPTER 12

The Return



THE ferry cut through water the color of slate. Eilidh Gunn stood at the stern, gripping the rail with both hands, and told herself she wasn't coming. The words moved through her like a current—not persuasive, not a lie, just the shape of what she wanted to be true. She wasn't coming. She was on the boat. These two facts had no relationship to each other.

Her father had called three days ago. Not about the ferry schedule, not about the Inn, not about anything she could file under the usual. He'd said her name and then stopped. In thirty-two years, Angus Finlay Gunn had never stopped mid-sentence. She'd heard him argue with suppliers for fifteen minutes about the correct shade of green for a door. He'd stopped for her twice: once when her mother died, and once now.

The boat heaved. She held the rail tighter.

...

The island appeared out of the grey like something remembered. Coulter's Light caught the low sun first—a white flash on the headland that meant home and not-home, both at once. Eilidh watched it grow

larger and felt something move in her chest that she refused to name. The island was smaller than she remembered. The moors ran down to the water in shades of brown and green, and the harbor she had left behind looked like a wound in the landscape, scabbed over with boats.

It was larger than she wanted.

That was the real problem with coming back. The island didn't shrink to fit her life in Edinburgh. It waited, unchanging, and when she returned it reminded her of every version of herself she had tried to leave behind. The girl who ran along the breakwater. The daughter who sat at her father's bar and pretended not to listen to the fishermen talk about the weather. The woman who put her mother in the ground and could not stop seeing the disease that had hidden in plain sight for a year.

She had been all of those people. None of them had stayed.

The ferry began its turn, swinging wide to align with the moorings. Aul□ harbor spread below her—the Inn's whitewashed wall, the empty post office, the cooperative building where the women worked the looms and talked about things she'd never learn. She scanned the dock without meaning to. Looking for someone. She didn't know who.

Finlay.

He stood at the end of the quay, apart from the small crowd that gathered when the ferry came in. He was not waving. He was not smiling. He was watching the water where her face would appear when she reached the rail, and the expression he wore was not the one she had come to expect. She knew his tired patience, his practiced nonchalance, his way of making every homecoming feel like a transaction being completed. This was none of those. This was the face he had made at the hospital when they told him her mother was gone. The face he had not made at the funeral, where he had been solid and steady and not enough.

Fear.

She descended the ferry's ladder and her feet hit the dock and her

father did not move toward her. He waited. She walked across the wet planks and the gap between them shrank until it was only breath, and when she stopped in front of him he said nothing.

“Dad.”

“You came.”

“You asked.”

He looked at her—really looked, the way he used to when she was small and he was checking for injury after a fall. Searching for something. She didn’t know what he found.

“You shouldn’t have come,” he said.

“You called.”

“I know what I said.”

“Then tell me what you mean.”

The harbor master’s empty office sat behind them. Beyond it, the Inn’s windows caught the light. Somewhere in that building, in a room with a view of the water, her father had made a phone call he couldn’t take back. He had spoken her name and stopped, and she had gotten on a boat.

“There was a message,” he said. “A bottle. Found at the light-house.”

Eilidh waited. She knew about the readings. Every child on Torran knew—you grew up hearing about them, about the bottles that came in with the tide, about the words that couldn’t be unread. You heard the stories and you filed them with the other island things: the ghost light in Ellen’s Cove, the way the sea sang before a storm, the names of the eleven who went down in the wreck of ninety-eight. Things that were true in the way the island was true—not rational, not provable, but impossible to argue with because the island itself would not allow the argument.

“A message came,” her father said. “To Mara Callaghan.”

“I know who Mara is.”

“It’s about you.”

The words arrived and she understood them and she did not be-

lieve them. Not yet. Belief was a thing you earned, and all she had was a dock and a grey sky and her father's face.

"I'm here," she said. "I'm here because you asked. I'm not here because I believe."

Finlay flinched. Not much. She wouldn't have seen it if she hadn't been watching for it. But the flinch was there, and it told her something about what he had expected from her, and it told her that whatever he had expected, this was not it.

"You should believe," he said. "If anyone on this island knows when to believe—"

"Then what? Then I'm saved? Then the message does something?"

"The message names you. The message says you're the only one who survives."

"Then I'll survive. That's what it says, isn't it? The only one who survives. That's not a warning. That's a promise."

Her father's face changed. The fear did not leave, but something else came with it—frustration, maybe, or grief. The expression of a man who had tried to say something important and been answered with a child's logic.

"A ship is going to sink," he said. "The reading says. A ship is going to go down, and you're the only one who makes it back to shore."

"And the others?"

He didn't answer. He didn't need to.

"How long?"

"I don't know. Mara didn't—"

"Mara knows. She found the bottle. She read the message."

"She won't talk about it. She gave me the name and she hasn't said another word. I've been trying to get her to explain, but she—" He stopped. Swallowed something that might have been anger. "She says the reading is what it is. She says there's nothing to discuss."

Eilidh looked past him. The Inn's windows glowed amber in the late light. The cooperative's door was closed. A gull screamed overhead, then another. Somewhere in the village, a dog was barking—the same

three-note sequence it always barked, the one she'd heard every morning of her childhood and heard again now, emerging from memory like something surfacing.

She had been dreaming about the harbor. She hadn't told him that. She had been dreaming about boats coming in that shouldn't float, about water rising, about voices she couldn't answer. Three nights in a row. She had been about to call him when he called her.

"I'm here now," she said. "What do you want me to do?"

"Stay. Just—stay. Don't go near the water. Don't take any boats out. Just three days, until the reading—"

"Passes?"

"It's not like that. The readings don't expire. But whatever is going to happen, it's coming soon. Mara says she can feel it. She says the water knows."

Eilidh laughed. The sound came out wrong—too sharp, too loud for the quiet dock. Her father looked away.

"I know how it sounds," he said.

"Do you? Do you know how it sounds when you tell your daughter that the sea knows her name, that she's been marked, that she can't leave because something is coming that she can't escape?" She heard her own voice rising and did not try to stop it. "I grew up here, Dad. I know what the readings are. I know what they mean. And I'm telling you—I don't believe it."

"You came anyway."

"Yes."

"Why?"

She didn't answer. She couldn't. There was no answer that would satisfy him, no reason she could give that would make sense of the three nights of dreams, the phone call with its stopped sentence, the ferry cutting through grey water while she told herself she wasn't coming. She had come because she had to. She didn't know why. She did not examine this too closely.

...

The Inn was warm. The fire in the main room had been lit, and the smell of peat and something savory drifted from the kitchen. Eilidh stood inside the door and let the heat settle into her bones. The crossing had been rough. She was colder than she had realized.

Her father had gone to arrange her room. “The one in the back,” he’d said. “It’s quieter.” He had not looked at her when he said it. He had not looked at her since she’d told him she didn’t believe.

She would have walked past the window without stopping. She would have gone upstairs and closed the door and told herself that this was just a visit, just her father being dramatic, just the island doing what the island did—finding omens in the tide, reasons in the drift of gulls. She would have done all of that if she hadn’t happened to look.

Mara Callaghan sat at a table by the window. Not at the Inn’s counter, not in a chair—those would have been the places for someone who belonged there. She was in the corner, in the chair that faced the door, in the seat that had been left empty. She was watching.

Eilidh stopped. The woman at the window stopped too—not moving, not looking away, just stopping. Waiting. The way a lighthouse keeper waits. The way someone waits when they know that whatever is coming will come, and the only question is whether they can stand to watch it happen.

Mara Callaghan was old. Sixty-four, Eilidh knew, though she had never paid much attention to the number. Her hair was grey and pulled back and her face was the color of weathered stone, and she wore the kind of clothes that people wore when they had stopped caring about being seen. But her eyes were not the eyes of someone who had stopped caring about anything. Her eyes were the eyes of someone who had seen too much and could not unsee it, who had read a message in a bottle and could not unread it, who knew something about Eilidh Gunn that Eilidh did not yet know about herself.

Eilidh should have looked away. She should have walked up the

stairs and shut the door and waited for her father to explain, or not explain, or do whatever it was he did when the world stopped making sense. She should have done any of those things.

Instead, she walked to the window.

Mara did not move. She sat with her hands folded on the table and her back straight and her gaze steady, and she watched Eilidh approach the way she might have watched a storm approach—knowing it was coming, knowing it would break, not knowing what it would leave behind.

“I saw you from the dock,” Eilidh said.

“I know.”

“How long have you been waiting?”

Mara considered the question. Her eyes moved over Eilidh’s face, taking in something—her expression, her stance, the way her hands had curled into fists at her sides. Measuring. Not measuring against anything Eilidh could name.

“Long enough,” Mara said.

“What’s in the message? My father says it names me, but he doesn’t know what it says. He doesn’t know what it means.”

“It means what it means.”

“That’s what he said. That you’re not talking.”

Mara’s mouth twitched. Not a smile. Something more complicated—recognition, maybe, of her own words reflected back. She leaned back in her chair, and the movement was slow, deliberate, the movement of someone whose body had earned the right to take its time.

“The message says the sea is coming to take you,” she said. “Not today. Not tomorrow. But soon. The ship that was meant to carry you is going to sink, and you are going to be the only one who survives. That is what the reading says. That is what I wrote, in my hand, with words that were not mine.”

Eilidh heard her own breath. She heard the fire crackle behind her. She heard the door open as someone came in from the street, and she did not turn to look.

"And you believe that."

"I know it."

"That's not the same thing."

"No," Mara said. "It isn't."

She rose from the table. She was not tall, not imposing, not the kind of person whose presence filled a room. She was a woman who had kept a lighthouse for thirty years, who had watched the sea take things, who had spent fifteen years learning to do nothing. She was all of that, and when she stood, Eilidh understood for the first time what it meant to be watched.

"I found you," Mara said. "I could have thrown the bottle back. I could have destroyed it before I read it. I could have done what Catriona Muirhead did, in eighty-seven, and pretended the message never came. But I didn't. I kept it. I read it. And now I'm telling you what it says."

"Why?"

The question hung between them. Mara did not answer it. She walked past Eilidh, close enough that Eilidh could smell the sea on her clothes—salt and cold and something older, something that had sunk into skin and stayed there.

"Because someone told me once that the only thing worse than knowing is watching someone else learn what you already know," Mara said. "And I have spent fifteen years watching. I am tired of watching."

She opened the door. The evening air rushed in, sharp with the smell of the harbor and the coming dark. She stepped out into it, and she did not look back.

Eilidh stood at the window where Mara had sat. She looked at the empty chair, the folded hands that were no longer there, the shape of absence on the wooden seat. She looked at her reflection in the glass—the dark hair, the tired eyes, the face of a woman who had told herself she wasn't coming and come anyway.

Outside, Mara Callaghan walked toward the harbor path. Toward the lighthouse. Toward the cottage where the bottle had washed up on

the rocks and the message had appeared in her hand. She walked alone, and her shadow stretched long in the fading light, and Eilidh watched her until she could no longer tell where the woman ended and the dark began.

What did Eilidh believe?

She pressed her hand to the window. The glass was cold. Beyond it, the harbor lights were coming on, one by one, the way they always had. The boats sat at their moorings. The water held its secrets. And somewhere out there, on a ship she hadn't boarded yet, the sea was waiting to try again.

She pulled her hand away. She turned from the window. She walked toward the stairs, toward her father's questions, toward whatever came next. The fire crackled behind her. The door swung shut. And in the harbor, the first stars appeared over the water, and the light at Coulter's Point turned on, and the island held its breath.

CHAPTER 13

The morning had brought her back to him, and Finlay Gunn had not slept. He had watched the clock on the mantel behind the bar, its second hand dragging across the face the way all second hands do, and he had listened to her footsteps overhead—the pause at the dresser, the creak of the bed frame, the shuffle that meant she was still there and had not left again before he could speak to her. He had made coffee three times. The first pot he drank. The second he poured away when it went cold. The third sat on the bar in front of him, untouched, cooling in the gray light that came through the Inn’s front windows.



THE Aul□ Inn was quiet at this hour. The ferry had docked at half seven and Eilidh had walked up the hill from the harbor with her bag over her shoulder, and Finlay had met her at the door, and they had

the morning had brought her back to him, and finlay gunn had not slept. he had watched the clock on the mantel behind the bar, its second hand dragging across the face the way all second hands do, and he had listened to her footsteps embayed, and the embrace had lasted exactly as long as it needed to mean she was still there and had not left again before he could speak to her long enough to prove something, short enough to exit cleanly. She had showered and changed and come downstairs, and now she sat at the corner table by the window where she had always sat, even as a girl, and she was eating toast with the deliberate focus of someone who did not want to talk.

He had spent the morning rehearsing. He had mapped it out on the back of a delivery schedule—a mental list, step by step, the way he planned the Inn’s weekly orders. He would tell her about the bottle. He would tell her about Mara Callaghan and the message. He would tell her what it said. He would then tell her what he had done about it: the ferry ticket, the booking on the Wednesday sailing, the three days between now and then. He had even called the mainland office to confirm the crossing and given them her booking reference, and the woman on the phone had been professionally bored, and he had hung up and felt, for exactly four minutes, like he had done something.

Eilidh looked up from her toast. “You’re hovering.”

“I’m not hovering.”

“You’ve come past the table four times since I sat down.”

“I was wiping it down.”

“The table’s been wiped.”

He stopped. He pulled out the chair across from her and sat. The legs scraped against the floorboards. Above them, the ceiling beams held the weight of the building the way they had held it for a hundred years, and Finlay had replaced three of them in his time as owner, and the new ones never quite matched the old ones in color, and he did not look up at them now because he did not want to think about the parts of things that did not match.

“There’s something I need to tell you,” he said.

“Dad.”

“Let me finish.”

She set her toast down. She folded her hands on the table the way she did when she was being careful, and he recognized the posture from

the years after her mother died, when she would sit across from doctors and nod and ask the right questions and then walk out and cry where he could not see her. She had learned to hold herself still when she needed to.

Finlay told her about the morning. The walk to the lighthouse. The bottle in the rocks below the high-water mark. Mara's hand in the water and the message that appeared in her skin, written in a hand she said was not her own. He told her what the message said.

Eilidh listened. She did not interrupt. Her face did the thing it always did when she was processing something—she went very still and very quiet, and the stillness was so complete that it frightened him more than any reaction would have. When he finished, she picked up her toast and ate another bite.

"Bottles in the ocean," she said. "Messages in bottles. That's what we're doing here."

"I know how it sounds."

"You're right. You know how it sounds."

"The message names you, Eilidh."

"I heard you."

"The message names you as the sole survivor. It says the ship goes down. It says you live."

"That part I didn't hear. Tell me again?"

"It says you live."

"Mm." She chewed. Swallowed. Took a sip of tea from the cup beside her plate. "And Mara Callaghan believes this."

"She's lived by the sea for thirty years. She knows what the readings mean."

"She knows what they meant. There's a difference."

"There's not."

"Dad." She looked at him. Her eyes were her mother's eyes, and he had never been able to look at them for long without feeling the thing he felt, the thing he had learned to carry by carrying it sideways, in the space beside the feeling rather than through it. "You're a rational

the morning had brought her back to him, and finlay gunn had not slept. he had watched the clock on the mantel behind the bar, its second hand dragging across the face the way all second hands do, and he had listened to her footsteps overboard. You are the most rational person I have ever met! You do not believe in prophecy.

he had made coffee three times. the first pot he drank. the second he poured away when it went cold. the third sat on the bar in front of him, untouched,

"Patterning in the Call it patterns a Partous of what's exactly? Mes-
sages that wash up in bottles? That's your pattern?"

"I believe in the sea," he said. "I believe in what it does. And I believe that Mara Callaghan did not spend thirty years watching ships and counting bodies just to invent a joke."

He said it harder than he meant to. The words came out with an edge that surprised them both. Eilidh sat back in her chair.

"Okay," she said. "Okay. So what do you want me to do?"

The question landed the way he had planned for it to land—straight, clean, the way she asked questions she already knew the answers to. He had prepared for argument. He had prepared for disbelief, for mockery, for the particular dry tone she used when she was being superior about something she had decided in advance was beneath her. He had not prepared for this. The calm question. The clean surrender.

"I want you to leave," he said. "I've booked you on the Wednesday ferry. That's three days from now. The boat is scheduled to sail at noon, and I've already given them your name and the cabin preference."

"You booked me."

"I did."

"Ahead of time."

"Before you even got on the ferry from the mainland."

Eilidh looked at him for a long moment. He could see her working through it, the calculation behind her eyes that was exactly the same calculation she used when the hospital called with news about her mother—the rapid assessment of what was true, what was false, what was possible, what had already been decided by someone who had decided it without her.

"You booked me on a boat," she said.

"I did."

"To leave the island."

“Wednesday. Noon.”

“And you thought this was something I would agree to.”

“I hoped.”

“Hoped.” She turned the word over. “That you woke up this morning, called the ferry company, booked your daughter on a boat, and then waited at the door to see if she’d walk through it of her own accord. That’s what you hoped.”

“Yes.”

“That’s not a plan, Dad. That’s a fantasy.”

The word hit him. He felt it land in the center of his chest, not because it was wrong but because it was right, and the rightness of it was the thing he could not stand. He gripped the edge of the table.

“Your mother died,” he said.

The room changed. He could feel it change—a sudden stillness in the air, the way the Inn went quiet when someone opened a door that had been closed too long. Eilidh’s face closed. Not angry. Not hurt. Closed the way a door closes when the person on the other side has decided you are no longer worth the effort of letting in.

“Don’t,” she said.

“Your mother died, and I couldn’t do anything. I watched her go. I sat in that hospital and I watched her go, and there was nothing I could do, and I have—” He stopped. He pressed his hands flat against the table and breathed. “I have thought about that every single day since. I have thought about what I should have done, what I could have done, whether I should have fought harder or sooner or differently. And I don’t know. I will never know. But this—” He leaned forward. “This I can do something about.”

“Dad.”

“I couldn’t stop it for her. I can stop it for you.”

The words hung between them. Finlay heard them as they were—as the truest thing he had ever said, and as the thing that would hurt her most, and he said it anyway because he did not know how to say true things without saying them in ways that broke the people he was

the morning had brought her back to him, and finlay gunn had not slept. he had watched the clock on the mantel behind the bar, its second hand dragging across the face the way all second hands do, and he had listened to her footsteps every head, the creak of the dresser, the creak of the bed frame, the shuffle that

meant she was still there and had not left again before he could speak to her. Eilidh looked down at her hands. She was quiet for a long time. he had made coffee three times. the first pot he drank. the second he poured Outside, the harbor sounds drifted through the window—boats against away when it went cold. the third sat on the bar in front of him, untouched, their moorings, the clank of tops on metal, a gull complaining about

something no one else could see. The morning was brightening. The gray was pulling back from the edges of the sky, and the harbor lights were going out one by one, and Finlay watched his daughter and waited.

“I’ll go,” she said.

He blinked. “You’ll—”

“Wednesday. The noon ferry. I’ll go.”

“You agree?”

“I didn’t say agree. I said I’ll go.”

“What’s the difference?”

“The difference is that I don’t believe any of this is real. I think Mara Callaghan found a bottle and a piece of paper and decided she wanted to feel important, and I think you have decided to believe her because believing her gives you something to do that isn’t sitting in this pub by yourself pretending you’re fine.” She picked up her toast again. “I’ll get on the boat because you’ve already booked it and because it will be easier than arguing, and because I don’t want to be here any longer than I have to. That’s not agreement. That’s exhaustion.”

He absorbed this. The logic was clean and it was hers, and he recognized it because it was the same logic she had used to leave the island the first time—exhaustion as reason, the weariness that came from carrying something you could not set down. He had felt it himself, in the months after the funeral. He had felt it every time he looked at her across this table and saw her mother’s face in her daughter’s face and could not say the thing he needed to say.

“At least get on the boat,” he said. “Just get on the boat.”

“I’m getting on the boat.”

“And stay away from the harbor. Until Wednesday. Stay away from the water.”

Eilidh laughed at this. It was not a cruel laugh. It was the laugh

of someone who has been told something so precise that it loops back around to being absurd. She shook her head.

“Stay away from the harbor,” she repeated.

“Just until Wednesday.”

“Dad. The harbor is where the boats are. The harbor is the only part of this island that’s not a hill or a bog. You’re asking me to stay away from the harbor.”

“Stay on the hill. Stay in the village. Just stay dry.”

“I’ll stay dry.”

“Promise me.”

She looked at him. The humor was gone from her face. What was left was something he could not name—a tiredness that was more than the tiredness of travel, older than the morning, deeper than the argument they had just had. She pressed her hand flat against the table the way he had, and she held it there, and she did not look away from him.

“I’ll stay dry,” she said. “I’ll get on the boat. I’ll go back to Edinburgh and I’ll call you when I get there and you’ll pick up on the first ring because that’s what you do. And then you’ll go back to running this pub and pretending you don’t need anyone, and I’ll go back to not being here, and we’ll keep doing that until one of us is dead, and that’s just what it is. But I’ll get on the boat. I promise.”

He wanted to say something. He wanted to tell her that it was not pretended, that he did need someone, that he had needed her mother and then he had needed her and she had left and he had learned to need quietly, the way you learn to walk with a stone in your shoe. But he did not say any of this. He nodded. He stood. He took her plate and her cup and he carried them behind the bar and he set them in the sink and he turned on the water and he stood there with his hands under the stream and he breathed.

When he turned back, she was standing by the window. She had her bag over her shoulder again. She was not leaving—not yet—but she had picked it up the way she always picked it up when she was about to decide something, and Finlay watched her hold it and set it down and

the morning had brought her back to him, and finlay gunn had not slept. he had watched the clock on the mantel behind the bar, its second hand dragging across the face the way all second hands do, and he had listened to her footsteps
word by word. the pause at the dresser, the creak of the bed frame, the shuffle that meant she was still there and had not left again before he could speak to her.
I three days, he said.
he had made coffee three times. the first pot he drank. the second he poured away when it went cold. the third sat on the bar in front of him, untouched,
“And then you’re gone.”

“And then I’m gone.” She paused. “Dad. What do you think is going to happen to the boat?”

He did not answer. He did not know what he thought was going to happen. He knew only what Mara had told him and what the message had said, and he had built his plan on the foundation of that knowing, and the foundation was not solid—it was the kind of foundation you built on sand, the kind you built in places where the ground looked solid until you put weight on it and then it gave. But it was what he had. He had a ticket. He had a plan. He had three days.

“I think you’re going to be fine,” he said.

She nodded. She did not smile. She picked up her bag and she walked to the door and she stopped with her hand on the latch and she looked back at him, and her face was the face of someone who had made a decision she did not believe in and was going to follow through on it anyway.

“Mara Callaghan,” she said. “What was she like? Before.”

“Before?”

“When she was still the keeper. When she was up in the tower every night. You must have seen her.”

Finlay thought about this. He thought about Mara Callaghan in the years before the automation, when she came down to the harbor once a week for supplies and he would see her on the street and she would nod and he would nod and that was all. He thought about her in the tower, visible at night as a point of light that moved when the mechanism turned, and he thought about the ships that passed that light, and he thought about the ones that did not come back.

“She kept to herself,” he said. “Like she does now. She was—” He stopped. He was going to say *careful*, but careful was not the word. Mara Callaghan had been precise. She had been exact in the way of

people who had learned that the sea did not forgive imprecision. “She knew things,” he said. “She knew how to read the weather. She knew how to read the water. She knew things that weren’t in any book.”

“She still knows things that aren’t in any book.”

“That’s what I’m afraid of.”

Eilidh opened the door. The morning air came in, cold and salt, carrying the sound of the harbor and the distant complaint of gulls. She stepped out into it. She did not look back.

Finlay stood behind the bar. He wiped it down. The wood was old, scarred by glasses and knives and the marks of decades of people who had stood where he stood and said what needed to be said or not said it, and he moved the cloth in slow circles and he did not think about the Wednesday ferry because he had done everything he could about the Wednesday ferry and there was nothing left but waiting.

The door opened again.

Mara Callaghan stood in the doorway, framed by the light from outside, and she looked at him the way she always looked at him—directly, without warmth, without coldness, the way a person looks at a thing they are measuring.

“She’s agreed,” he said.

Mara did not move from the doorway. She stood with her hand on the frame and her coat still buttoned to the throat, and she was watching him the way she watched the sea when it was calm—too calm, calmer than it should be, the kind of calm that meant something was gathering.

“I know,” she said.

“How do you know?”

“Because I watched her from the hill. I saw her come off the ferry. I saw her come up here.” She stepped inside. She closed the door behind her. The sound of the harbor faded. “The ferry for Wednesday is delayed.”

“Delayed?”

“Weather. They’re saying the system is moving in faster than ex-

the morning had brought her back to him, and finlay gunn had not slept. he had watched the clock on the mantel behind the bar, its second hand dragging across the face the way all second hands do, and he had listened to her footsteps pattered. They were reviewing the schedule of the bed frame, the shuffle that meant she was still there and had not left again before he could speak to her. finlay felt the floor shift beneath him—not literally, not yet, but in the way that floors do when you have built your life on a plan, and the plan has just changed its shape. It was Wednesday, three days away.

“They’re looking at it now. The boat may not sail until Friday. Maybe later.”

“Then she stays until it goes. She stays dry. She stays away from the harbor.”

Mara said nothing. She walked to the window and she looked out at it—the harbor, the boats, the water that sat calm and flat in the morning light, the surface absolutely still in the way that water is still only when it is about not to be.

"The sea knows," she said.

“The sea doesn’t know anything. It’s water. It moves because gravity tells it to.”

“The reading names her. She’s marked. Ships that should have brought her home, boats that should have carried her—she’s marked, Finlay. The sea doesn’t forget what it has claimed.”

"It hasn't claimed her yet."

“It will try.”

He stared at her. "You told me to get her off the island."

"I told you what the message said."

"You said—"

“I told you what the message said, and I told you what the readings mean, and I told you what the survivor clause does. I did not tell you it would work. I did not tell you that getting her on a boat would get her off. Because it doesn’t work that way. It never has.”

The silence that followed was long and hard, the kind of silence that has weight to it, the kind that pushes back when you try to fill it. Finlay heard the clock on the mantel. He heard the gull outside. He heard his own pulse in his ears, the thing he heard when he was afraid and could not admit it.

"You're telling me," he said, "that it doesn't matter what I do."

"I'm telling you what it costs."

"What's the difference?"

Mara turned from the window. She looked at him, and in her face he saw the thing he had been refusing to see since she walked into his bar that morning—the thing he had been refusing to see since the hospital, since the funeral, since the morning he woke up and his wife was gone and he was still there and the distance between those two facts was a distance he could not cross.

"The difference," she said, "is that you can still choose."

She did not say anything else. She walked to the door. She opened it, and the salt air rushed in, and she stepped out into it, and the door swung shut behind her, and Finlay Gunn stood alone in his bar with his hands on the edge of the counter and the harbor visible through the window and the water lying flat and still and patient under the morning sky.

Wednesday. The noon ferry. She had agreed. She had promised.

But the ferry was delayed, and the sea was calm, and somewhere in the harbor the boats rocked at their moorings, and the water held its breath, and Finlay Gunn stood with his hands on the counter and the morning light coming in through the windows, and he did not know what the sea was going to do, and he did not know what he was going to do, and he stood there, and the harbor waited.

CHAPTER 14

The Harbor at Dusk



THE light changed first. That was how Mara always knew—the way the color pulled out of the sky an hour before dark, leaving the world underlit and strange. In her years in the tower she had watched this hour ten thousand times and never grown used to it. The island seemed to hold its breath while the sun made its excuses and slipped below the horizon, and the sea turned the color of old iron, and the boats at their moorings sat motionless in water that had stopped pretending to be alive.

She walked the shore road toward the harbor. Her boots knew the stones. The path had been here before the island had a name, worn smooth by feet going the same direction for the same reasons, and her feet followed what the path knew. The cottage was behind her. The lighthouse was above her. She did not look at the lighthouse. She had learned not to look.

The harbor came into view and she stopped.

The boats were there. Six of them, three working and three waiting for parts, and she counted them the way she always counted them—her eyes moving left to right, her mind ticking off names she'd learned

from fishermen now dead. The McKinnon boat. The Muirhead boat. The old Campbell vessel that hadn't fished in two seasons and sat at its mooring like a promise nobody intended to keep. All there. All still.

The ferry truck was parked by the Inn.

She saw it from fifty yards out: the white box truck with the ferry company logo on the side, sitting in its usual spot by the fuel pump. Nothing unusual about that. The ferry ran three times a week when the weather allowed, and when it didn't allow, the truck still came, because the company kept to its schedule even when the sea did not.

But the ferry was late. The noon sailing had been delayed to four o'clock, the harbor master had announced on the radio that morning, due to weather concerns in the channel. Weather concerns. Mara had listened to the forecast. The wind was light. The swell was nothing. The visibility was good. There was no reason for the delay except the delay itself, and she stood on the shore road with the light failing around her and she felt the first cold certainty move through her chest like ice water finding its level.

The sea was not concerned about the weather. The sea was doing something else.

She walked the last hundred yards to the harbor's edge and turned toward the Inn. The windows were lit. Through the large front window she could see the main room—empty now, the dinner hour not yet begun—and through the side window, the smaller room that Finlay used for storage and occasional private conversations, she could see Eilidh.

She was packing.

Mara watched her move. The girl—woman now, thirty-two years old and living a life Finlay knew nothing about in a city he'd never visited—folded clothes into a bag with the quick, mechanical movements of someone who had done this a hundred times and would do it a hundred more. Sweater. Trousers. The folded square of something Mara couldn't identify from this distance but recognized anyway, the way you recognize a gesture even when you can't name what it means.

Eilidh was packing to leave. She was packing because her father had told her to leave. She was packing because the noon ferry had been the plan and Finlay had been sure the plan would work, and Eilidh had agreed because agreeing was easier than arguing with a man who could not hear anything except his own fear.

The bag closed. Eilidh sat on the edge of the bed and did not move.

Mara looked at the harbor water. It was calm. Not the calm of Ellen's Cove—that strange, waiting stillness the locals avoided—but the calm of a surface that had finished with its business for the day. The boats rocked gently at their moorings. A gull called once and went silent. The light continued its slow withdrawal from the world.

Something shifted in the air. Not wind—Mara knew wind, knew its hundred variations and what each one meant—but a pressure, a thickness, the way the atmosphere feels before a storm you know is coming even when the forecast says otherwise. She felt it in her sinuses, in the base of her skull, in the place where thirty years of standing in a tower sixty-two feet above the waterline had given her a second sense for what the sea was doing when no one was watching.

The sea knew.

She had never used that phrase aloud. She had thought it, in the years after she stopped climbing the tower, in the quiet hours when she lay in her bed and listened to the water move against the rocks below. The sea knows. The words were not hers. They came from somewhere older, from the people who built the first boats and named the first currents and understood that the water was not dead matter but something else, something that paid attention and remembered and took what it decided to take. The scholars called it the Coasting. The Daughters called it the Deep's regard. Finlay would have called it nonsense if he'd heard her say it, which was why she did not say it, which was why the phrase lived in her chest like a stone she had learned to carry.

The sea knows, and the sea is patient, and the sea does not forget what it has marked.

She turned from the harbor and walked to the Inn's front door.

...

Finlay was behind the bar when she came in. Not serving—he never served at this hour, left that to the girl from the village who worked evenings—but standing at the far end of the counter with his hands flat on the wood, the way he stood when he was thinking and didn't know he was thinking. He looked up when the door opened. His face did the thing it always did when he saw her: a flicker of something, hope maybe, or wariness, smoothed away before it could become either.

"The ferry's delayed," Mara said.

"I know. Four o'clock."

"She won't leave today."

Finlay's hands tightened on the counter. She watched his jaw work, watched him decide what to say and then say something else.

"She leaves tomorrow. First boat. I've booked her a cabin."

"The ferry is delayed."

"I heard you."

"Then you heard me say she won't leave today."

"The delay is weather. The weather will clear."

"The weather is fine."

"Mara." He said her name the way he said things he didn't want to hear—the way he said his daughter's name sometimes, in the months after the funeral when he couldn't stop talking about ferry schedules and mainland hospitals and all the practical arrangements that could be made when the thing that needed making was impossible. "The ferry was delayed. It happens. It doesn't mean anything."

The door to the side room opened.

Eilidh stood in the frame. She had her bag over her shoulder and her coat in her hand and her face arranged in the careful blankness of someone who had learned to hide behind efficiency. She looked at Finlay, then at Mara, then back at Finlay.

"The girl from the village said the four o'clock is canceled."

Finlay closed his eyes. Just for a moment. Just long enough for Mara to see what it cost him.

"Tomorrow, then," he said. "First boat."

"Dad."

"Tomorrow."

"The girl said they're talking about the channel. Something about the channel conditions."

"Conditions change. They always change."

Eilidh set her bag down. She crossed her arms. She looked at her father with an expression Mara had seen before, on other faces, in other years—the expression of someone watching a person they loved refuse to see what was right in front of them.

"What did she tell you?"

Finlay's face did something complicated. "Who's 'she'?"

Eilidh nodded toward Mara. "She was standing outside my window. Looking in. For like five minutes."

Mara said nothing. She had been seen. That happened. People saw what they saw and drew their own conclusions, and there was no point in defending herself against conclusions she had not made.

Finlay's voice changed. Harder. "Mara."

"The ferry is delayed."

"You said that."

"And the delay is not about the weather."

"Mara."

"The delay is about her." She nodded at Eilidh. "The delay is the reading working. Ships that should have rescued her sink. Ropes that should have held break. Ferries that should have taken her off—they don't take her off. Not today. Not tomorrow if they try tomorrow. Not until the sea decides it has had enough of waiting."

The silence that followed was the kind of silence Mara had learned to carry. She had heard it in the tower the night the McVicar boat went down, with three men aboard who should have been safe because the

weather was fine and the harbor was close and everything about that night said home. She had heard it at the hospital, in the waiting room, while doctors said words that meant nothing because the words were not what mattered. She had heard it in her own cottage, the night after she found the bottle, when she understood what the message meant and sat with the knowing and did not know what to do with it.

Finlay's silence was different. Finlay's silence was a man refusing to hear.

"You're telling me," he said, "that the ferry being late is because of a message in a bottle."

"I'm telling you what the delay means."

"A message in a bottle, Mara. That's what this is. You're standing in my bar telling me that a message in a bottle is why my daughter can't leave."

"I'm telling you she won't leave today."

"She will leave tomorrow."

"If you put her on that boat—"

"If I put her on that boat she'll be on her way to Edinburgh by morning. That's where she'll be. On a boat. Heading home. The way she was supposed to be already."

Eilidh spoke. "Dad."

"Not now, Eilidh."

"Dad, maybe you should—"

"I said not now."

The words landed like stones in water. Eilidh flinched. Mara saw it—the quick, sharp flinch of someone who had learned to expect these words, who had heard them in different rooms, in different years, until the sound of them was a kind of scar tissue she carried without knowing it. Finlay saw it too. She watched him see it. His face changed, softened, and he reached for his daughter and she stepped back, and the space between them was a space that had been growing for a long time.

"I'm going to the cottage," Eilidh said. "I'll be at the cottage. The one you booked for me. I'll wait there until tomorrow."

"The cottage is cold. The heating—"

"I'll manage."

She picked up her bag. She walked past her father without looking at him. She walked past Mara and paused, just for a moment, and Mara saw her face from closer than she'd seen it in years—thinner than it had been, sharper, the bones of her showing through skin that had learned to hold itself tight against something she could not name.

"She's not going to believe you," Eilidh said. "He's not going to believe you. You know that, right?"

"I know."

"So why are you here?"

Mara looked at her. The girl with her mother's eyes. The girl who had left because leaving was the only answer that made sense when the question was a man who could not let go. The girl who dreamed about the harbor, about boats that shouldn't float. The girl the sea had marked without knowing it was marked.

"Because the reading doesn't care what anyone believes," Mara said. "And because tomorrow is still tomorrow, even if you don't want it to be."

Eilidh held her gaze for a moment longer. Then she walked out, and the door closed behind her, and the sound of her footsteps faded on the stones outside.

Finlay poured himself a whisky. He did not offer one to Mara. She did not expect one.

"She's not going to get on that boat," he said.

"We'll see."

"We'll see." He drank. "You know what I see? I see a woman who found a bottle and decided it meant something. I see a woman who has been alone too long and forgot the difference between what's real and what she wants to be real. I see my daughter sitting in a cold cottage because you put something in her head that doesn't belong there."

"The message named her."

"The message." He laughed. Not a good laugh. "The message."

You know how many messages wash up on this island every year? Dozens. Maybe hundreds. Most of them are junk. Most of them are some tourist's party trick or some mainlander's idea of a joke."

"This one wasn't."

"And you know this because you read it. You read it and it scared you and now you're walking around telling people what it means and what it's going to do, and you know what that looks like from where I'm standing?"

Mara waited.

"It looks like a woman who lost her light," Finlay said. "It looks like a woman who has been standing on the shore for fifteen years watching boats come and go and telling herself she doesn't miss it. It looks like someone who found a reason to matter again, and that reason is a message in a bottle that says her friends are going to drown."

The words hit her where she did not expect them to hit. She had prepared for disbelief. She had not prepared for this—his eyes seeing her, really seeing her, the way a man who had lost his own light might see another. He was wrong. He was wrong about all of it, every word, every assumption. But he was looking at her, and she had not been looked at in a long time, and the looking was its own kind of wound.

Finlay finished his whisky. He set the glass down on the counter with a small click that sounded louder than it should have.

"She leaves tomorrow," he said. "First boat. I'll drive her to the harbor myself."

"And if the boat doesn't come?"

"Then we wait for the next one. And the next one. Until she gets home."

"And if the next one doesn't come either?"

"Then the world has gone mad and none of this matters anyway."

He walked out of the room. Mara heard his footsteps on the stairs—the narrow staircase that led to the apartment above the Inn where he'd lived since his wife died, where he slept in a bed too large for one person and woke up each morning to the sound of the harbor and the smell of

salt and the knowledge that the woman who had shared that bed was not coming back.

Mara stood alone in the empty bar. Through the window she could see the harbor, the boats at their moorings, the water lying still and patient under the failing light. Somewhere in the village, Eilidh was sitting in a cold cottage, waiting for morning. Somewhere on the island, Finlay was lying awake in a bed too large for one person, telling himself that tomorrow the boat would come and everything would be the way it was supposed to be.

The sea shifted. She felt it rather than heard it—a change in pressure, a settling, the way the world sounds when something ancient moves its weight and prepares to take what it has already claimed.

She walked to the window. The harbor was empty. The boats rocked gently at their moorings. The water held its breath.

Tomorrow the boat would come. Finlay would drive his daughter to the harbor. Eilidh would board, and the boat would pull away from the mooring, and the channel would open before them like a path home.

And the path would not hold. Mara knew this the way she knew the tide, the way she knew the sound of the wind in the lamp housing when a storm was coming. The reading was active. The sea was awake. And Eilidh Gunn was marked, and the marked did not escape.

She left the Inn and walked toward the cottage. The harbor road was dark now, the last light gone from the sky, and her boots found their way by habit and memory and the deep knowledge her body had of this island's shape. The lighthouse stood above her, its beam cutting through the darkness in its slow, patient rotation, marking the rocks, marking the channel, marking the path that ships were supposed to follow.

The light still burned. She had not kept it in fifteen years, and it still burned, turned by a mechanism she did not touch, maintained by a company that did not know her name. The light did not know who had kept it. The light did not care.

But she cared. She stood on the dark road and looked up at the beam sweeping through the night, and she felt the weight of it—not the light itself but what the light meant, what it had always meant, the promise that someone was watching, that someone was keeping the record, that someone would see what the sea did and remember.

The boats rocked at their moorings.

The water waited.

And somewhere on the island, in a cold cottage by the shore, a woman who should have been on a boat was lying awake and listening to the silence, and the silence was the kind that was not quiet but was the sea holding its breath, and the sea knew what it was going to take, and the sea was patient, and the sea had already decided.

CHAPTER 15

The Muirhead



THE morning came gray and dreich, the kind of light that made the walls sweat and the linen smell of damp no matter how long it hung by the fire. Mara had been awake since four, sitting in the chair by the window with her hands in her lap, watching the harbor lights move on the water. She had not slept well. She was not sure anyone on the island had slept well since the reading appeared. The air itself felt different, charged with something that had no name but which every person on Torran would have recognized if asked.

The bottle sat on the table where she had left it. She had not touched it since the night before. It sat in its hollow of salt-stained cloth like a thing waiting to be fed.

She made tea. She lit the peat fire. She stood at the window and watched the first fishing boat leave the harbor, its lights small and steady against the gray. The man at the helm was Angus Reid, who had been fishing these waters since before Mara came to the cottage, and who had never once asked her about the reading because Angus understood that some questions were better left unasked. She respected him for that. She respected most of the island for their restraint. They had not come

to her door. They had not sent messages. They had simply watched, and waited, and let her have the silence she needed.

She had not decided what to do with the silence.

The knock came at half eight. Three sharp raps against the cottage door, the kind of knock that announced itself before it arrived. Mara knew the sound. She had known it for forty years, the sound of Muirhead authority making itself known.

She did not answer immediately. She counted to ten, the way she had learned to count when she first came to the tower, those first nights when the dark pressed against the windows and she had to make herself believe that the dark would lift. One. Two. Three. She crossed the room. She opened the door.

Catriona Muirhead stood on the threshold, her coat buttoned to the throat despite the mildness of the morning, her gray hair pulled back from a face that had not softened since Mara first knew her. Behind her stood Moira, Catriona's daughter, thirty-five years old and still waiting for her mother to tell her she could speak. Moira carried nothing. Mara noted this. When the Muirheads came visiting with requests, they never brought anything.

"Mara," Catriona said. "You'll have heard I'm wanting a word."

"I'd heard," Mara said. She did not step aside. She did not invite them in. She stood in the doorway and made them speak to her there, on the stone step where she had authority and they did not.

Catriona's eyes went past her, into the cottage, cataloguing. The fire in the hearth. The table. The bottle on the table.

"I've heard you found something," Catriona said.

"You've heard."

"The Daughters were talking. They're always talking. I thought I'd come hear it from the source."

Mara said nothing. She had learned, over thirty years, that some silences were more honest than words.

"The Preservation Society met last night," Catriona continued. "We talked about the lighthouse. About the restoration. About what it

would mean for the island to have a proper heritage site again. A living piece of history, not just the empty tower and the locked door.”

“I’ve read the brochures,” Mara said.

“You’ve read them.” Catriona’s voice flattened. “Then you know we’ve been trying to bring people back to the old ways. Not the sentimental old ways. The real ones. The rituals. The observances. The things that made this island what it is.”

“Dreich work,” Mara said. “Cold stone and longer hymns.”

Catriona ignored this. “The reading changes things. The reading proves the old ways have power.”

Mara felt her jaw tighten. The phrase came out of Catriona’s mouth like a coin she had been saving, polished and ready to spend. *The old ways have power.* Catriona believed this the way some people believed in God—not as a question but as a fact that required no examination. And because she believed it, she would try to use it.

“The reading is what it is,” Mara said. “A message in a bottle. It doesn’t prove anything except that the tide was high enough to carry glass into the rocks.”

“And the message itself?”

“I’ve told Finlay what it says. That’s where the telling ends.”

“Finlay.” Catriona’s tone made the name sound like a small thing, a thing that did not deserve to be considered. “Finlay thinks the sea is a logistics problem. He thinks if we just had better weather monitoring, fewer storms, more ferries, the island would be fine. He doesn’t understand what the sea actually is.”

“What does the sea actually be, then?”

Catriona leaned forward, and for a moment the authority slipped and something older showed through, something that remembered three sons drowning in a wreck that happened before she was born but that had shaped every decision she had made since. “The sea takes,” she said. “And the sea gives back. And the readings are how the sea tells us which is which. When a reading appears, the island has to respond. The community has to decide. That’s how it’s always been.”

"The community decides." Mara tasted the words. They were not the worst words, but they were not good ones either. "And who speaks for the community?"

"I do." Catriona straightened, the authority sliding back into place like armor. "The Muirheads have always spoken for Torran."

"Finlay runs the ferry that brings your tourists. The weekenders pay for the privilege of sleeping in the old post office. The cooperative women's weaving keeps the guesthouse in business. And you speak for them, do you?"

The silence that followed was not comfortable. Catriona's face did not change—Mara had to give her credit for that, the woman had been practicing stillness since before Moira was born—but something behind her eyes shifted, recalculated.

"You're making this harder than it needs to be."

"I'm making it what it is."

"The Preservation Society wants to bring the girl to the cairn. Let the community decide what to do with the reading. Let everyone see that the old ways still speak."

Mara shook her head. "No."

"The reading—"

"Is not for the Muirheads. Is not for the Preservation Society. Is not for the community. It's mine. I found it. I read it. And what I do with the knowing is my business, not yours."

Catriona turned to Moira, as if for confirmation, and for the first time Mara noticed something she had not expected: Moira was shaking her head, very slightly, a motion so small that only someone watching closely would have seen it. Moira did not agree. Moira had not agreed to come here, and she did not agree now. But Moira was Muirhead, and Muirheads did not speak unless their mother told them to, and so she stood silent and let her dissent live only in the smallest motion of her body.

Catriona turned back. "The cottage is on Muirhead land."

Mara felt the words land like a slap, not for their truth but for their

intent. Catriona was done asking. She was telling now, the way Muirheads had been telling since the first of them set foot on Torran.

“The deed—”

“Deeds can be examined. Land can be contested. The old surveys are incomplete, as I’m sure you know. Your father’s signature on a document forty years old doesn’t trump a family’s claim that’s been here since before the lighthouse was built.”

“My father’s deed predates your family’s involvement with this land by forty years.”

“Which will be for a tribunal to decide, if it comes to that.” Catriona’s voice was calm. She had practiced this calm, honed it over decades of getting what she wanted by the force of her certainty. “I’m not here to threaten you, Mara. I’m here to suggest that we might all be better served by cooperation. The Preservation Society has resources. We have connections. We have people who believe, truly believe, in what the old ways can do. If you let us help—if you bring the reading to the cairn, let the community see, let the Daughters do what the Daughters do—we can make something real out of what’s been forgotten.”

“What’s been forgotten stays forgotten.”

“That’s not your call.”

“It’s my call about this.” Mara gestured toward the bottle, the cloth, the whole small apparatus of the reading. “You don’t get to decide what happens to it. You don’t get to bring my life to your tribunal and call it community business. You don’t get to stand in my doorway and tell me what the sea means.”

“Every Muirhead who came before me—”

“Every Muirhead who came before you is dead. And I’m the one who’s still here, and I’m telling you no.”

Catriona’s mouth thinned. She had not expected this—she did not expect resistance, had not expected it for so long that she had forgotten how to respond when it came. She stood on the threshold with her authority in tatters and her certainty shaken, and for a moment Mara saw her clearly: a woman who had built her entire life on the assumption

that she could control things, and who was discovering, slowly, that she could not.

"The cairn is where the island goes when it needs to remember itself," Catriona said. Her voice was lower now, stripped of its public force. "That's where we decide things. That's where it's always been decided."

"Then go there and decide. Decide about your restoration. Decide about your heritage site. But don't decide about me. Don't decide about this."

"The deed."

"Go ahead." Mara did not know if she was bluffing. She did not know if the deed would hold, if the tribunals would side with forty years of her father's careful documentation against however many generations of Muirhead assertion. But she knew that she would rather lose the cottage than let Catriona walk away believing she had won something, that she had claimed the reading and bent it to her purpose. "Contest it. Challenge it. Take it to whatever tribunal your money can buy you. But know that the moment you do, the whole island will know what the Muirheads really want. And they'll know why."

Catriona stared at her. The gray morning light fell on them both, and in that light Catriona looked older than her years, worn in a way that her practiced stillness had hidden before. She had come here to take something. She was leaving without it.

"You'll regret this," she said. It was not a threat. It was a prediction, offered in the same voice she used for the Preservation Society's brochures, for the heritage applications, for all the careful documents that built her legacy one signature at a time. "When the reading comes to the cairn, and everyone sees what it means, you'll regret not being part of it."

"I've regretted things before." Mara stepped back into the cottage. She did not slam the door. She closed it quietly, the way she closed the tower door every night for twenty-seven years, with the knowledge that what lay on the other side was not hers to control. "I survived them."

Through the window she watched them go. Catriona walked ahead, her back straight, her pace unyielding. Moira followed three steps behind, her hands in her pockets, her head down. They did not look at each other. They did not look back.

Mara stood at the window for a long time. The harbor lights came on as the morning darkened, little points of yellow against the gray. The boats rocked at their moorings. Somewhere on the island, the Daughters were talking. Somewhere, Catriona was planning her next move. The cairn waited. The reading waited. The sea waited.

She thought about Eilidh, asleep in her Edinburgh flat, dreaming dreams she did not understand. She thought about Finlay, at the Inn, making coffee and pretending that the world was a problem with a practical solution. She thought about the lighthouse, its beam cutting through the dark, marking the path that ships were supposed to follow.

She turned from the window. She picked up the bottle. She held it in her hands, feeling its weight, its cold glass certainty, the message inside that had already changed everything.

Not for them, she thought. Not for the Muirheads. Not for the community. Not for anyone who wants to use it.

She set the bottle down. She went to the fire. She fed another peat brick into the flames and watched it catch, watched the light climb and twist and settle into the slow burn that would keep her warm through the rest of the morning.

Catriona wanted to control the reading. She wanted to bring it to the cairn and make it speak for her, proof that the old ways still had power, evidence that the Muirhead vision of restoration was more than nostalgia. She wanted to use Eilidh, and the message, and the whole apparatus of what the sea had given, and she wanted to make it hers.

Mara understood this. She had spent thirty years watching the sea take things, and she had learned that the taking was never random. The sea claimed what it claimed, and it did not let go, and no amount of Muirhead assertion or Preservation Society resolution was going to change what the reading meant or who it named.

But Catriona would try. Catriona would bring it to the cairn whether Mara agreed or not. She would stand in the old place and speak the old words and call the community together, and she would make Eilidh's name into a demonstration, a proof, a thing that served her purpose instead of the survivor's survival.

And Eilidh did not know. Eilidh was asleep in Edinburgh, and tomorrow she would board a boat, and the boat would bring her home, and she would walk into a conflict she had not chosen and could not escape.

Mara sat by the fire and watched the peat burn.

She had told Catriona no. She had meant it. But meaning it was not the same as stopping her, and Catriona had resources that Mara did not, and the Muirheads had been claiming things on this island since before the lighthouse was built.

She would have to move faster than she had planned. She would have to find Eilidh before Catriona did. She would have to tell her the truth—or enough of the truth that Eilidh would understand what was coming—and she would have to do it soon, before the cairn and before the community and before Catriona turned the reading into a weapon.

She stood. She crossed to the table. She picked up the bottle one more time, holding it up to the firelight, watching the glass catch the glow.

The old ways have power, Catriona had said.

Mara looked at the bottle, at the message inside that she had already read and could not unread.

Yes, she thought. *But not the way you think.*

She set the bottle down. She put on her coat. She did not take the bottle with her—she left it on the table, in its hollow of cloth, waiting—but she did take her father's ledger from the shelf where it had sat for fifteen years, the record of every reading he had ever seen, every prediction he had ever transcribed, every small piece of the truth the sea had given him and that he had kept in ink and paper instead of letting it consume him the way it consumed the others.

She opened the ledger. She found the page she wanted. She read the entry one more time, the same words she had read a hundred times as a girl, the same words she had tried to forget and could not.

When the reading names one, the sea does not forget.

She closed the ledger. She put on her boots. She walked to the harbor, to find the boat that would bring Eilidh home, to reach her before Catriona did, to give her the warning she needed in time for the warning to matter.

The lighthouse stood above the harbor, its beam resting between sweeps, patient and indifferent and eternal.

The boats rocked at their moorings.

The water waited.

CHAPTER 16

The phone call was three days ago. Three nights she had not slept without seeing the harbor.



SHE had not told her father about the dreams. She had not told anyone. What would she say? *I'm dreaming about boats that shouldn't be here. I wake up and I can still see them, the way they come into the harbor wrong, the way the water takes them.* Her father would say it was grief. Her father would say she was tired. Her father would say a great many things and none of them would be the truth, because her father did not know how to say the truth about anything except the Inn and the weather and the ferry schedule.

She walked down to the harbor in the morning because she did not know where else to go.

The air was cold enough to taste. November on Torran—she had forgotten what it felt like in her lungs, this particular sharpness that was not quite frost and not quite salt but something in between, something that made her think of her childhood and then made her stop thinking about her childhood. The village was waking around her. Smoke rose from the Inn's chimney. A gull cried somewhere above the harbor,

*the phone call was three days ago. three nights she had not slept without seeing
the harbor.*

the sound flat and purposeful, the way gulls sounded when they were claiming something.

She did not go to the Inn. She walked past it, down the track that led to the rocks, and she was not thinking about where she was going until she was already there.

Mara was sitting on the flat stone where the boats moored closest to shore. She was not watching the boats. She was not watching anything. She was sitting with her hands in her lap and her face turned toward the water, and she looked like a woman who had been sitting there so long the island had stopped noticing her.

Eilidh did not know why she sat down.

She just did. One moment she was standing on the track, the next she was lowering herself onto the stone beside Mara, her legs folding under her without her permission. The rock was damp. Her boots were not meant for this—she had worn her city boots, the ones with the flat heels that slid on wet stone, and she had to brace her feet against the edge to keep from sliding toward the water.

Mara did not look at her.

Eilidh waited. The harbor stretched below them, the boats moored in their rows, the water the color of slate. The light was thin this morning, the sun somewhere behind the clouds that had been sitting on the horizon since she arrived, and the harbor looked the way it always looked in November—gray and patient and waiting.

“I’m dreaming,” Eilidh said.

The words came out before she had decided to say them. She had not meant to say them. She had come down here to sit, not to confess, not to anything, but the words were out now and she could not take them back.

Mara turned her head. Just slightly. Just enough that Eilidh could see her profile against the gray sky.

“About what?”

“The harbor.” Eilidh’s voice sounded strange in her own ears. Flat. Not like her voice at all. “Boats coming in that shouldn’t float.”

She waited for Mara to ask a question. To laugh, maybe, or to say something practical about dreams being dreams and the mind processing what the mind processed. But Mara did not laugh. Mara did not say anything. She just looked at Eilidh with those eyes that had seen too much and knew too much and had stopped expecting anyone to believe them.

“The reading is not about knowing,” Mara said. “It’s about what you do with the knowing.”

Eilidh shook her head. “What does that mean?”

“It means the sea is coming. It means you can run or you can stay.”

The sea is coming. Eilidh felt something cold move through her chest, not her heart but something deeper, something that had nothing to do with the weather or the water or anything she could name. She thought of the boats in her dreams. She thought of the way they came into the harbor wrong, the way the water took them, the way she stood on the rocks and watched and could not move.

She thought: *How does she know.*

She thought: *What does she know.*

She thought: *I should not have come here.*

“You don’t understand,” she said. Her voice came out wrong, too loud for the quiet morning, too sharp. “I came home because my father called me. I didn’t—I wasn’t going to stay. I’m not staying. I have a job. I have a flat. I have a life.”

“I know.”

“You don’t know anything about my life.”

“I know what the message said.”

The words hung in the air between them. Eilidh opened her mouth to argue, to say something about messages in bottles being nonsense, about prophecy being what people believed in when they did not have the courage to face reality. But she looked at Mara’s face and she did not say any of that. Mara was not looking at her. Mara was looking at the harbor, at the boats, at the water that was the color of slate.

“Message,” Eilidh said. The word tasted like rust in her mouth.

*the phone call was three days ago. three nights she had not slept without seeing
the harbor.*

“You came here to tell someone about the dreams. You sat down without knowing why.” Mara’s voice was quiet. Not kind—Mara did not say kind things—but not unkind either. Just true. “The dreams are not nothing. They are never nothing.”

“Then what are they?”

Mara was silent for a long moment. The harbor stretched below them. A boat rocked at its mooring, the motion slow and patient.

“They are the sea telling you what it has claimed.”

Eilidh stood up. She did not decide to stand up; her legs simply unfolded and she was on her feet, and she was looking down at Mara, and she did not know what she was feeling except that it was too big for her body.

“I need to think,” she said.

She walked back up the track toward the village. Her legs felt strange, not quite under her, and she had to watch her feet to keep from stumbling. The harbor fell away behind her. The Inn came into view ahead, its white walls and its smoke-stained chimney, and she knew her father was inside, probably standing at the bar doing the thing he did with the papers and the schedules, pretending the world was something that could be managed with the right list and the right plan and the right number of ferry runs.

She did not go inside.

She stopped in the middle of the street, halfway between the harbor and the Inn, and she stood there with the cold air on her face and the gray light in her eyes and the words Mara had said turning over and over in her head. *The sea is coming. It means you can run or you can stay.*

She could run. She could call the mainland office and say she needed emergency leave. She could get on the ferry tomorrow and go back to her flat and her job and her life that was not here and had never been here and did not have to be here. She could run, and the dreams would stop, and she would never have to think about boats that shouldn’t float again.

She could stay. She could go into the Inn and talk to her father

and make him explain what message, what reading, what any of this was supposed to mean. She could stay and find out whether Mara was right about what the sea had claimed, or whether Mara was wrong, or whether it did not matter whether she was right or wrong because the boats came anyway and the water took them anyway and standing on the rocks and watching was all anyone could ever do.

The street was empty. The Inn sat in front of her, patient and solid and full of things she did not want to face. Behind her, the harbor spread out toward the horizon, the boats at their moorings, the lighthouse standing on its rock.

The light had not turned on yet. The sun was still behind the clouds.

Eilidh stood in the middle of the street and did not go inside.

CHAPTER 17

The barometer dropped before breakfast.



MARA felt it in her knuckles first—the ache that came with pressure change, the way her joints remembered weather the way other people remembered names. She had been eating her porridge when the change arrived, standing at the window with the bowl in her hands, watching the harbor through the gray morning light. The boats were still at their moorings. The water was calm. And then it wasn't.

The ache moved up her arms. She set the bowl down on the table and crossed to the barometer on the wall, the old brass instrument her father had hung there forty years ago and that she had never once moved. The needle was falling. Had been falling, she realized, for hours. She had been watching the harbor and not watching the instrument and the needle had dropped a quarter inch while she wasn't looking and now it was still dropping, still falling, and she understood what that meant.

November. The sea was never quiet in November.

She finished her porridge standing up, washing it down with cold tea, and dressed in the clothes she kept by the door for weather like this. Wool trousers. A heavy sweater her mother had made, the one with the

reinforced elbows. The boots that had seen thirty years of shore walks. She didn't need to check the window again. She knew what she would see.

The wind had shifted. Northwest now, the direction that brought weather from the open Atlantic, the direction that meant the harbor was protected and the north shore was not. The boats would be fine in the harbor. The boats on the north side of the island, the fishing boats that stayed out until they had to come in, those boats would be watching the horizon now, wondering whether to run for home or ride it out.

Mara pulled on her coat and stepped outside.

The air was cold and it tasted different—saltier, heavier, the way it always tasted before a storm came in from the open water. She could see the clouds building in the northwest, gray pushed against gray, layers of weather stacked on top of each other like sediment. This was not the quick weather that blew through in an afternoon. This was the slow storm, the big storm, the kind that came in November and stayed for days.

She walked down toward the harbor, not hurrying, because hurrying would make people ask questions and she wasn't ready to answer questions yet. She had a picture in her head of what the message had said, and she had been trying for two days now to decide whether the picture was real or whether she had invented it in the night, whether the words she remembered were the words the reading had given her or the words she had written herself in the dark, half-asleep, her hand moving without her permission.

She did not know which it was. She had never been unsure like this before.

The message had said: *The sea is coming. It means you can run or you can stay.*

The message had said: *A boat that should not float will float, and a child of the island will be the only hand that reaches the shore.*

The message had said: *The storm comes with the tide, and the tide*

comes with the storm, and if the child of the island is on the water when the two meet, the sea will keep what it has marked.

She had written those words in her own hand, in a script that was hers and not hers, and she had watched the ink appear on the paper as though the paper itself were bleeding, and she had known what it meant. She had known, and she had tried to un-know it, and she had failed, and now the barometer was falling and the wind was shifting and she could taste the storm on the air the way she had tasted it a hundred times before, when she was the keeper and the light was hers to tend and the sea was a thing she could warn people about if they were willing to listen.

No one had ever been willing to listen.

She reached the harbor and stopped at the top of the slope that led down to the water. The boats were bobbing at their moorings, the green paint bright against the gray water, the rigging sounds sharp in the cold air. A gull screamed somewhere behind her. The Inn sat across the small square, its windows dark, its chimney sending up a thin line of smoke.

The ferry was in port. She could see it from here, the flat-bottomed vessel that made the crossing twice a week, that carried the mail and the supplies and sometimes the people who needed to leave or needed to come home. It would make the crossing again tomorrow, if the weather allowed. That was what Finlay had said. That was what Finlay believed.

Finlay believed that tomorrow was a day like any other, and that the ferry would come unless the weather stopped it, and that the weather was something you watched and planned around and did not have to fear unless it was worse than you expected. Finlay believed this because Finlay had to believe it. Finlay ran the Inn and the League and the schedules and the lists, and if Finlay did not believe that tomorrow could be managed, Finlay would have to believe something else, and what Finlay believed instead was worse.

She crossed the square and pushed open the door of the Inn.

The common room was empty at this hour. The fire was low in the grate, banked for the day, and the tables were wiped clean and waiting for the evening trade. Finlay was behind the bar, as he always was, doing something with papers and a ledger, his reading glasses perched on the end of his nose. He looked up when she came in.

"Mara."

"The barometer's dropping."

He nodded toward the window. "I know. Tam from the north shore was in earlier. He's running his traps early. Says the birds are moving south."

"The birds are right."

"Middle of November. Happens every year."

"This isn't every year."

He set down his pen. He took off his glasses. He had the look he got when he was about to disagree with her, which was most of the time, because she was the keeper who had watched eleven men die and he was the innkeeper who had watched his wife die and neither of them knew how to talk about the things they had watched.

"You're going to tell me about the message again."

"I'm going to tell you what the weather is going to do."

"Then tell me."

She crossed to the bar and stood across from him, the polished wood between them, the smell of old beer and old smoke in the air. "The storm that's coming. It's not the one we expected. The one we expected was another week off, maybe two. This one is forming now. The pressure's dropping faster than it should. The wind's already shifted. By tonight it'll be blowing fifty knots from the northwest, and the waves on the north shore will be fifteen feet high, and the ferry won't be able to make the crossing."

"Tomorrow's a week day. Ferry runs every Tuesday and Friday."

"I know when the ferry runs."

"Then you know tomorrow's not a ferry day."

"It is now. She's coming home for the funeral anniversary. You said

she was coming tomorrow.”

Finlay’s face changed. Not much—a tightening around the eyes, a stillness in the jaw. He did not like to talk about his daughter. He did not like to admit that he had asked her to come home. He did not like to admit that he had been the one to suggest the timing, the week of the anniversary, when the island would be quiet and there would be time to remember and to talk about things that were hard to talk about.

“She’s coming on the Tuesday ferry. She’s already booked the passage. I confirmed it myself.”

“Cancel it.”

“Mara.”

“Cancel it. She needs to stay on the island.”

“That’s not something you get to tell me about my daughter.”

“I know.”

“Then why are you telling me?”

She made herself hold his eyes. “Because the reading named her. Because the sea has marked her. Because if she gets on that ferry tomorrow and the weather turns the way it’s turning, she will not come home. She will not come home, Finlay. She will not come home, and there is nothing either of us can do about it unless she is here when the storm hits.”

The silence stretched between them. The fire crackled in the grate. Somewhere outside, a gull screamed again.

“You don’t believe that.”

“I believe it.”

“You don’t believe it. You found a bottle with some words in it, words you wrote yourself without remembering writing them, and now you’re standing here telling me my daughter is marked for drowning.” He shook his head. “I’ve known you for forty years, Mara. You’ve never said anything like this before. What happened to you?”

“Things have happened.”

“Since the bottle?”

“Since the message.”

"What message? You've told me there was a message. You've told me it said something about a child of the island. You've told me it was a warning. But you haven't told me what it actually said, word for word, the way it came to you."

She had not told him. She had been avoiding telling him because once she told him, it would be real for him the way it was real for her, and she did not know what he would do with that reality. She did not know if he would believe her or if he would fight her or if he would simply refuse to hear it, the way he had refused to hear anything about his wife's illness until there was nothing left to hear.

But the barometer was dropping. And the wind was shifting. And tomorrow was too close.

"It said a boat that should not float will float."

Finlay looked at her. His face was unreadable.

"It said a child of the island will be the only hand that reaches the shore."

"That's not what you told me before."

"I told you what I could. I told you what I understood. This is what it said. Word for word. My hand wrote it and I watched."

"A boat that should not float."

"Yes."

"And Eilidh is the only hand that reaches the shore."

"Yes."

"That means she's the survivor. Doesn't it? It means she lives."

"It means she's marked. It means the sea has claimed her. It means the ferry that should bring her home will not bring her home. It means the storm that should wait will not wait. It means every piece of luck and timing and chance that stands between her and the water has already been decided, and the only variable is whether she's here when it happens or whether she's out on the water when it finds her."

Finlay stared at her. His hands were flat on the bar, pressing down, as though he was trying to hold something in place. "You're saying she'll die if she comes tomorrow."

"I'm saying the reading says she will die if she's not here when the storm hits. I'm saying the storm is coming early and I don't know why and I don't know what it means, but I know that she's supposed to be on the water tomorrow and the water is going to be wrong tomorrow and I don't know what happens when the reading and the weather disagree, but I know that I don't want to find out."

Finlay was quiet for a long moment. Then he picked up his phone from behind the bar.

"What are you doing?"

"I'm calling her. I'm telling her not to come."

"Do that. Tell her to stay on the mainland until this passes."

He dialed. He put the phone to his ear. He listened. He pulled the phone away and looked at the screen.

"No answer."

"Call again."

"She's probably at work."

"Call again."

He called again. He listened again. He pulled the phone away and shook his head.

"Voicemail again."

"Tell her to stay."

"I am." He set the phone down on the bar. "I'm telling her. But she doesn't have to listen. She's thirty-two years old. She makes her own choices."

"She chose to come home. You asked her to come home."

"I asked her to come for the anniversary. That's different."

"Is it?"

Finlay didn't answer.

"The ferry comes at what time?"

"Two in the afternoon. If it comes."

"If. You said if."

"I said if the weather allows. The ferry comes unless the weather stops it."

"And if the weather stops it?"

"Then it doesn't come."

"Then she stays on the mainland."

"Then she's safe. That's what you said. That's what you wanted."

"I want her to be here. I want her to be on the island when the storm hits. I want her away from the water."

"She'll be safe on the mainland."

"The reading doesn't care where she is."

The words hung in the air between them. Finlay's face had gone hard, the way it went hard when someone told him something he didn't want to believe, and she recognized that look because she had seen it before, the look of a man who had built his life on the assumption that the world was manageable and who did not want to hear that some things could not be managed.

"What do you mean, it doesn't care where she is?"

"I mean the reading doesn't stop because she's not on the island. I mean the clause is working. The sea has marked her, and the mark follows. If she's on the mainland when the storm hits, the storm will find her there. If she gets on the ferry tomorrow, the ferry will fail. If she drives to her flat and locks the door and doesn't come out until the weather clears, something will happen. Something will bring her to the water. The readings don't care about geography."

Finlay was staring at her. "That's not possible."

"It's happened before. In the Registry. There are cases where the survivor was removed from the island before the wreck. They brought the wreck to her. The sea doesn't forget what it's claimed."

"That's—Mara, that's insane. That's not how the world works."

"I know."

"You can't believe that."

"I know I can't prove it. I know it sounds insane. I know you think I've lost my mind." She held his gaze. "But I'm asking you. I'm asking you to call her again. I'm asking you to tell her not to come. Not because of the weather. Not because of the storm. Because of what the

message said. Can you do that? Can you tell her the truth?"

Finlay picked up his phone. He looked at the screen. He set it down again.

"I can't tell her that."

"Finlay."

"I can't tell my daughter that the sea has marked her for death because of a message in a bottle. I can't tell her that the reason she shouldn't come home is because a prophecy says she's going to drown. She's going to think I've gone insane. She's going to think you're insane. She's going to think the whole island has lost its mind."

"She already thinks the island has lost its mind. She left, didn't she?"

Finlay flinched. It was a small movement, barely visible, but she saw it and he knew she had seen it, and for a moment neither of them said anything.

"I'll tell her the weather's bad. I'll tell her not to travel. I'll tell her to wait a few days."

"That's not enough."

"It's what I can do."

Mara looked at him. She had known this would happen. She had known he would not believe, would not understand, would do the practical thing and not the hard thing and call it a choice when it was a failure. She had known, and she had come anyway, because the barometer was dropping and the wind was shifting and there was no one else who could tell him what she was telling him.

She had done what she could. Now she would have to do what came next.

She turned and walked out of the Inn.

...

The storm hit that night.

Mara felt it coming the way she always felt storms coming—through

the walls of the cottage, through the sound of the sea that never stopped, through the way the air pressure changed and her bones remembered what was coming before her eyes could see it. She did not light the lamp. She sat in the dark by the window and watched the harbor through the rain, the boats jerking at their moorings, the water white with foam.

The wind screamed around the cottage. The rain came horizontal. The sea she could not see in the darkness was moving the way it always moved when it was angry, and she could hear it—could feel it—through the stone walls that had held for a hundred and thirty years, through the windows that rattled in their frames, through the door that she had learned to brace against the worst of the weather.

She did not sleep. She watched.

Somewhere out on the water, the ferry was in port or it was not. Somewhere on the mainland, Eilidh was listening to her father's message or she was not. Somewhere, the reading was working or it was not, and the storm was gathering or it was dispersing, and the tide was coming in or it was going out, and all the choices that had been made and not made were aligning themselves toward a single point where the weather and the prophecy would meet and something would be decided.

She did not know what that something would be. She did not know if the reading could be changed or if it was fixed the way the tide was fixed, coming in whether you were ready or not, taking what it had claimed whether you had tried to save it or not. She had spent fifteen years believing that witnessing was enough, that watching was enough, that if she could not stop the sea from taking things then she could at least be there when it did, could at least remember what had been taken and honor the taking.

But the reading named someone she knew. The reading named a child she had watched grow up, a woman who had left the island and tried to make a life somewhere else, a person who was not supposed to be part of this, who was supposed to be safe, who was supposed to be free of the things that happened on the water.

The reading had not freed her. The reading had claimed her.

And now the storm was here, and the ferry could not come, and the island was cut off from the mainland the way it had always been cut off in bad weather, alone on its rock in the North Atlantic with nothing but the weather and the water and the old stories about what happened when the sea decided to keep what it had marked.

...

Dawn came gray and cold.

The storm had passed in the night, or rather it had settled in, the worst of the wind dropping to something that was merely dangerous rather than catastrophic, the rain becoming a steady drizzle that would last for days. Mara walked down to the harbor in the gray light. The boats were still there, still at their moorings, some of them knocked against each other in the chop, their paint scratched, their rigging tangled. The ferry dock was empty. No ferry.

The harbor was empty in a different way than usual. The early-morning fishermen were out—the ones who had stayed, the ones who had not run for home when the weather turned. They were out on the water now, working the morning tide, and the harbor was quiet except for the sound of the waves against the stones and the cry of the gulls fighting over the offal from last night's catch.

Mara stood at the water's edge and looked out toward the horizon. The mainland was there, somewhere beyond the gray water, but she couldn't see it. The weather was too thick, the sky too low, the world contracted to the range of what she could touch and no more. She was alone on her island, the way she had always been alone, and the world beyond was gone.

The ferry would not come today. Perhaps not tomorrow either. The weather was set in, the kind of November weather that could last a week or a month, the kind that made the island what it was and kept people away or drove them away, the kind that had killed the eleven

men in 1998, when the rescue boat couldn't make the crossing and the keeper stood on the tower and watched the water take them one by one.

She had not been able to save them. She had lit the signal fires. She had sent up the rockets. She had done everything the protocols required, and it had not been enough, and she had learned that the sea did not care about protocols, did not care about effort, did not care about the people who watched from shore and wanted to help and could not.

The sea took what it took. It did not negotiate.

She turned and walked back up the slope from the harbor. The street was empty in the early light, the Inn dark, the cooperative building closed. She walked until she reached the shore path that led north along the coast, the path that followed the edge of the island toward the rocks where the boats had come in and the boats had gone down and the sea had given back what it wanted to give and kept the rest.

The path was slick with rain and covered in dead grass. She walked slowly, her boots finding the footing, her eyes on the ground and on the sea at the same time. The waves were high still, the swells coming in from the northwest, and she could hear them before she could see them—the crash and roar and thunder that was the sound the sea made when it was still angry, still unspent, still carrying the memory of the storm that had blown through in the night.

She walked until she reached the place where the path ended and the rocks began. This was where the boats came in, the sheltered cove that faced east, the place where the water was deep enough for the bigger vessels and the harbor master had once kept his office. The office was empty now. The dock was gone, washed out in a storm ten years ago and never rebuilt. But the boats still came here when they could, tying up to the mooring rings set into the granite, unloading their catch onto the stones where the women waited to carry it to the cooperative.

No boats were here now. The water was too rough, the surge too high, the rocks too slick with rain and spray. Anyone who tried to land here in this weather would be dashed against the stones, and everyone on the island knew it, and no one tried.

Mara stood on the rocks and watched the sea.

She did not know what she was waiting for. She did not know what she expected to see. The ferry could not come. The weather had stopped it, and Finlay had told her not to come, and Eilidh was either listening or she was not, and there was nothing left for Mara to do except wait and watch and see what the sea had decided.

The waves came in. They broke against the rocks. They pulled back and came again. The water was the color of the sky, gray and formless, and she could not see where the sea ended and the horizon began, could not see anything beyond the range of her own island, could not see what was happening on the mainland or in the harbor of the island itself or in any of the places where people lived their lives and made their choices and hoped for things they could not control.

She stood on the rocks and watched the sea.

And then she heard footsteps behind her.

She turned. Eilidh was walking down the path toward her, her coat pulled tight against the drizzle, her hair wet, her face pale in the gray light. She was alone. She was here.

She had not listened to her father's message. Or she had listened and come anyway. Or she had never received it, the phone dead or the message undelivered, and she had gotten on the morning ferry that should not have run and somehow had, and now she was here, on the rocks, in the weather, where the reading said she should be.

The sea rose behind her. The waves came in higher than before.

Mara did not move. She did not call out. She watched Eilidh walk toward her across the wet stones, and she felt the wind on her face, and she tasted the salt in the air, and she knew that this was the moment the reading had been waiting for, the moment when the weather and the prophecy aligned, the moment when the sea would take what it had marked or when it would not.

The question the chapter needed to end on was not whether the reading would come true. The question was whether the reading could be wrong.

Mara stood on the shore and watched the sea rise.

CHAPTER 18

*without hurry, without expectation, ready for
whatever the weather decided to bring.*



SHE was not ready for this. The cairn sat on a rise of ground that had once been an island, before the strait between Torran and the mainland silted up and became a causeway. The oldest families said the first settlers had buried their dead here, before they knew the island's name or understood what the name meant. *Torran*. Place where the tide turns. They had named it for what they saw from this hill—the way the water rushed in and then rushed out, the way the current shifted twice a day without fail, the way the sea could take and the sea could give, and no one ever knew which it would do until the tide had turned.

The cairn was a mound of stones covered in grass, older than the lighthouse, older than the village, older than the language people used to argue about who owned what. A ring of standing stones marked its base, brought up from the beach in an age when moving stones was something a community did together, when the work of moving them was a kind of prayer.

Catriona Muirhead stood at the center of the ring, wrapped in a black coat that had been her mother's, her white hair pulled back from a face that had not softened in the seventy-one years it had been taking the wind. She was not alone.

Mara counted them as she approached. The three families of the Cairn—the Muirheads, the Camshields, the MacDonalds—had sent their elders. Dougie Camshield, who owned the second boat that still worked. Moira MacDonald, who had not left the island since her husband drowned in eighty-nine and who spoke to the sea like it could hear her. Donald Muirhead, Catriona's nephew, who had come back from Aberdeen for the funeral and stayed for reasons no one understood. Fourteen people in all, standing in a loose semicircle with their backs to the wind.

Agnes was there. She stood at the edge of the group, her hands folded in front of her, her face the color of old paper. She had been the first to arrive, Mara guessed. She always arrived early for things like this. The Daughters of the Deep understood that presence was its own kind of statement.

Finlay was there. He stood apart from the others, near the path, his shoulders hunched against the wind. He had not wanted to come. Mara could see it in the set of his jaw, the way he kept looking back toward the village as though the harbor could still give him an excuse to leave. But he was here, which meant Catriona had asked, and Finlay had learned long ago that the Cairn families did not ask twice.

And Eilidh.

She stood next to her father, her coat pulled tight around her, her hair wet from the drizzle. She did not look at the people gathered around the cairn. She looked at the stones, the grass, the sky, anything but the faces turned toward her. She had come because Finlay asked, and she had come anyway, and she did not know why it mattered, and that not-knowing was written on every line of her body like tide marks on a cliff face.

Mara stopped at the edge of the ring.

“Mara,” Catriona said. Not a greeting. An acknowledgment. “You received the message.”

“I did.”

“And you came.”

“I came.”

The wind picked up. It moved through the standing stones with a sound like a voice calling across water, and the grass at the base of the cairn bent and rose and bent again. The cloud overhead had thickened, and the light had gone from gray to the color of slate, and in that light the faces around the cairn looked older than they were. Older and harder and more afraid than they wanted anyone to see.

Catriona turned to address the group. Her voice carried in the way that voices carried on Torran, shaped by wind and stone and the particular acoustics of a landscape that had been listening to human speech for a hundred and seventy years.

“A reading has named one of ours.” She did not look at Eilidh. She did not need to. “The community must decide how to respond.”

The silence that followed was the kind that had weight. It pressed against the ears, against the chest, against the space between people where words usually lived. Mara watched the faces around the cairn. Dougie Camshield was looking at the ground. Moira MacDonald was looking at the sea, or at the direction of the sea, her lips moving slightly as though she were already speaking to it. Donald Muirhead was looking at Catriona with an expression that might have been loyalty or might have been calculation. It was hard to tell the difference with Donald.

Finlay’s jaw had tightened. His hands had gone into his pockets, and his shoulders had come up, and Mara recognized the posture of a man who was about to do something he would regret. She waited. Finlay would speak or he would not. She had learned, over thirty years, that some silences were more honest than words, and this was one of them.

“The survivor clause is not a myth.” Catriona’s voice had not changed. It was still formal, still measured, still the voice of a woman who had

been stating facts about the sea since before most of the people in this circle were born. "Ships that should have rescued them sink. Ropes that should have held break. The sea does not forget what it has marked."

"We don't know that," Finlay said. His voice was rough. "We don't know that any of this is real."

"We know that every reading in the Registry has come true."

"The Registry. The Registry. You want me to believe in a pile of paper in some office on the mainland."

"I want you to believe what your own island has taught you." Catriona turned to face him, and for a moment the mask of authority slipped and there was something older beneath it, something that had watched three sons drown in a winter storm and had decided, forty years ago, that it would never be helpless again. "The sea takes. The sea marks. And the community decides what to do with what the sea has given."

"What the sea has given." Finlay's laugh was short and bitter. "You want to call Eilidh a gift now?"

Eilidh flinched. Mara saw it—a small movement, the way her body tried to make itself smaller without actually moving. She had not known. That was clear now. Finlay had not told her what the reading said, had not explained why he had called her home, had not done any of the things that a father should do when his daughter was in danger. He had just asked her to come, and she had come, and now she was standing in a circle of stones listening to people talk about her like she was cargo on a tide.

"I have not called her anything," Catriona said. "I have stated what the reading means. The community must decide how to respond—which means the community must decide what to do with the knowledge it has been given."

"What you mean is you want to use her."

"I want to use the reading. The survivor is the community's concern."

"The survivor is my daughter."

"And therefore the community's. Every person on this island is the

community's concern. That is what it means to live here."

The wind shifted. It came from the east now, carrying the smell of the harbor, and in that smell there was fish oil and diesel and the particular dampness of a village that had been drying nets in the same place for a hundred years. Mara breathed it in. She had grown up with that smell. She had left it behind when she moved into the keeper's cottage, and she had never quite gotten used to the salt-and-peat of the promontory, the absence of the harbor's particular□□.

She stepped forward.

"The reading is not yours to decide."

Every face turned to her. Catriona's expression did not change, but something behind her eyes did—a flicker of calculation, of reassessment, of a woman who had expected resistance and was deciding how much it mattered.

"The reading arrived in my hand," Mara said. "The message was mine to receive. And the survivor is not yours to use."

"The community—"

"The community has no say in what the reading means." Mara's voice was flat, declarative, the voice she had used for twenty-seven years in the lighthouse tower, calling across the water to ships that could not hear her. "The reading names who it names. The survivor survives or does not. The community's decision changes nothing."

"Then what use is the community?" Catriona asked. "If the reading cannot be altered, what is there to decide?"

"The community decides what it owes the survivor. Not what it owes the reading. Not what it owes the sea. What it owes the person."

"You think the two can be separated?"

"I think they have to be."

The wind died. For a moment, the cairn was silent—not the silence of the absence of sound, but the silence of the presence of listening. The stones stood. The grass bent. The sky pressed down. And the people gathered around the oldest grave on the island waited for someone to say the thing that would break the silence or make it permanent.

Agnes spoke.

“The survivor clause has been tested.” Her voice was quiet, but it carried. It always carried. The Daughters had a way of speaking that slid under the noise of argument and landed in the place where people actually listened. “In seventy-three, a reading named my brother. My parents tried to keep him on the island. They tried to stop him from going to sea. They tried everything they could think of, and he went anyway, and he came back in a box.”

Moir MacDonal made a small sound. She remembered. Everyone old enough remembered.

“The reading was not changed,” Agnes continued. “But the reading was not the point. The point was what we did with the knowing. My parents had a year. A year to say the things they should have said. A year to let him know he was loved. A year to be with him before the sea took him.” She paused. “The reading came true. But the year was ours.”

The silence returned. It was different now—less weight, more depth. Mara watched the faces around the cairn and saw something shift in them, a movement like the tide going out, a recession that would not last but that was happening anyway.

Catriona’s expression had not changed, but her silence had. She was thinking. Mara could see it in the way her hands had come together in front of her, the way her weight had shifted slightly forward, the way she was looking at Mara as though she were seeing her for the first time.

“The community still must decide,” Catriona said finally. “If not what to do with the reading, then what to do with the survivor.”

“The community can decide what to offer,” Mara said. “Not what to take.”

“And if the survivor refuses?”

“Then the survivor refuses.”

Eilidh spoke.

Everyone turned. She had not meant to speak—she could see it in the way her hand came up to her mouth, the way her body went rigid

with the shock of having said something in a space where silence had been the rule. But she had spoken, and now she had to finish.

“I don’t—” She stopped. Started again. “I don’t know what any of this means. I don’t know what a reading is supposed to do, or why it matters, or why I’m standing in a field being talked about like I’m already dead.”

“Eilidh,” Finlay said.

“No.” She looked at her father, and for a moment the fear was gone and what was left was something harder, something that had been building for years and that had finally found an outlet. “No. You brought me here. You made me come. And you didn’t tell me why.”

“I was trying to protect you.”

“Protect me from what? From knowing?” Her voice cracked. “From being here? From being part of this?” She gestured at the cairn, at the stones, at the faces turned toward her. “You wanted me to come home, and now I’m home, and you’re still trying to keep me away from something. What is it? What are you so afraid I’ll find out?”

Finlay did not answer.

Mara watched the two of them—father and daughter, standing three feet apart and farther apart than that, separated by years of unspoken things and a mother who had died without telling either of them what she knew. She thought about the harbor at low tide, the way the water pulled back and left the rocks exposed, bare and glistening and utterly changed from what they had been an hour before. That was what she was seeing now. The truth exposed. The things that lived underwater finally visible.

“The reading named you,” Mara said. She did not move closer. She did not need to. “I know because I received it. The message said you would survive a wreck. It said you would be the only one left.”

Eilidh’s face went white.

“I didn’t want to believe it,” Mara continued. “I stood on the rocks this morning and watched the sea and tried to think of a way to unwrite what was written. There isn’t one. The reading is true, and it will come

true, and there is nothing any of us can do to stop it.”

“Then why are we here?” Catriona asked. “If nothing can be changed—”

“Because the reading is not the whole story.” Mara turned to face the cairn, the stones, the grass that had been growing since before the island had a name. “The sea takes. The sea marks. But the sea does not take everything. There is always something left. There is always what we do with the time we have.”

She turned back to Eilidh.

“I don’t know if you believe what I’m telling you. I don’t know if you can. But the reading names you, and the community knows now, and what happens next is up to you.”

Eilidh stared at her. Behind her, Finlay had gone very still. Around them, the Cairn families watched, and in their watching there was no judgment, no decision, only the weight of a knowledge that had been shared and could not be unshared.

“I don’t know what to do,” Eilidh said. Her voice was small.

“No one ever does,” Mara said. “That’s the truth of it. No one knows what to do. We just do something and hope the sea remembers we tried.”

The wind picked up again. It came from the northwest now, cold and salt-heavy, carrying the smell of the open Atlantic and the first hint of the storm that was building beyond the horizon. The cloud had darkened to the color of iron, and the light at the edge of the cairn had gone from gray to something deeper, something that had no name except the name the island gave it: the light before.

The families began to disperse. They did not speak to each other, not at first. They walked back down the path in ones and twos, heads bent against the wind, each of them carrying the weight of what they had heard and what they had not heard and what they had chosen not to say. Dougie Camshield was the first to leave. Then Moira MacDonald, still speaking to the sea under her breath. Then Donald Muirhead, who paused at the edge of the ring and looked back at Catriona with

an expression Mara could not read.

Agnes was last. She walked past Mara without stopping, but she touched her arm as she went—a brief pressure, an acknowledgment, a thank-you for the thing that had needed saying. Then she was gone, too, walking down the path with her hands folded and her face turned to the wind.

Catriona was the last to leave. She stood alone in the circle of stones, her black coat whipping around her, her white hair escaping from its pins. She looked at Mara for a long moment. There was no anger in her face. There was something worse: uncertainty. The realization that the thing she had built her authority on—the belief that the old ways could be controlled, managed, used—had been challenged in the place where that authority meant the most.

“The community will decide,” she said finally. “That has not changed.”

“The community will decide what it owes,” Mara said. “That has always been what the cairn means.”

Catriona did not answer. She turned and walked away, her footsteps soundless on the grass, her figure growing smaller against the darkening sky until it disappeared over the rise and was gone.

Mara stood alone at the cairn.

Finlay and Eilidh were still there. They had not moved. They stood three feet apart, father and daughter, and between them there was a distance that had nothing to do with space. The wind blew. The stones stood. The grass bent and rose and bent again.

“I should go,” Eilidh said finally. Her voice was flat. Exhausted. The voice of someone who had learned something they did not want to know and who was still trying to find the words for it. “I should go back to Edinburgh.”

“The ferry won’t run,” Finlay said. “Not in this weather.”

“Then I’ll wait.”

“Eilidh.”

“Don’t.” She held up a hand. “Don’t tell me what to do. Don’t tell me how to feel. You brought me here and you didn’t tell me why,

and now I know why, and I need—I need to not be here. I need to not be standing in a field being told I’m going to survive something.”

“You’re not going to survive.” Finlay’s voice broke. “The reading says you’re the only one. That means everyone else—”

“I know what it means.”

“Do you? Do you really?” He stepped toward her, and for the first time since Mara had known him, Finlay Gunn looked like a man who was afraid. Not afraid of the sea, not afraid of the reading, but afraid of the thing that was standing in front of him and refusing to be held. “Do you have any idea what it would do to me? To watch you go? To know I could have done something and didn’t?”

“You can’t do anything.” Eilidh’s voice was sharp. “That’s the whole point, isn’t it? The reading is true. The sea takes what it takes. Nothing changes.” She laughed—a short, broken sound. “Nothing ever changes on this island.”

“That’s not true and you know it.”

“Do I?” She turned to face him, and in her face Mara saw something she recognized—the look of a woman who had left and who had never stopped regretting the leaving, and who had never stopped knowing that the leaving was necessary. “I left because I couldn’t stand it anymore. The way you looked at me. The way you held on. The way you tried to keep me safe from everything, and the whole time the sea was just waiting.”

“I was trying to protect you.”

“From what? From being here? From knowing?” Her voice cracked. “From being part of this?” She gestured at the cairn, at the stones, at the sky. “You wanted me to come home, and now I’m home, and you’re still trying to keep me away from something. What is it, Dad? What are you so afraid I’ll find out?”

Finlay did not answer.

Eilidh waited. The wind blew. The cloud pressed down. And then, slowly, her shoulders dropped, and the anger went out of her, and what was left was something worse than anger—it was exhaustion,

the exhaustion of a woman who had spent her whole life running from something and who had finally stopped and turned around and realized that the thing she was running from had been running beside her the whole time.

“I don’t know what to do,” she said quietly.

Mara watched them. She thought about the lighthouse, the way it stood on the promontory and shone out over the water, year after year, light after light, calling ships home that would not always listen. She thought about the eleven faces she saw every night. She thought about the bottle in her pocket, still there, still heavy, still waiting.

“I don’t know what to do either,” Finlay said. “I never have. That’s the truth of it. I’ve been pretending I knew what to do since your mother got sick, and I don’t. I don’t know anything except that I can’t lose you too.”

Eilidh closed her eyes.

“I’m not going anywhere,” she said. “Not tonight. Not in this weather. I’ll stay at the Inn. We’ll talk tomorrow. We’ll figure out—” She stopped. “I don’t know what we’ll figure out. But we’ll figure out something.”

She walked past her father. She walked past Mara. She walked down the path toward the village, her coat pulled tight, her head down, her footsteps soundless on the grass. She did not look back.

Finlay watched her go. When she was out of sight, he turned to Mara.

“Why did you tell her?”

“Because she needed to know.”

“She needed to be protected.”

“From what? From herself?” Mara shook her head. “The reading names her. The community knows. And now she knows, and what she does with that knowing is her choice. Not yours. Not Catriona’s. Hers.”

“The community will never accept that.”

“The community doesn’t have to accept anything. The commu-

nity can only offer.”

Finlay looked at her for a long moment. There was something in his face that Mara had not seen before—not anger, not fear, but something closer to recognition. The look of a man who had spent his whole life trying to control the things he could not control and who was only now realizing that the control had never been his to have.

“The harbor’s going to be rough tomorrow,” he said finally.

“It always is.”

“I should check the moorings.”

“You should.”

He turned and walked away. His footsteps were heavy on the path, and the wind blew them away before they could settle, and then he was gone too, and Mara was alone at the cairn.

She stood there as the light faded. She stood there as the cloud thickened and the first drops of rain began to fall. She stood there as the stones grew dark and the grass disappeared into shadow and the wind turned cold and the sea, somewhere beyond the hills, began to rise.

The reading was true. The survivor was named. The community knew.

And now everything would change, or nothing would change, and no one—not Mara, not Catriona, not Finlay, not even Eilidh herself—would know which until the tide turned and the sea made its choice.

She reached into her pocket and touched the bottle. The glass was cold against her fingers. The message inside had already done its work. It had named who it named, and it had marked what it marked, and now it sat in her pocket like a stone, like a weight, like the tide waiting to come in.

She let it rest.

She turned and walked back toward the keeper’s cottage, toward the sound of the sea, toward the light that still burned on the promontory despite everything, because that was what lights did—they burned, and they waited, and they hoped that someone out in the dark would see them and know they were not alone.

*without hurry, without expectation, ready for whatever the weather decided
to bring.*

The rain came harder. The wind rose. The island sat in the gray water and waited for what would come next.

And somewhere in the harbor, Finlay Gunn walked the moorings in the rain, checking knots he had checked a thousand times before, pretending he could hold the world together if he just held on tight enough.

CHAPTER 19

The weekenders' daughter was building a castle at the waterline. Eilidh watched from the harbor wall, her hands in her pockets, her back to the inn. The girl was maybe eight, maybe nine—young enough to believe that sand could hold against the sea. Her mother called to her from the rocks where she was sketching. Her father sat on the wall farther up, reading something on his phone, shielding the screen from the glare. They had come for two weeks. They would leave with photographs and memories of quaintness and a vague sense that they had seen something authentic.



THEY didn't know about the reading. They didn't know about any of it. They were just here.

The girl shoved another handful of sand into place. The tide was

the weekenders' daughter was building a castle at the waterline. Eilidh watched from the harbor wall, her hands in her pockets, her back to the inn. the girl was maybe eight, maybe nine—young enough to believe that sand could hold a tower the size of her. She would have been maybe twenty minutes before the water reached her walls.

Edinburgh had counted the boats that morning. Six in the water, two would leave with photographs and memories of quaintness and a vague sense on the hard. The Muirhead boat was in the water mooring, where it had been all week—theirs or someone else's, she didn't know. The ferry was due in three hours. She had looked at the schedule on the way off the mainland boat, noted the times, calculated the connections. Edinburgh to the coast. Coast to the islands. Three days she could be gone if she left now, before Finlay knew she was awake, before anyone saw her on the street and thought to ask questions.

The girl stamped on her castle. Patting, shaping. She believed.

Eilidh turned and walked to the inn.

...

Her father was behind the bar, drying glasses with a cloth that had been white once. The morning trade was light—a pair of the ferry crew finishing breakfast, the weekenders drifting in for coffee. Finlay looked up when she came in. His face did something she had learned to read as concern, which he tried to disguise as casualness.

"You're up early."

"Slept badly."

"The ferry ride?"

"Bad dreams."

He set the glass down. Wiped a spot that wasn't there. "I called you."

"I know."

"You came."

"I came."

They had this conversation every time, though not always in words. She was here because he called. She was here because of the dreams. She was here because she had swum in water that smelled like the harbor at night, water that shouldn't have been in her apartment, water that

meant she was already back before she had decided to come.

The weekenders came through the door. The man nodded at Eilidh, at Finlay, at the room in general. His wife followed with the sketches she'd made on the rocks—Ellen something, from somewhere, she had introduced herself but Eilidh had already forgotten. They wanted coffee. They wanted to sit by the window. They wanted to watch the harbor and feel the feeling they came here to feel.

Finlay poured their coffee. Eilidh watched the harbor through the salt-streaked glass.

"It's so peaceful here," the wife said, not to anyone in particular. "No phones. No rush. Just the sea."

Eilidh almost laughed. The weekender looked at her, curious.

"Sorry," Eilidh said. "Just thinking about something."

The wife smiled. She had the kind of face that had never been tested by anything harder than a delayed flight. She had come to get away from the noise. She had succeeded. She would go home with clearer skin and a deeper understanding of her own privilege, and she would tell people it was spiritual, what the island had done for her. She would mean it.

"Just the sea," Eilidh said. "Yeah."

She thought about the boats. She thought about the moorings. She thought about the channel between the harbor and the open water—maybe half a mile of deep water, tide running north, current pulling toward the shipping lanes where the big boats went through without stopping. She thought about swimming. She thought about the dinghy tied up at the end of the pier, its painter knotted in a loop she could undo in thirty seconds if she was quick, if she was quiet, if Finlay was busy with the weekenders and no one saw her cast off and drift.

She could be in the water before anyone noticed.

She could be past the harbor mouth before the ferry arrived.

She could disappear.

...

the weekenders' daughter was building a castle at the waterline. Eilidh watched from the harbor wall, her hands in her pockets, her back to the inn. The girl was maybe eight, maybe nine—young enough to believe that sand could hold against the sea. Her mother failed to hold from the rock where she was sketching. Her father sat on the wall farther up, reading something on his phone, shielding the screen from the glare. They had come for two weeks. They would leave with photographs and memories of quaintness and a vague sense of shallow enough to stand in and warm enough not to kill you. She wasn't a strong swimmer. She knew what the harbor could do.

She knew what it had done.

Her mother had swum. Finlay had told her that once, early in their marriage—Mhairi had swum every summer, braved the cold water like it was nothing, came out shaking and laughing and alive. But that was years before Eilidh was born. By the time Eilidh knew her mother, Mhairi didn't swim anymore. Didn't go near the water unless she had to. Eilidh had asked once why, and her mother had looked at her with an expression she hadn't understood then and understood now—a look that said the answer was too heavy to carry and too true to speak.

Her mother had stayed. That was the thing. Through the winters and the storms and the slow dying of the island, through the automation and the departures and the years when it felt like everyone Eilidh knew had left, her mother had stayed. She had said it was because of the house, the community, the history. But Eilidh knew now that it wasn't any of those things. Her mother had stayed because leaving would have meant admitting that the sea had won, that the island had taken enough, that there was nothing left worth keeping.

She had stayed, and she had died anyway.

Eilidh pushed back from the table. The weekenders looked up, then away. Her father was watching her from behind the bar.

"I'm going out," she said.

"Out where?"

"The harbor. Walking."

"Alone?"

"I'm not going to drown, Dad."

He flinched. She hadn't meant it as a cruel thing, but she said it and felt the weight of it and knew that her mother was in the room

with them, in the silence between his breath and hers. Her mother, who had hidden her illness for a year. Her mother, who had bled into the hospital on the mainland while Eilidh was in Edinburgh failing to answer her phone.

Finlay wiped the bar with the cloth. His hands were steady. His eyes were not.

“I need to go to Mara’s,” Eilidh said.

The cloth stopped.

“What?”

“Mara Callaghan. At the cottage. I need to talk to her.”

Finlay set the cloth down. He looked at the weekenders, then at Eilidh, then at the harbor through the window. He was thinking, she could see it—the calculations running behind his face, the attempt to manage what could not be managed.

“She found the reading,” he said.

“So I heard.”

“Eilidh.”

“What?”

He came around the bar. He was wearing the apron he wore for the breakfast shift, white with the inn’s name embroidered at the chest, a gift from his wife years ago. He looked like a man who had rehearsed what he was going to say and was now discovering that the words didn’t work.

“What do you think you’re going to learn from her?”

“Everything.”

“There is no everything. There’s what she thinks she knows and what the rest of us have to live with.”

“Then I’ll learn what she thinks she knows. And I’ll decide for myself.”

He stepped closer. Lowered his voice. “You don’t have to decide anything. That’s the point. You can leave. The reading doesn’t—”

“The reading named me.” Her voice was flat. The weekenders had stopped talking. She didn’t care. “That’s what you said. That’s what

the weekenders' daughter was building a castle at the waterline. eilidh watched from the harbor wall, her hands in her pockets, her back to the inn. the girl was maybe eight, maybe nine—young enough to believe that sand could hold again. She isn't her mother, he called to her, friends. Don't tell me the message said. So don't tell me I don't have to decide. Don't tell me it's optional. Because it's not. Finlay's jaw worked. He was controlling himself, she could see it—*the effort it cost him not to say something he would regret, not to grab her arm and lock her in a room until she came to her senses. He had done that once, years ago, when she was seventeen and had been out all night with the Muirhead boy. He had waited up with the door locked and a face like stone, and she had screamed at him until her throat hurt, and then she had sat in her room and listened to him pace below her, and in the morning he had made her breakfast and said nothing.*

He was doing the same now. Controlling himself. Letting her have the space he thought she needed.

But he couldn't control this. He couldn't control what the message had said, or what the sea had marked, or what was coming whether she faced it or fled.

"I'm going," she said.

She walked out.

...

The path to the cottage was gravel and old stone, worn smooth by generations of feet. Eilidh had walked it a hundred times as a child, when Mara was still the keeper, when the light was still lit, when the tower was a thing of wonder instead of a thing of loss. She had climbed it once, with her mother holding her hand. She had stood at the top and looked out at the water and felt small in a way that was good, that made her feel like part of something larger than herself.

She didn't feel that now. She felt the size of the water, its indifference, its willingness to take whatever it was offered.

The cottage was gray stone, windows dark, chimney cold. Mara would be inside. Mara would be waiting. Mara had been waiting since the message appeared, since the words formed in her hand and named a daughter who had tried to forget where she came from.

Eilidh stopped at the gate.

The lighthouse stood behind the cottage, sixty-two feet of stone and iron, dark in the morning gray. The light was burning—she could see the faint glow through the housing, the mechanism that turned the lens, the system that someone else now maintained. Mara had climbed those stairs every night for twenty-seven years. She had climbed them alone, in the dark, in the cold, in the wind that screamed through the gaps in the door. She had lit the light and watched the sea and known what she was for.

Now she was retired. Now she was alone. Now she was waiting for a girl to come ask her the question that had no good answer.

Eilidh's hands were shaking. She shoved them deeper into her pockets. She breathed in, out, in, out. She thought about the ferry schedule and the boats and the swimmer's stroke that would carry her past the harbor mouth if she was fast enough, strong enough, cold enough to survive.

She was not fast enough. She was not strong enough. She was not cold enough.

Or maybe she was all of those things, and it didn't matter, because the reading had said what it had said and the sea had marked who it had marked, and running would only change the location of the ending.

She walked up to the door.

She knocked.

The door opened. Mara stood in the doorway. She looked old. She looked tired. She looked like someone who had been waiting for exactly this moment.

"You're here," Mara said.

"Tell me everything."

Mara stepped back. The door opened wider. The room beyond was dim, firelight and salt smell, the same as it had always been.

Eilidh stepped inside.

The door closed behind her.

The lighthouse beam swept across the cove, past the harbor, past

the weekenders' daughter was building a castle at the waterline. eilidh watched from the harbor wall, her hands in her pockets, her back to the inn.

the girl was maybe eight, maybe nine—young enough to believe that sand could hold against the sea. far the dark called to her from the rocks where she was sketching. her father sat on the wall farther up, reading something on his phone, shielding the screen from the glare. they had come for two weeks. they would leave with photographs and memories of quaintness and a vague sense that they had seen something authentic.

CHAPTER 20

Chapter Twenty



THE Inn was quiet.

Not the comfortable kind of quiet—the kind that comes after the last drinker has gone home and the fire has burned down to embers and the only sound is the sea against the harbor wall. This was the other kind. The kind that happens when two people sit across from each other and do not know what to say, and the not-saying fills the room like water filling a hull.

Finlay had lit the lamps an hour ago. Two of them, on the bar, because he could not stand the dark. He had straightened the glasses behind the counter even though no one had touched them. He had wiped the same spot on the bar twice. His hands needed something to do. His hands had always needed something to do.

Eilidh sat at the table by the window.

She had not taken off her coat. She sat with her hands in her lap, fingers interlaced, and she looked at the harbor through the salt-streaked glass as though she were waiting for something to arrive. The boats rocked at their moorings. The sky was the color of wet slate.

“You talked to her,” Finlay said.

“Yes.”

“And?”

“She told me what the message said.” Eilidh did not turn from the window. “She told me what it means.”

Finlay set down the cloth he had been folding. He had been folding it for ten minutes. He put it on the bar and pressed his hands flat against the wood and breathed in through his nose and out through his mouth and tried to remember what it felt like to say things without calculating their effect.

“I’m going to tell you something,” he said. “And you’re going to listen.”

“I’m listening.”

“Three weeks ago. A bottle came up on the rocks below the lighthouse. Mara found it. She opened it and the message appeared in her hand and it said—” He stopped. His throat had closed around the words. He had said them before, to Mara, to himself, in the dark when he could not sleep. He had practiced. He had practiced so he would not break. “It said there would be a wreck. A bad one. And it said there would be one survivor. It named that survivor.”

Eilidh turned now. Her face was pale in the lamplight, and her eyes were the same color as her mother’s eyes had been, and Finlay felt something crack open in his chest that he thought had calcified years ago.

“Who?” she said.

“You.”

The word sat between them like a stone dropped in water.

“You’re joking,” Eilidh said.

“I am not.”

“Dad. You can’t actually believe—”

“I don’t know what I believe.” He was shaking. He could feel it in his hands, in the muscles of his forearms, in the jaw he was clenching to keep his face still. “I don’t know if I believe in prophecy or readings or messages in bottles. I don’t know if any of it means what the island thinks it means. But I know what happened to the last ship Mara

watched go down. I know she lit the signal fires and did everything right and eleven men still drowned. And I know that when a reading names a survivor, the sea doesn't let go. I've seen the records. I've read what the Registry says."

"The Registry." Eilidh laughed, but there was no humor in it. "The Registry of Tidal Readings. The one no one takes seriously except when they do and then they pretend they don't."

"You came home."

"I came home because you called."

"I called because of the reading."

"I know." She looked down at her hands. "I know why you called. I knew before I got here."

Finlay waited.

"I've been dreaming about the harbor," she said. "For weeks. Boats coming in that shouldn't float. Water that looks black even in daylight. I thought it was—just stress. Work. The way things pile up when you don't deal with them." She closed her eyes. "I've been dreaming about boats sinking and I didn't want to tell you because I knew what you'd do with it."

"What did I do?"

"You called me and told me a bottle told you I was going to drown."

"That's not—"

"Is it wrong?"

He had no answer. She was right. He had taken the dreams—the dreams she had not told him about, the dreams she had kept hidden the way she kept everything hidden—and he had found a reason to make them matter. He had found a prophecy. He had found a way to make her come home.

"I'm not staying because of the reading," Eilidh said.

"Then why?"

She did not answer. She was still looking at her hands, and Finlay saw, with a clarity that felt like a blade, how thin her fingers had become. How sharp the knuckles. When had she gotten so thin? When had he

stopped noticing?

"Your mother," he said.

Eilidh looked up.

"She was sick for a year." The words came out rough, scraped from somewhere he had bricked over years ago. "Before she went to the mainland for tests. Before they told us what it was. She was sick for a year and I didn't see it. I was here, running the Inn, counting boats, worrying about ferry schedules, and she was—" He stopped. His hands were shaking again. He pressed them harder against the bar. "She told me, at the end. She said she'd known for months. She said she didn't want to worry us. She said she'd been waiting for it to pass."

Eilidh's face had gone still.

"She didn't tell me," Finlay said. "She didn't tell you. We could have done something. We could have had more time. But she kept it quiet and I kept not seeing and you—" He faltered. He could feel the shape of it now, the thing he had been circling for years. "You knew too. Didn't you."

The silence stretched.

"Yes," Eilidh said.

"She told you."

"She didn't have to." Eilidh's voice was barely above a whisper. "I saw her. The way she got tired. The way she went to bed earlier and earlier. The pills she thought she was hiding. I knew. I knew and I didn't say anything because I thought—" She stopped. Her jaw worked. "I thought if I didn't say it out loud, it wouldn't be real."

Finlay sat down. He had not meant to sit—he had meant to stand there and say what he had to say and stay controlled, but his legs had gone and there was nowhere to fall except into the chair across from his daughter. He sat and he looked at her and he felt the years of distance between them like a physical weight, like the stones stacked in the harbor wall, like the water pressure at a hundred feet.

"We watched each other drown," he said.

The words were out before he knew he was going to say them. They

came from somewhere below language, from the place where the things you cannot say live until you cannot hold them anymore. He heard them and they were true and he wished he could take them back and he knew he could not.

Eilidh did not speak.

She reached across the table. Her hand came to rest on his, and her fingers were cold, and he could feel the bones of her hand through her skin, and he had not touched her like this since she was a child, since before her mother got sick, since before he learned that love was just another word for helplessness.

"I knew she was dying," Eilidh said. "And I didn't tell you. And I've been carrying that for six years. And I thought—" Her voice broke. She did not try to fix it. "I thought if I stayed away, if I kept enough distance, maybe you'd blame me less. Maybe I could make it mean something. But you never blamed me. You just kept waiting for me to come back. And I didn't know how to come back without admitting I'd done something wrong."

"You didn't do anything wrong."

"Neither did you."

The words hung between them. Finlay felt his chest ache, felt the pressure of everything he had not said building against his ribs. He had been so careful. He had been so controlled. He had spent six years making sure he never said too much, never asked too much, never let her see how much he needed her to come home.

"I called you because of the reading," he said. "But that's not the only reason."

"I know."

"I needed you to know what it said. Not because I thought you'd believe it, but because—" He stopped. Tried again. "Because if something happens, and I didn't tell you, I couldn't live with that. I couldn't add that to the list."

Eilidh's hand was still on his. He had forgotten, for a moment, how long it had been since anyone had touched him like this. The

women who came into the Inn sometimes smiled at him, and he smiled back, and neither of them meant anything by it. He had become a man who smiled without meaning anything, and he had thought that was enough.

"I'm not staying because of the reading," Eilidh said again. She said it differently this time. Softer. More certain. "I'm staying because I need to."

"Need to."

"Yes."

The harbor light swept past the window. The beam moved slowly, the way it had moved for over a century, illuminating the water and the boats and the dark shape of the headland where the lighthouse stood. Finlay watched the light move and felt, for the first time in years, that he was not alone.

"I don't know how to help you," he said. "The reading says you're the survivor. It says the sea will claim you if the wreck happens. Mara said—Agnes said—the only way to change it is to change the terms. Pay a different price. I don't know what that means. I don't know how to do it."

"Neither do I."

"But you're staying anyway."

"I'm staying anyway."

Finlay looked at his daughter. She looked back at him. Her eyes were wet, but she was not crying—not quite—and he recognized the effort it took to hold that boundary, to not let go in front of someone who had never known how to catch you.

"The storm's coming," she said.

He had not noticed until she said it, but the windows were rattling. The sound came from the east, from the open water beyond the headland, and Finlay could feel the change in the air pressure, the way the room seemed to contract around them.

"How bad?"

"Bad." She tilted her head. Listening. "Maybe the worst in years."

The fire had burned down to embers. Finlay stood and crossed to the hearth and added a log, and the flames caught and flared and threw shadows across the walls of the room where his wife used to read by the fire, where his daughter used to fall asleep on the couch with a book open on her chest, where he had spent fifteen years pretending that keeping the Inn running was the same as keeping his family together.

"We should check the boats," he said.

"They're moored. They'll hold."

"Someone should watch the harbor."

"Dad." Eilidh stood. She was still wearing her coat. She moved to the window and looked out at the water and the darkening sky and the lighthouse beam sweeping back and forth like a warning. "There's nothing to do. Not tonight. The reading doesn't come true until the wreck. And the wreck won't happen until the storm brings the wrong ship too close to shore."

"And then?"

"Then we see what we're made of."

Finlay stood beside her. The harbor was choppy now, the waves higher than they should be for this time of evening. The boats tugged at their moorings. The gulls were gone—nothing flew above the water.

"I should have told you about your mother sooner," he said.

"Yes."

"Years sooner."

"Yes."

"I was afraid."

"I know."

"I thought if I said it out loud, it would break something. Between us. Between you and the island. I thought silence could hold it."

Eilidh turned to him. In the firelight, she looked younger, or maybe she looked exactly like she was, a woman who had carried too much for too long and had finally found somewhere to set it down.

"You can't hold anything with silence," she said. "I've been trying for six years. It just gets heavier."

Outside, the first drops of rain struck the window. Then more, harder, driven by wind that came all the way from the Atlantic. The harbor light swept past again, and in its glow, Finlay could see the white-caps forming on the water, the swells building in the open channel.

The sea was turning black.

...

They did not speak of the reading again. They talked instead about nothing—the ferry schedule, the state of the Inn’s roof, whether the Muirheads were still pushing for the heritage site designation. Small things. Safe things. The conversation of two people who had run out of big things to say and were not yet ready to admit that there was nothing left but silence.

Eilidh went to bed early. She took the room she had slept in as a child, the one that still had her old things in it—books, photographs, a scarf her mother had knitted. She did not tell Finlay she was going. She simply stood, stretched, said “I’m tired,” and climbed the stairs without waiting for a response.

Finlay stayed by the fire.

He watched the flames and listened to the rain and tried not to think about ships in distress, about signal fires lit too late, about the faces of men who drowned while he stood on solid ground and did nothing wrong.

He heard the door open behind him.

Agnes stood in the doorway. She was wearing her old oilskin, the one she had worn for forty years of ferry runs and blessing ceremonies and trips to Ellen’s Cove. Her face was grave.

“The Daughters felt it,” she said. “The current shifted an hour ago. Something is moving.”

“In the channel?”

“Past the channel. Coming in from the west.”

Finlay stood. “A ship?”

“Can’t say. But the feeling is strong. The old ones felt it before the readings came. They’d know something was wrong by the way the water tasted.”

“And now?”

“Now we wait.” Agnes stepped inside and closed the door. “The ritual requires presence. Attention. You must mean it.”

“Mara told me.”

“She told you what she knows.” Agnes moved to the fire and held her hands to the heat. She was smaller than Finlay remembered, or he had grown larger in his own perception of himself. “But knowing isn’t the same as doing. The readings don’t care what you think. They care what you’re willing to pay.”

“What’s the price?”

“For a reading this strong? I don’t know. Maybe nothing. Maybe everything.” She looked at him, and her eyes were the eyes of a woman who had buried a brother and never spoken of it and learned, through decades of silence, that some prices were paid in ways no one could see. “Eilidh’s here.”

“Yes.”

“She’s going to try to run.”

Finlay said nothing.

“The reading says she’s the survivor. That means the sea has marked her. If she tries to leave before the wreck, the wreck will follow her. The ferry won’t run in this weather—she’ll have to wait—but the current will try to pull her in. It’s already trying.”

“What do I do?”

“You let her choose.” Agnes turned back to the fire. “That’s all any of us can do. We let them choose, and we hope they’re strong enough to choose right.”

The fire crackled. The rain hammered the windows.

Above them, on the headland, the lighthouse beam swept across the cove, past the harbor, past the boats that were already straining at their moorings. Somewhere in the dark water, the tide turned.

The storm was here.

CHAPTER 21

The storm was here.



MARA heard it before she saw it—the way the wind shifted, the way the air pressure changed against her skin, the way the birds went silent on the headland. She had watched storms build on the horizon for forty years. She knew the signs the way she knew her own heartbeat. This one was not building. It had built. It was here.

She was in the cottage when it arrived, standing at the window with Finlay's words still heavy in her mind: *Something is moving. Past the channel. Coming in from the west.* Agnes had gone out into it twenty minutes ago, pulling on her old oilskin, the one she had worn for forty years of ferry runs and blessing ceremonies and trips to Ellen's Cove. Her face was grave.

Now the rain came. Not drizzle—driving horizontal sheets that hammered the windows and turned the world outside into a grey wall of noise. The wind screamed over the headland, finding the gaps in the stone, and the cottage walls shuddered the way they always did in storms. Mara did not move from the window. She watched the harbor through the blur of water running down the glass. The boats were gone from view. The water was gone from view. Everything was grey and

violent and beyond her.

Except the light.

The lighthouse mechanism hummed. She heard it through the walls, felt it in the floor, the same low vibration that had been her companion for twenty-seven years. The beam swept past the window, cutting through the rain, and she watched it go. Someone else's light now. The company maintained it for the cargo ships that came through the channel, the ships that didn't stop, didn't anchor, didn't know the names of the people who watched them pass. Mara had given thirty years to that light. Now it gave nothing back. It just turned, over and over, indifferent as the sea.

A ship was coming. She knew this the way she knew the storm: Finlay had said it, Agnes had felt it, her own body read the pressure in the same way her grandmother had taught her to read it. *The Daughters felt it. The current shifted an hour ago. Something is moving.* The Daughters were not wrong. They rarely were.

Mara put on her boots. She did not think about it. She had spent three weeks thinking, and thinking had led her nowhere. She knew what the reading meant. She knew what it meant that the message named a survivor. She knew what it meant that Eilidh Gunn was marked, that the sea had already chosen her, that no amount of thinking would change what was coming. She had learned this lesson before. She had learned it in blood and salt water and the faces of eleven men she could not save.

She had spent three weeks watching the harbor for signs of her. There had been no signs. The ferry had run twice, in the lulls between weather systems, and each time Mara had stood at the harbor road and watched the passengers come and go. No Eilidh. No one who looked like Finlay's daughter, though she had never met the woman, had only seen her once or twice as a child before the girl grew up and left and became a name that Finlay spoke with his teeth closed. Finlay did not say Eilidh's name. He said *she*, and he said *my daughter*, and he said *the girl*, and he said everything but the word that mattered. Mara had learned

to hear what people didn't say. On this island, that was the only way to survive.

She climbed down the granite steps to the rocks below. The tide was high, driven in by the storm, and the waves were crashing against the cliff face twenty feet up, spray exploding against stone, the whole headland shaking with the impact. Mara had seen this before. She had seen it a hundred times. She climbed down anyway, her boots finding the worn grooves where her own feet had carved the path over forty years. Her father had taught her this descent when she was eight years old. He had held her hand the first time. The second time he had stood at the top and watched. The third time he had let her go alone, and she had never slipped, never fallen, never doubted the stone.

Now she walked to the edge of the flat rock where she had always stopped, the place where the spray was constant and the roar of the sea filled everything, where a person could stand and watch and feel the whole weight of the ocean pressing against them. The waves were enormous. The spray soaked her coat and ran down her face and she did not wipe it away. She stood there, in the storm, in the dark, and she watched.

The lighthouse beam swept past. She watched it go. She had not turned that light on in years. The company kept it running, kept the mechanism turning, kept the light burning in a tower that was no longer hers. She thought about this sometimes. She thought about it now. The light was not hers. The tower was not hers. The sea was not hers. She owned nothing out here except the rocks beneath her feet and the salt in her lungs and the memory of eleven faces that came to her every night in the dark.

She thought about the eleven now.

Their names were in the Registry. She had looked them up once, in the harbor master's office, in the old records that no one kept anymore. She had stood at the filing cabinet and pulled the folder and read the names and then closed the folder and put it back and never gone back. The names had not helped. They had not made the faces less vivid.

They had only given her something to call them that she didn't want to use, a way of knowing them that felt like violation, like reading someone's diary, like standing in a room where you had no right to be.

The faces were enough. The faces were too much.

She had watched them die. She had lit the signal fires and watched the ship list and called the mainland and done everything right, everything she had been trained to do, and the rescue boat had been too late, the sea had been too fast, the current had pulled the bodies under before anyone could reach them. Eleven men. She had counted them in the water. She had stopped counting after six because the numbers were too much, because the faces were too much, because she stood in the tower and watched and there was nothing she could do, nothing, the light burning and the ship sinking and the sea taking what the sea wanted and the light doing nothing, doing nothing, the light just burning and the world just happening and her standing there with her hands on the controls and her eyes on the water and her voice saying *please, please, please* to a god she had stopped believing in twenty years before.

She had not slept that night. She had not slept for many nights after. The faces came to her in the dark, and she learned to live with them, learned to carry them the way she carried everything else, the way the island carried its dead, the way the sea carried its claims. You did not get over these things. You just got used to them. You built a life around them. You woke up every morning and did what needed doing and went to bed every night and carried the weight.

Mara stood on the rocks and spoke to them now. She had never done this before. She had never spoken aloud. She had thought about it. She had thought about it every night for three weeks. But thinking was not the same as doing, and now the storm was here and the ship was coming and Finlay was in the cottage above her watching the window and Agnes was preparing for something that might not work, and Mara was standing on the rocks with the rain in her face and the salt in her throat and nothing left to think.

“I cannot watch again.”

Her voice was small against the wind and the sea. It was taken immediately, absorbed into the roar, and she was grateful for that. She did not want the words to exist beyond the moment. She only wanted to say them.

“I can’t watch again.”

She had watched for thirty years. She had watched the sea take things and she had kept the light burning and she had done everything right and it had never mattered. The light did not save anyone. The light was just a light. It was iron and glass and oil and a mechanism that turned. It did not care who drowned. It did not know who lived. It just burned, over and over, while the world did what the world did.

“I know you’re out there.” She was talking to the eleven. She knew this. She had been talking to them for three weeks, in her head, in the dark, in the cottage with the fire burning and no one to hear. “I know what happened. I know I couldn’t stop it. I lit the fires and the rescue came too late and I stood in the tower and watched and there was nothing I could do. Nothing. I have spent fifteen years trying to forget the weight of that nothing. I thought if I stopped watching, if I let the light go, I could stop carrying it. But the carrying doesn’t stop. The watching doesn’t stop. I see you every night. All eleven of you. You come to me and I don’t know if you’re real or if I’m making you real because I couldn’t let you go.”

The tears came. She did not wipe them away. The rain and the spray and the tears all ran together on her face, salt water and fresh water and the water of the world mixing into something that tasted the same no matter where it came from.

“I can’t do it again.” Her voice broke. She did not care. “I can’t stand in that tower or on these rocks or anywhere and watch someone drown when I know what’s coming. I know the message. I know what it means. There’s a ship coming and a girl is marked and I can’t—I can’t—”

A hand touched her shoulder.

She spun. Her boot slipped on the wet rock and she nearly fell, but the hand caught her arm and held her steady, and she looked up into the face of Agnes, older and smaller than she remembered, her oilskin dark with rain, her eyes steady.

Agnes did not speak. She just held Mara's arm and waited, the way she had learned to wait through decades of standing with people who had no words left.

Mara wiped her face with the back of her hand. "How long have you been there?"

"Long enough."

"Finlay."

"Finlay heard you once, through his wall. He didn't know what to do with it so he didn't say anything." Agnes released her arm but did not step back. "He thinks you don't know."

"I didn't know he could hear."

"Does it matter?"

Mara looked at the sea. The waves crashed and roared and the spray flew and the lighthouse beam swept past again, indifferent. "No. I suppose it doesn't."

"The lighthouse is running. Do you hear it?"

Mara listened. The mechanism hummed through the rock, through her boots, the same sound she had heard every night for twenty-seven years. "Yes."

"The company keeps it burning for the cargo ships. The channel is narrow here. Without the light, there'd be more wrecks." Agnes paused. "That's what it's for. Not for us. For them."

"I know."

"Do you? Because you've spent fifteen years avoiding the sound of it. You leave your windows closed when the wind is from the east. You cross the road instead of walking past the tower." Agnes turned to face her directly. "You're not avoiding the light. You're avoiding what it means."

"It means I can't do anything." Mara's voice was flat. "The light

burned and the ship sank and eleven men died and the light kept burning. I lit it and it kept burning and they kept dying and the light didn't stop it. Nothing stops it."

"No." Agnes's voice was quiet. "Nothing stops it. But some things change the terms."

The words hung in the air between them. Mara thought of what Agnes had said in the cottage: *The readings don't care what you think. They care what you're willing to pay.*

"What does that mean? Change the terms?"

"Every reading has a cost. That's what the Daughters have always known. The sea gives a message and the message takes something back. Not the same thing. Not a punishment. A different price." Agnes reached into her coat and pulled out a small object—a piece of sea glass, green and worn smooth. She held it out to Mara. "My mother found this the day after my brother's burial. He was named in a reading in 1973. She kept him home from the boats. Made him work the croft. Made him stay."

Mara looked at the glass. "What happened?"

"He stayed for three years. Then he went to the sea anyway." Agnes put the glass back in her pocket. "The sea took him the same month he left."

"So the readings can't be stopped."

"They can't be stopped. But they can be moved." Agnes turned to face the water. The waves were enormous, the spray rising higher than their heads, but she stood steady, her hands in her coat pockets, her face calm. "My mother paid one price. She kept him home for three years. He was safe. He was alive. And then the sea collected what it was owed, and the debt was paid in a different way."

"A different way."

"He drowned in a harbor on the mainland. Different water. Different current. Farther from rescue." Agnes's voice was quiet. "The sea doesn't forget what it claims. If you move the person, the sea moves the danger. The wreck still happens. The death still comes. But the

location changes. The circumstances change. And sometimes—” She stopped. The wind screamed around them. The spray soaked them both. The lighthouse beam swept past, again and again, the rhythm of it like a heartbeat.

“Sometimes what?”

“Sometimes the person survives anyway. Not because the reading changes. Because something else happens. Something no one can predict.” Agnes looked at her. “The ritual I’m talking about. It’s not in the Registry. It’s older. It was here before the readings were recorded, before the Daughters had a name, before anyone thought to catalog what the sea was doing. It’s what the first people did when they came to this island. What they did to survive.”

“What does it require?”

“Presence. Attention. You must mean it.”

“That’s all?”

“That’s everything.” Agnes’s voice was gentle. “You have to stand at the edge of the water and name what you’re willing to lose. Not to bargain. Not to buy. Just to acknowledge that the sea takes what it takes, and sometimes we can choose what it takes from us. Sometimes we can give it something freely so it takes that instead.”

“And then?”

“Then the sea decides.” Agnes turned back to the water. “We don’t know what it will do. We never know. The old forms are not reliable. They were never reliable. They just gave people something to do while they waited for the sea to decide. But it’s what we have. It’s what we can offer.”

Mara thought of the eleven faces. She thought of Eilidh Gunn, who might already be dead, who might be coming home to a harbor that would watch her drown. She thought of Finlay in the cottage above them, standing by the window, watching for a light that would never be hers to control again.

“What do I have to do?”

“Tomorrow night. When the storm is overhead. Ellen’s Cove.”

Agnes looked at her. "I need to prepare. The ritual requires objects. Words. The words are in Gaelic. I learned them from my mother. She learned them from hers."

"Will it work?"

"I don't know." Agnes's voice was honest. "No one knows. The old forms are not reliable. But you asked me what you could do, and this is what there is. This is what we have."

Mara closed her eyes. The rain was cold on her face. The wind pulled at her coat. She could feel the stone beneath her feet, slick and uneven, the same stone her grandmother had stood on and her great-grandmother before that, the same stone the first islanders had used for their rituals before the Registry made it official, before the readings were named and recorded and filed away in buildings no one visited.

She opened her eyes. "What does it cost?"

Agnes was quiet for a long moment. The waves roared and the spray flew and the lighthouse beam swept past again and again, the rhythm of it like a heartbeat, like time passing, like something moving forward whether they were ready or not.

"What you're willing to pay," she said.

Mara stood on the rocks, in the storm, in the dark, and she let the question settle into her bones. Not an answer. Not yet. Just the question, the only question that mattered now, the question that had been waiting for her since she found the bottle in the rocks and read the message and understood, in her bones, what it meant.

What was she willing to pay?

The sea waited. The light swept on. Above them, in the cottage, Finlay watched the window for a ship that might not come, for a daughter who might already be gone, for a reading that had already changed everything it touched.

And Mara stood on the rocks with the rain in her hair and the question in her chest and no answer yet, only the shape of the choice she would have to make when the time came, only the knowledge that she could not watch again, could not stand by and let the sea take what it

wanted, could not light the fires and watch them fail the way they had failed before.

Something had to change. Someone had to pay.

The question was who. The question was what.

The question was whether she was strong enough to find out.

CHAPTER 22

The storm was a ceiling above them. Mara could see the way the clouds pressed down on Ellen's Cove, close enough to touch, and she could feel the weight of all that water waiting to fall. But the cove itself was still. The water lay flat as glass. Not a ripple. Not a breath of wind. The granite walls of the cove held the air in place, and the air held its silence, and Mara stood at the water's edge with her boots soaked through and her hands shaking for reasons she did not examine.



AGNES was already there. She had been there since before Mara arrived, kneeling at the place where the stone sloped down into the shallows. She did not turn when Mara came down the path. She did not need to.

"You came," Agnes said. Not a question.

"You knew I would."

"I hoped."

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Agnes had laid out her things on a flat rock: a wooden bowl cracked with age, a bundle of dried Heather tied with twine, a small tin box that Mara recognized from the Daughters' observances. A lock of hair wrapped in muslin. A coin, old and worn smooth. A word, perhaps. Or a name.

"I need you to watch," Agnes said. "And when I tell you, I need you to speak. Can you do that?"

"I don't know."

"Honest." Agnes smiled, briefly. "That's what I need. Not certainty. Honesty."

She lifted the wooden bowl and held it over the water. The crack ran along one side, dark against the pale wood. Mara had seen this bowl before, at blessings and burials, passed down through the Daughters for as long as anyone could remember. It was older than the lighthouse. Older than the Muirheads. Older than the island had a name.

Agnes spoke, and the words were not English.

Mara had grown up hearing Gaelic. Her grandmother had spoken it when she was tired or angry or deep in memory, the words falling out of her like stones dropping into water. But this was not the Gaelic of conversation. This was something older. The sounds moved like the tide—not forward but in and out, pulling back before they pushed forward, each word a wave that withdrew and returned changed.

She did not understand the words. She understood the weight of them.

Agnes lifted a pinch of salt from the bowl and let it fall. The grains caught the gray light and vanished into the water, and for a moment nothing happened. Then the surface of the cove shivered. Not a ripple—a shudder, like a body trying not to shiver and failing.

The salt sank.

Agnes lifted the bundle of heather and held it over the flame of a taper she had lit from somewhere—it burned steady and small, giving no smoke, giving no warmth. The dried flowers caught and blackened and fell, embers dropping into the water with a sound like whispered secrets. The smell of burning heather rose and mixed with the salt air, and Mara breathed it in and tasted something she could not name. Childhood, maybe. Or grief. Or the place where those two things became the same.

“Ellen Coulter,” Agnes said. Her voice had changed. The measured cadence was still there, but underneath it Mara heard the years—the forty she had spent performing these rituals, the faces she had watched the sea take, the names she had spoken into water and wind and the silence that followed. “Daughter of the engineer who built the light. She drowned here in 1901. She was twenty-three years old.”

Mara knew this. Everyone on Torran knew this. Ellen’s Cove was named for her, and the name was a warning as much as a memorial. The Muirheads had tried to change it once, in the 1960s. The island had refused.

But hearing Agnes say it here, in this stillness, with the storm pressing down and the water not moving—

Mara felt the weight of it settle into her bones.

Agnes performed the naming. She spoke the names of every wreck that had come through these waters, and the names were not in any order Mara recognized—some were old, predating her grandmother’s grandmother, and some were close enough that she could have pointed to the rocks where the ships had broken. The *Margaret Anne*, 1892. The *Dundee Pride*, 1909. The *Archibald*, which had no business being this far north and came anyway, and the sea had taken it in a single night. The cargo ship from 1998. She heard the number of the dead after each name: three, seven, twelve, eleven. Her eleven were in that list. She heard their silence, and she did not look away.

The names went on. The cove did not move.

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“Return,” Agnes said. “Return what was taken.”

The water accepted each offering without resistance. The hair drifted down. The coin turned once and vanished. The word—

Mara felt the word land. She did not hear it hit anything. She felt it land the way she felt a change in pressure before a storm, the way she felt the moment a ship decided to break.

Agnes rose. Her knees were wet to the bone. She did not complain. She turned to face Mara, and her eyes were the color of the water in the cove—gray and deep and holding things that had been placed there and never retrieved.

“You must name the survivor,” she said.

Mara’s throat closed. She had known this was coming. She had known since she woke in her cottage with the message burned into her hand, since she walked up the hill to the lighthouse and stood at its base and could not climb, since she went to Finlay and watched him refuse to believe and then went to Catriona and watched her want too much. She had known. But knowing and speaking were different countries, and the border between them was a cliff she had been standing at for three days.

“Not to ask for her life,” Agnes said. “To ask for a different price.”

“What do you mean?”

“The sea has already named her. The reading named her. When the wreck comes—” Agnes paused. She looked at the water, at the still and waiting water, and her face held something Mara had never seen there before. Fear, yes. But also certainty. The certainty of someone who has stood at this edge before and did not fall. “When the wreck

comes, the sea will take what it has claimed. Unless someone speaks for her. Unless someone offers something in her place.”

“Something.” Mara’s voice came out rough. “What something?”

“It doesn’t say. The price is never exact.” Agnes turned back to her. “I offered hair. A coin. A word. I offered things the sea might want—things that belonged to me, things I could give up without losing who I am. That’s what the ritual asks. Not a payment. A substitution. You offer something of yourself, and you ask the sea to look at that instead.”

“And if it accepts?”

“Then she lives. And you carry whatever was taken.”

“And if it doesn’t accept?”

Agnes did not answer. She did not need to.

Mara looked at the cove. The water lay flat and still, and the storm above it churned in its prison of clouds, and the air smelled of salt and heather ash and something else—something old, something that had been waiting a very long time. The faces of the eleven came to her, as they always did, and she did not push them away. She let them look at her. She let them wait.

“Finlay’s daughter,” she said.

“Yes.”

“Eilidh Gunn.”

Agnes nodded. She did not tell Mara to be sure. She did not ask if this was what she wanted. She knew what wanting had to do with it and what it did not.

“Speak her name into the water,” Agnes said. “And mean it.”

Mara stepped forward. The water rose to her calves, cold enough to ache, cold enough to remember. She had waded into water like this before—the morning she found the bottle, the morning she read the message, the morning her life became a thing that required choosing. She had not known, then, that she was choosing. She knew now.

She opened her mouth.

“Eilidh Gunn,” she said.

The name fell into the water. It did not echo. It did not ripple.

the storm was a ceiling above them. mara could see the way the clouds pressed down on ellen's cove, close enough to touch, and she could feel the weight of all that water waiting to fall. but the cove itself was still. the water lay flat as glass. not a ripple with like a stone into deep water, silent and straight, and the place, and the air held its silence, and mara stood at the water's edge with her boots soaked through and her hands shaking for reasons she did not examine.

Then the water moved.

Not a wave. Not a tide. The whole body of the cove shifted, a shudder that ran from the shallows to the □□ and back again, and Mara felt it through her boots, through her bones, through the place where fear lived and had lived for thirty years. The storm above them cracked open—not rain yet, but the sound of rain waiting, the pressure of all that water about to fall.

The cove began to fill.

Mara watched the water rise. It came in from nowhere she could see, drawn up from some deep place or some distant place or some place that had no name, and it covered the stones at the water's edge, the flat rock where Agnes had laid her things, the place where the offerings had sunk and disappeared. It rose slowly. It rose steadily. It rose until it reached the level of Mara's thighs, and then it stopped.

Not receded. Stopped.

Agnes stood beside her, still as the water, and she looked at the cove with an expression Mara could not read.

"It's waiting," Agnes said.

"For what?"

"For you to give it something." Agnes's voice was quiet. "You named her. The sea heard. Now it wants to know what you're willing to pay."

Mara looked at her hands. The message was gone from her palm—the words had faded sometime in the night, leaving only the memory of the burn. But she felt the message still. She felt the weight of the names, the survivor's name and the dead's names and her own name, standing at the edge of all of them.

She thought of the eleven faces. She thought of her grandmother, who had watched the 1916 rescue and remembered it sixty years later, who had told Mara the story and made her promise to remember. She thought of the lighthouse tower she could not climb, the light she no

longer kept, the thirty years she had spent watching ships and counting the ones that did not make it home.

She thought of Finlay, who did not believe. She thought of Catriona, who believed too much. She thought of Eilidh, who did not know yet, who was somewhere on the mainland living a life that did not include boats or islands or the weight of old names spoken into water.

The water waited.

“What do I give?” Mara asked.

Agnes shook her head. “That’s yours to know. The ritual shows you how to ask. It can’t tell you what to offer. That has to come from you.”

From her. From the place where wanting lived and had lived for fifteen years, in the silence of the cottage, in the absence of expectation. From the place where she had locked away the faces of the eleven and the weight of the lighthouse and the light she had once carried and could not carry now.

The cove filled around her. The water was at her waist. It was cold. It was still.

She did not know what she was willing to lose.

She did not know what she had left.

The storm broke above them, and the rain came down, and the water in the cove rose with it, and Mara stood at the edge of the sea and waited for the price to be named.

CHAPTER 23

The floor was cold under her cheek.



MARA opened her eyes to grey light. The cottage. She was on the floor of the cottage, and her back ached in the way that meant she'd slept wrong, the way that meant she'd slept at all, which she had not intended to do. The storm—had there been a storm? The night came back in pieces. The cove. Agnes. The naming.

The naming.

She pushed herself up. Her joints protested, her right knee especially, and she sat on the edge of the cot for a moment with her hands on her thighs, letting her breath come back to her. The cottage was cold. The fire had gone to ash sometime in the night, and the windows were crusted with salt spray where the storm had thrown itself against the cottage walls and left its mark.

Agnes was sitting at the table.

Mara hadn't heard her come in. The old woman sat with her hands folded in her lap, her coat still on, her boots still caked with the black mud of the cove. She looked like someone who had been sitting there for hours. She looked like someone who had been waiting.

"The storm passed," Agnes said.

Mara's mouth was dry. She tasted copper, and sand—she must have been lying face-down in the shallows at some point, though she didn't remember going into the water. Her boots were wet. Her sleeves were wet. The hem of her coat had soaked through and dried and soaked through again, leaving a tide line on the wool.

"How long?"

"Six hours. Maybe seven." Agnes's voice was hoarse. She had been talking to the sea. She had been naming. "The cove went still around three in the morning. I watched."

"You should have woken me."

"You needed to sleep."

Mara stood. Her legs were unsteady, but they held. She crossed to the fire and bent to feed the kindling, then thought better of it and straightened instead, standing with her back to the cold hearth. The grey light through the windows was the light of early morning, the sky heavy with cloud that hadn't finished deciding whether to rain again.

"Did it work?" Mara asked.

Agnes nodded. Her eyes were red-rimmed, exhausted, the eyes of someone who had spent the night in prayer or something that resembled it.

"The sea answered," she said.

The words settled into the cottage like a stone dropped into still water. Mara felt them ripple through her chest, through the place where hope had calcified into something she no longer trusted herself to feel.

"And?"

Agnes folded her hands tighter. "The sea will let her live."

Mara exhaled. The breath came out ragged, shaking. She pressed her palm against the mantelpiece to steady herself, feeling the cold of the stone seep into her hand, anchoring her to something solid.

"But?" she said.

"But she will lose something she loves."

The word *but* hung in the air between them. Mara had known it was coming. She had known from the moment Agnes said the word

price that it would not be simple, that the sea did not give without taking, that the readings had never been free. But knowing and hearing were different things. Knowing was abstract. Hearing was a fist closing around her ribs.

"What?" Mara asked. "What will she lose?"

Agnes shook her head. "It doesn't say. The price is never exact."

"Can't you—"

"The ritual asked. The sea answered. What it takes, it keeps to itself until the taking is done." Agnes's voice was steady, the voice of someone who had accepted the terms long ago. "That's how it works. That's how it's always worked."

Mara turned away from the hearth. She walked to the window and looked out at the cove, at the grey water lying flat and calm under the overcast sky. It looked peaceful. It looked finished. As though the storm had never happened, as though the sea had simply decided to be still, and that stillness was the answer.

"What she loves," Mara said. She was not asking Agnes to confirm. She was testing the words, feeling their weight, trying to understand what they might mean. "A person? A thing? A possibility?"

"Any of those. All of them." Agnes rose from the table, slowly, like someone whose joints had stiffened in the cold. She crossed to stand beside Mara at the window. "The readings take what the sea decides is equivalent to what was given. A life for a life is the simple accounting. But sometimes—"

"Sometimes?"

"Sometimes the sea wants something smaller. A relationship that would have been. A future that was possible. Something that mattered to the person who was supposed to die, even if it didn't matter to anyone else." Agnes looked at the water, and her face was unreadable. "My grandmother told me about a reading in 1892. A boy was named as survivor. He lived. But the girl he would have married married someone else instead, because he came back changed, and she couldn't bear it. The sea took his chance at happiness. It wasn't a life, but it was some-

thing.”

“And there’s no way to know. No way to prepare.”

“No way to know.”

Mara watched the water. The cove was still. The boats in the harbor would be damaged—she had seen the waves from the tower window, seen them breaking over the breakwater, seen the way the moorings shuddered under the strain. The storm had been bad. The storm had been worse than bad. And somewhere on the mainland, Eilidh was waking up in a flat in Edinburgh, dreaming of nothing, knowing nothing, about to learn that her life had been weighed against something she would never see.

“She’ll have to be told,” Mara said.

“Yes.”

“She’ll have to choose.”

“Yes.”

“And if she refuses? If she says she won’t pay the price?”

Agnes was quiet for a moment. The wind rattled the window frame, and a gull cried somewhere outside, high and sharp.

“Then the price is still paid,” Agnes said. “The sea doesn’t negotiate. It doesn’t wait for consent. If she won’t give what it’s asking, it takes anyway. It takes something else, something worse, something that wasn’t hers to lose.” She turned to look at Mara directly, and her eyes were steady and sad. “That’s what the readings are. That’s what they’ve always been. Warnings that come too late to change anything. The survivor lives. That’s the one thing that’s certain. But what surviving costs—only the survivor knows.”

Mara thought of the eleven faces. She thought of them now, not as they had been when she first saw them through the rain-streaked glass of the tower, but as they had been when the rescue boat finally reached them, broken and waterlogged, their skin the color of old wax. She had learned their names afterward. She had said them aloud in the cottage, alone, in the dark, and she had never said them again. The sea had taken them, and what they had loved—their wives, their children, their

futures—none of it had mattered. The sea had wanted them, and the sea had taken them, and that was the only accounting that counted.

Eilidh would not die. That was the answer. That was the thing Mara had gone into the water to ask for, and that was the thing Agnes said the sea had granted. Eilidh would live.

But she would lose something she loved.

Mara pressed her forehead against the cold glass of the window. She could feel the grain of the wood under her fingertips, the slight give of the putty, the vibration of the wind against the frame. The cottage had stood here for over a hundred years. It had survived storms that made the walls groan and storms that made the roof shake. It would survive this one too. It would stand here long after Mara was gone, and the sea would still be taking, still be giving, still be keeping its accounts in a ledger no one could read.

“I have to tell her,” Mara said.

Agnes nodded. “You do.”

“She needs to know what it will cost. She needs to know what she’ll lose.”

“She needs to know.”

“But she might refuse.” Mara turned from the window, and the cold of the room hit her like a wall. “She might say no. She might say she’d rather die.”

“Then she dies.”

The words were blunt, flat, without comfort. Agnes said them the way the sea would have said them—without malice, without pity, without any acknowledgment that the choice mattered to anyone except the person making it.

“And if she dies, the reading comes true anyway. The other survivor clause. The one where ships that should have rescued her sink. The one where ropes that should have held break.” Agnes crossed her arms, and she looked old, older than Mara had ever seen her, old in the way that the island itself was old. “The sea doesn’t forget what it’s claimed. If Eilidh runs, the wreck follows her. If she hides, the wreck finds her.

If she refuses to be saved, the sea saves her anyway and takes the price from somewhere else. From someone else.”

“Who?”

Agnes shook her head. “Anyone. The reading names a survivor, but it doesn’t name who pays. That’s the part they never tell you. That’s the part that isn’t in the Registry.”

Mara thought of Finlay. Finlay, who did not believe. Finlay, who would fight the reading with every practical tool at his disposal—ferry schedules, weather reports, the weight of his own refusal to accept what he could not control. Finlay, who would try to save his daughter by keeping her away from the island, not understanding that the sea did not care about geography.

“It could be him,” Mara said. “The price could fall on Finlay.”

“Yes.”

“And if it does—”

“Then he pays. And she lives. And the debt is settled.” Agnes moved toward the door, her boots leaving small dark prints on the stone floor. “That’s the other thing the readings don’t tell you. Who will break. Who will bend. Who will pay the price you couldn’t warn them about.”

She stopped at the door and turned back. The grey light caught the lines of her face, the exhaustion in her eyes, the set of her jaw. She looked like someone who had been carrying something heavy for a very long time and had finally, finally set it down.

“You named her,” Agnes said. “You went into the water and you named her and the sea heard. That means the price is yours to offer, or hers to pay. But it’s being paid either way. The only question is whether she knows it’s coming.”

She opened the door. The wind came in, salt and cold and wet, carrying the smell of the harbor—the diesel, the fish oil, the rot of the things the storm had torn loose. Somewhere down the hill, a bell was ringing. The ferry was coming in. The island was waking up to find itself battered but still standing, still breathing, still waiting for the sea

to decide what it wanted next.

“I’m going to the harbor,” Mara said.

Agnes nodded. She stepped out into the wind and did not look back, and Mara watched her go, watched the old woman walk down the path toward the village with her coat pulled tight around her and her head bowed against the weather. Then Mara turned from the door and pulled on her boots and went to find Finlay and Eilidh.

...

The harbor was quieter than it should have been.

Mara stood at the top of the dock and looked down at the boats. Two of them had torn free from their moorings in the night—the ropes had snapped or come undone, and they had drifted against the rocks at the harbor’s edge, scraping their hulls against the granite in the dark. One of them was listing badly, its starboard side stove in, water pooling in the well. The other had been driven up onto the stones and would need to be hauled off by hand, a job that would take six men and half a day.

She counted the boats she could see. Six total. Three working, three damaged. The same ratio as always, or close to it. The island had been dying for as long as Mara could remember, and the boats were a measure of it—not the dramatic failures, the sinkings and the drownings, but the slow attrition of things that could not be repaired, could not be replaced, could not be sustained against the weight of time and weather and the sea that took what it wanted and gave back only what it chose.

Finlay was standing at the end of the dock.

He had not seen her yet. He was looking out at the water, at the boats that had survived and the boats that had not, and his hands were in his pockets and his shoulders were hunched against the wind. He looked tired. He looked old. He looked like a man who had spent the night awake, waiting for the storm to pass, praying to gods he did not

believe in that his daughter was safe on the mainland, far from the water that had taken everything else.

“Finlay.”

He turned. His face when he saw her was complicated—relief and suspicion and something that might have been anger, all tangled together in the lines around his mouth. He had not slept. She could see it in the shadows under his eyes, in the way he moved, in the slight unsteadiness of his stance.

“Mara. You’re alive.”

“Mostly.”

“The storm—” He stopped. He looked back at the harbor, at the damaged boats, at the water that was still choppy with the memory of what it had done. “The storm was bad. I’ve never seen it like that. I thought—” He stopped again, and this time the word that came out was different. “Eilidh called. Last night, when the storm started. She couldn’t sleep. She said she kept dreaming about the harbor.”

Mara felt the words land in her chest like stones.

“What did she dream?”

“I don’t know. She couldn’t say. She just said she couldn’t sleep, and she was worried, and she wanted to know if the boats were all right.” Finlay laughed, but there was no humor in it. “She wanted to know if the boats were all right. That’s my daughter. Worried about the boats.”

“Did you tell her?”

“Tell her what? That the storm was bad? That I was worried?” He shook his head. “I told her to go back to bed. I told her the boats would survive. I told her to stop worrying about things she couldn’t control.”

Mara nodded. She understood. She understood perfectly. Finlay had spent his whole life trying to protect his daughter from the things she could not control, and in doing so he had made her feel that the things she could not control were the things that mattered. He had spent his whole life fighting the sea, and in doing so he had made her believe that the sea was something that could be fought.

But the sea did not fight. The sea simply was. It took what it wanted, when it wanted, and no amount of ferry schedules or weather reports or prayers to gods of steel and diesel could change that.

“Eilidh’s coming back,” Mara said.

Finlay went still. The word *still* was the only way to describe it—he had been moving, breathing, existing, and then he was not. He was a statue, carved from the same granite as the island, rooted to the dock by a weight she could not see.

“What?”

“She called the ferry this morning. Before dawn. She wanted to come home.” Mara watched his face, watched the war between hope and fear play out in the lines of his forehead, the clench of his jaw. “She’s on the boat now. She’ll be here by noon.”

“The ferry doesn’t run in weather like this—”

“It’s running. The captain said the worst is over.” She did not tell him where she had learned this, or what the captain had said before the ferry□□ed to make the crossing. Some things were better left unexplained. “She’s coming home, Finlay. She’s on her way.”

He opened his mouth. He closed it. He turned away from her and looked at the water, and she could see him trying to find a reason to hope, trying to construct a version of events where his daughter’s sudden decision to return was a coincidence, a whim, a sign that she was finally ready to come home instead of a sign that she was already running from something she could not name.

Mara let him have his silence. She had given him the truth, or as much of it as she could give, and now the rest was up to him. He would have questions. He would have demands. He would want to know why Eilidh was suddenly, inexplicably coming home, and he would not be satisfied with any answer that did not make sense, that did not fit into the framework of cause and effect he had spent his whole life building around himself.

But there was no answer that would make sense. That was the thing about the readings. That was the thing about the sea. The answers were

there, but they did not make sense. They simply were.

“Finlay,” she said, and her voice was quiet, the quiet she used when she was talking about the eleven, when she was talking about the things that could not be fixed. “There’s something else.”

He turned back. His face was raw, unguarded, stripped of the defenses he usually wore. He looked like a man who had been bracing for bad news all night and had finally stopped pretending it was not coming.

“Tell me.”

So she did. She told him about the bottle and the message, about the reading that named Eilidh as the sole survivor, about the wreck that was coming and the storm that was the first sign of it. She told him about Agnes and the ritual, about the naming and the asking and the price that had to be paid. She told him that the sea would let his daughter live, but that she would lose something she loved, and that no one could say what that something would be until the taking was done.

She told him all of it, and she watched his face as she spoke, watched the disbelief rise and fall, watched the anger come and go, watched the fear settle into his bones and stay there. When she finished, he was silent for a long time.

The harbor was still. The wind had died down, or perhaps she had simply stopped hearing it. The gulls wheeled overhead, crying their endless hunger, and the boats creaked at their moorings, and somewhere out on the water, the ferry was making its way toward the island, carrying Eilidh home.

“Tell me what to do,” Finlay said. His voice was hoarse. He did not look at her. “Tell me how to stop it.”

Mara shook her head. “You can’t stop it.”

“Then tell me how to change it. Tell me how to pay a different price.”

“You can’t do that either.”

“Then tell me—” He stopped. He pressed his hands against his face, and for a moment he was not Finlay the innkeeper, not Finlay the

practical man, not Finlay the skeptic who did not believe in readings or rituals or the sea's intelligence. He was just a father, afraid for his child, and Mara understood that fear because she had carried it herself for thirty years, for the eleven, for the faces she could not forget.

"Tell me what you need," he said finally. "Tell me what to do. I don't care about the readings. I don't care about the sea or the price or any of it. Just tell me how to save my daughter."

Mara looked at him. She looked at the harbor, at the boats that had survived and the boats that had not, at the water that was calm now but would not stay calm, at the island that had stood here for a hundred years and would stand here for a hundred more, weathering whatever the sea decided to throw at it.

She thought of her grandmother, who had watched the 1916 rescue and remembered it sixty years later. She thought of the lighthouse tower she could not climb, the light she no longer kept, the thirty years she had spent watching ships and counting the ones that did not make it home.

She thought of Eilidh, who was on the ferry now, who was coming home to an island that was about to tell her that her life had been weighed and measured and found worthy of survival, but only at a price.

"Wait," Mara said. "She's on the ferry. She'll be here by noon. I'll tell her everything—the message, the price, what the sea has asked. And then she chooses."

"And if she chooses wrong?"

Mara did not answer. There was no answer. The sea did not deal in wrong choices or right choices. The sea dealt in tides and storms and the slow, inexorable weight of what it wanted. Eilidh would choose, and whatever she chose, the sea would take what it was owed.

But at least she would know. At least she would have the chance to decide what she was willing to lose, rather than having it taken without her consent.

That was the only thing Mara could give her. That was the only

thing any of them could give.

The choice.

“Go to the harbor master’s office,” she said. “Make sure the ferry can dock. The moorings are damaged—I don’t know if it can tie up safely.”

Finlay stared at her. “You’re changing the subject.”

“I’m giving you something to do.” She turned from the dock and started walking, toward the path that led up the hill, toward the cottage, toward the place where she would wait until the ferry arrived. “You can’t stop what’s coming. But you can make sure the harbor is ready. You can make sure the boats are secured. You can make sure that when she steps off that ferry, there’s a place for her to stand.”

She did not wait for his answer. She walked up the path, her boots slipping on the wet grass, her coat catching the wind. Behind her, Finlay stood at the edge of the dock, watching her go, and she could feel his eyes on her back like a weight.

The harbor was still. The boats were damaged. The ferry was coming.

And somewhere on the water, Eilidh was dreaming of harbors she did not understand, counting boats she could not see, moving toward a home that was about to tell her the price of staying alive.

Mara climbed the hill alone.

CHAPTER 24

The Inn was warm. Mara had forgotten what warm felt like when it wasn't the cottage and its peat fire, when it was a room full of bodies and heat from the kitchen and the particular closeness that came from too many people in too small a space. She stopped in the doorway and let her eyes adjust.



FINLAY sat at the table nearest the fire. Eilidh sat across from him. Between them, two cups of tea gone cold, and the space where a conversation had been—Mara could see it in the way they weren't looking at each other, the way Eilidh's hands were wrapped around her cup as though it were the only solid thing in the room.

Finlay saw her first. His face did something complicated, and then he was standing, and then he was crossing the room, and his hand was on her arm, and he was saying her name like it was an accusation.

"You went up the hill," he said.

"I came back down."

"You were supposed to stay. I told you to stay."

"You told me to stay away from your daughter." Mara looked past him, to where Eilidh had risen from her chair and was standing very still, watching. "I didn't promise to obey."

Finlay's grip on her arm tightened, then released. He stepped back. His face was red—from the fire, from something else. "She came on the morning ferry. She came home. That's—that's what she does. She comes home."

"Does she."

"She came home."

Eilidh spoke from across the room. Her voice was steady, which surprised Mara. Young women who had just been told they were marked for death did not usually sound steady. "He told me about the message. The reading. He told me what it says."

"And what does it say?"

"That I drown." Eilidh's hands were still around her cup. She looked down at them as though they belonged to someone else. "That I'm the only one who survives, but I drown. I don't understand that part. How do you survive drowning?"

"You don't," Mara said. "That's why there's a price."

The room had gone quiet. The other patrons—the three fishermen at the back table, the old woman by the window who was always there, the weekenders who had wandered in for lunch and now sat frozen with their forks halfway to their mouths—all of them were listening, and none of them were pretending not to. This was the island. This was what happened when you spoke in public. You spoke to everyone.

Finlay turned to Eilidh. "She doesn't know what she's talking about. Readings are—there's no proof, there's never been any proof, it's superstition and old women and—"

"Finlay."

"Don't tell me to be quiet."

"I'm not telling you to be quiet. I'm telling you to listen." Mara moved past him, toward the fire, toward the table where Eilidh stood.

the inn was warm. mara had forgotten what warm felt like when it wasn't the cottage and its peat fire, when it was a room full of bodies and heat from the kitchen and the particular closeness that came from too many people in too
“Your daughter came home. She got on a boat and she came back to an island that was about to tell her that her life had been weighed and measured and found worthy of survival, but only at a price.”

“That’s not—”

“The sea will let her live,” Mara said. She was close enough now to see the fine lines around Eilidh’s eyes, the exhaustion that sat in her like a stone. This was Finlay’s daughter. This was the child he had watched grow, the child he had lost to Edinburgh and a life that was not this one, the child he had clung to after her mother died. “But she will lose something she loves. That’s the bargain. That’s what the sea has asked.”

Finlay made a sound. It was not a word. It was the sound of something tearing.

“No.” He was shaking his head. “No. Not again. We don’t make bargains with the sea. We don’t—we don’t negotiate with it, we don’t—we don’t give it things, we just—”

“Finlay.”

“Someone drowned in 1987. Did you know that? A man from the Cairn family went swimming in Ellen’s Cove and didn’t come back. And afterward they said the sea had taken him because he’d made a bargain, fifty years before, when he was young and stupid and thought he could get something for nothing. They said the price had finally come due.” His voice was rising. The fishermen in the back were staring. The weekenders had put down their forks entirely. “That man was my grandfather. He drowned because his father made a deal, and now you’re telling me my daughter—”

“Your grandfather made a bargain to save someone,” Mara said. “Someone he loved. He paid the price when it came, and the sea let him live until it didn’t. That’s how it works. The debt doesn’t come due until it comes due.”

“That’s not—that’s not a reason. That’s not a reason to—”

“What would I lose?”

Eilidh’s voice cut through Finlay’s. She had not moved from her position by the table, had not raised her voice, had not done anything

but ask a question, but the room went quiet for her the way it always went quiet for women who had learned to make themselves heard in places that did not want to hear them.

Mara turned to face her. "I don't know. That's how it works. The reading tells you that you will lose something. It doesn't tell you what. It doesn't give you a list. It just—takes."

"So I could lose anything."

"Yes."

"My car. My job. My—"

"Anything you love."

Eilidh was quiet for a moment. She looked at her father. Mara watched the conversation pass between them without words—years of silence, years of leaving, years of grief neither of them had known how to carry. Finlay's face was raw. His hands were clenched at his sides.

"I'd rather lose something than lose everything," Eilidh said.

The words landed in the room like a stone in still water. Mara felt the ripples move outward—Finlay flinching, the fishermen turning away, the old woman by the window closing her eyes as though in prayer or in memory.

"Eilidh." Finlay's voice broke on her name. "Eilidh, you don't have to—you don't have to decide now, you don't have to decide at all, we can wait, we can think, we can—"

"What would thinking change?"

"I don't know. Something. Anything." He was moving toward her, reaching for her, the same gesture he had made with Mara at the door—grabbing hold as though physical contact could stop what was coming. "There has to be something. Another way. A different price."

"There isn't."

"How do you know? You're not—you're not an expert, you're just a woman who found a bottle, you're just—"

"I'm the woman who has watched the sea take things for thirty years." Mara's voice was quiet. It did not need to be loud. The room was listening. "I'm the woman who lit the signal fires when the *Mairead*

the inn was warm. mara had forgotten what warm felt like when it wasn't the cottage and its peat fire, when it was a room full of bodies and heat from the kitchen and the particular closeness that came from too many people in too small a space. She stopped in the doorway and let her hand adjust

to the door handle. She had been in the harbor every morning and knew which ones wouldn't come back. I'm the woman who knows what the readings cost because I have seen the people who paid them, and I am telling you now: there is no other price. There is no bargaining with the sea. There is only what it asks, and what you give it, and whether you can live with the difference."

Finlay's hand was on Eilidh's shoulder. He was holding her like she was something that might fall, or something that might fly away. His face was wet. Mara had not seen him cry since the funeral.

"Then I'll pay it," Eilidh said.

"Eilidh—"

"I'll pay it." She stepped back from her father's touch, and the motion was not rejection but necessity—she needed the space, needed the room to stand in, needed to be her own person in this moment and not his child. "I'll get on the ferry. I'll take my chances. And if the sea wants something in return, I'll give it."

"You can't just—"

"Dad." She looked at him. "I came home. I got on the boat and I came back, and I don't know why, I don't know what made me do it, but I did it. And now I'm here, and the message says I survive, and all I have to do is pay a price I don't know yet." She took a breath. Her voice was steady. Mara wondered how she had learned to sound so steady, this young woman who had grown up on an island and fled to the city and come back to find her life measured out in tide and storm. "I'd rather lose something than lose everything."

Finlay said nothing. His hands fell to his sides. He stood there, in the warm room that smelled of cooking and bodies and the sea that had made them all, and he looked at his daughter with the face of a man who had finally understood that he could not hold on.

Mara went to the window. Outside, the harbor was still. The clouds had thinned. The wind had dropped. For the first time in days, the weather held.

"Ferry comes at noon," she said. "Weather window opens in an

hour. If she's going to go, she goes now."

Finlay made a sound. It might have been a word. It might have been her name.

Eilidh was already moving. She crossed to her father and she put her hand on his arm, briefly, and she said something Mara could not hear, and then she was walking toward the door, toward the harbor, toward the water that had been waiting for her all along.

Mara watched her go. She watched Finlay stand frozen by the fire, watched the fishermen exchange glances, watched the weekenders look at their half-eaten lunch with expressions of people who had stumbled into something they did not understand and would not be able to explain.

Outside, the sky was clearing. The storm was over. The sea was waiting.

And somewhere on the water, the ferry was coming, and on it was a woman who had chosen to pay a price she did not know, and the only question left was the one that had no answer: what would she lose?

Mara followed her out the door.

CHAPTER 25

The Harbor



THE ferry came at half past noon.

Eilidh had counted the boats in the harbor that morning—she did this without meaning to, the way her father counted them, the way everyone on Torran counted them, a tally that was never finished because the tally was the point. Six boats in the water. Two in the dry dock. The supply ferry tied at the far buoy, its hull dark with fuel oil, its engine growling low in the morning calm.

The waves were still high. She could see them from the Inn's window, white-capped and restless, the swells from three days of storm not yet settled into the long Atlantic rhythm that would eventually calm them. The weather window had opened, Mara said. The coast guard had cleared the route. But the sea remembered the storm even when the sky had forgotten it, and the water knew what it had done.

Eilidh put her pack on her shoulder. She had packed that morning, quickly, the way you pack when you want to leave before you're sure you want to leave. Her father's jacket was folded on the chair where she'd left it. She hadn't worn it. She wouldn't wear it. That was a choice she was making, one of many she was making, and she would

not unpick it by taking comfort in wool that smelled like peat smoke and old men's tobacco.

The common room was empty. The weekenders had gone out walking, toward the cairn or the hidden bay on the north side where the seals gathered. The fishermen had gone to their boats. Her father was in the kitchen, scraping something, the sound of metal on metal carrying through the closed door.

She walked out without telling him.

The harbor was a hundred yards from the Inn, down the single street that was more packed earth than road, and Eilidh walked it in five minutes because she had walked it every day of her childhood and her body remembered the way even when she wanted to forget. The smell came first—diesel and fish oil and the particular green of boat paint that had been applied too many times. Then the sound: seagulls arguing over something in the shallows, the slap of water against hulls, the low thrum of the ferry's engine idling at the buoy.

Finlay was standing at the end of the pier.

She had known he would be there. She had hoped he would be there and she had dreaded it, and now she was doing both things at once, her chest tight with something she couldn't name. He was looking at the ferry, at the water, at the sky. He was not looking at her until she was close enough that looking away would have meant something, and then he turned, and his face was the face she had known for thirty-two years, and it was also a face she no longer recognized.

"The ferry's late," he said.

"I know."

"The tide's not quite right. They're waiting for the next swell."

"I know."

She stopped a few feet from him. The harbor stones were rough under her boots—old granite, worn smooth by a hundred years of boots and weather and the slow grinding of the sea. She had played on these stones as a child. She had scraped her knees on them. She had learned to swim from the buoy line, her father's hands under her arms, his voice

counting backward until he let go.

She did not say goodbye.

There was nothing to say. She had said everything that mattered in the Inn, in the room that smelled of cooking and bodies and the sea that had made them all. She had said she came home. She had said she didn't know why. She had said she would rather lose something than lose everything, and she had meant it, and now the meaning of it was waiting on the water in the form of a ferry that was already thirty minutes late.

Finlay looked at her for a long moment. His hands were at his sides. He did not reach for her. That was a choice he was making.

"The reading said you survive," he said.

"I know."

"That doesn't mean anything has to change."

"I know."

Another moment. The ferry's engine growled, a low idling sound that vibrated through the stones and up into her boots. She could feel it in her feet, the ferry's restlessness, the way it wanted to be moving.

"I'll be at the Inn," Finlay said. "When you get to the mainland. I'll call. We'll talk."

"Sure."

This was what they did. They made plans that they both knew were lies. They talked about the future as though the future were a place they would both reach, and they did not talk about the water between now and then, the cold gray swells that were still remembering the storm.

Eilidh turned and walked toward the ferry.

The gangplank was down, a narrow wooden bridge from the pier to the ferry's deck, and she crossed it with her pack on her shoulder and her boots loud on the weathered boards. The deck was empty except for the captain, a man she didn't know, someone from the mainland who drove the ferry back and forth and probably thought Torran was a small and slightly ridiculous place where people counted boats and believed in messages in bottles.

She found a seat at the stern. The benches were bolted to the deck, salt-stained, comfortable in the way that hard things become comfortable when you've sat in them enough times. The gunwale was low enough that she could lean her arms on it, rest her chin on her hands, watch the island recede.

The engine revved. The ferry pulled away from the buoy, turned in a wide arc, and pointed its bow toward the mainland.

Torran fell behind her.

She watched the lighthouse first. It stood on its promontory, sixty-two feet of stone above the waterline, and from this distance it was just a white tower against the gray sky, a mark on the horizon that told you where you were. Mara would be at her cottage. Mara would be watching the ferry come in or go out, the way she always watched, the way she had watched for thirty years before she stopped keeping the light.

Then the harbor shrank. The Inn became a smudge of stone and thatch. The street became a line. Her father's figure on the pier became a dot, and then there was no dot, there was only the sea, and she was on the water, and the water was deep, and the waves were still high.

The first twenty minutes were uneventful.

Eilidh sat at the stern and watched the island shrink. The mainland grew on the horizon, a dark line that was more promise than land, the place where she had built a life that had nothing to do with tide and storm and her father's counting. She was going back. She was going to be a person who happened to have grown up on an island, not an island person who happened to live elsewhere. She was going to be free.

The sun broke through the clouds. The water went from gray to silver, and the silver was blinding, and for a moment she let herself feel something like hope.

Then the engine made a sound she had never heard before.

It was not a growl anymore. It was a cough, a stutter, a failure of something that should not have been able to fail. The ferry lurched, just slightly, and the sound changed, and then there was silence where the engine had been, and the ferry began to drift.

Eilidh sat up.

The deck was tilting. Not much—not yet—but enough that she could feel it in her boots, the shift of weight, the wrongness of a boat that should have been level and wasn't. She stood and held the gunwale and looked forward. The captain was at the wheel, his hands moving over controls that were not responding. A crewman—the only other person on board—was shouting something, but the words were lost in the wind and the sudden silence of a boat that had stopped making the sounds a boat should make.

"Engine's gone," someone said. She didn't know who. "She's taking on water."

The ferry listed further.

Eilidh moved to the side and looked at the hull. She couldn't see damage from here—couldn't see anything except the way the ferry was settling, the way it was leaning to one side like something tired, like something that had decided to stop fighting. The deck beneath her feet was wet now, spray from waves that were catching them broadside, and the swells that were still high were no longer something to be respected but something to be feared.

The captain was shouting again. "Life jackets. Under the seats. Everyone put on a life jacket."

There was no one to hear him except Eilidh and the crewman. The ferry was a supply boat, not a passenger vessel—it carried cargo in the forward hold and a handful of people in the stern, and on this crossing there were only three of them. The captain. The crewman. And her.

Eilidh opened the compartment under her seat. The life jacket was orange, standard issue, the kind that would keep her head above water if she had the strength to keep her head above water, if the cold didn't take that strength first. She pulled it on and clipped the straps and did the things you do when you are on a boat that is sinking, things you have rehearsed in your mind a hundred times and never thought you would actually do.

The ferry rolled.

It happened fast. One moment the deck was beneath her feet, sloping but stable. The next moment it wasn't, and she was sliding, and the world turned, and the water came up to meet her.

Cold.

The cold was a shock that knocked the breath out of her before she understood what was happening. It hit her face, her hands, her whole body, and for a moment she couldn't move, couldn't think, could only feel the sharpness of water that remembered winter even when the sky was mild. She went under. The gray light of the surface was above her, and she kicked toward it, and her lungs were burning, and she broke the surface and gasped and went under again.

The water was deep here. She knew this without knowing how she knew it—the way her father had taught her to read water, the way she had learned to feel the slope of a bottom and the pull of a current. The ferry was in water that was deeper than the hull was long, and it was going down, and she was in that water, and her life jacket was holding her up but the waves were high and the cold was getting deeper and the gray sky was above her and she was alone.

She was not alone for long.

She saw the boats first—two small shapes on the horizon, moving fast, coming toward her. She understood what they were even before she understood what was happening. The harbor at Torran had sent its boats. Her father had called them, or someone had called them, and the boats were coming, and rescue was coming, and she would be fine.

The first boat capsized a hundred yards from her.

She saw it happen. One moment the boat was riding a swell, its hull steady, its small engine pushing it through the water. The next moment it was over, turned on its side, and the people in it were in the water, and the boat was sinking, and the people were struggling in the gray waves that were still high and still hungry.

The second boat didn't capsize. It came on, fast, its engine straining against a swell that was too much for a small boat to take. It reached her. She saw hands reaching for her, faces that were trying to be calm,

the crewman's hand gripping her arm and pulling her toward the boat's side. She was climbing out of the water. She was getting into the boat. She was alive.

Behind her, the ferry went under.

She heard it—the sound of a boat sinking, the gurgle and rush of water filling a space that had been holding air. She turned and saw the bubbles rising, saw the surface breaking and reforming, saw the place where the ferry had been and where the ferry was no longer. The water closed over it. Within minutes, there was nothing left but a slick of diesel and the memory of something that had existed and no longer did.

The crewman was holding her arm. The man who had pulled her from the water was talking to the man at the boat's tiller, words she couldn't quite hear, words about the other boat, about the people in the water, about the rescue that was not going to plan.

"How many?" she asked. Her voice was hoarse. Her teeth were chattering. The cold was in her bones now, and she was shaking, and she was alive.

"Three," the crewman said. "Three in the water. The first boat—"

"What about the first boat?"

The man at the tiller answered. "She's gone under. Took on too much water. The people—"

He didn't finish. He didn't need to finish. Eilidh looked at the water where the first boat had been. The swells were breaking over something—a hull, a person, she couldn't tell—and the current was pulling everything toward the deeper water where the ferry had gone down, and the gray was swallowing everything that fell into it.

The people in the water were gone.

She was in the boat. She was alive. She had been pulled out, and the ferry had sunk, and the boats that had come to rescue her had not all arrived, and she was the only one who had been saved.

The reading said she survived.

She lay in the bottom of the rescue boat and felt the cold water in

her boots and the shaking in her hands and the gray sky above her, and she understood that she had survived not because the boats had come but despite the boats that had come. The first boat had sunk. The people who had tried to save her had drowned. The second boat had reached her, and she did not know why, and she could not ask, because the man at the tiller was looking at the water where his friends had gone and he was not speaking and his face was the face of a man who had lost something he would never be able to name.

The sea keeps what it has claimed.

The harbor at Torran grew larger as they approached. Eilidh saw the pier, the stones, the gathering crowd—fishermen and weekenders and her father standing at the water's edge with his hands at his sides and his face the face of a man who did not know whether to be relieved or destroyed. The boat scraped against the pier. Hands reached down. She was lifted out of the boat and set on the harbor stones, and she was on her knees, and she was shaking, and she was alive.

She looked up at her father.

He didn't move. He didn't speak. He stood there with the harbor behind him and the island that had made them both and the sea that was still taking things, and he looked at his daughter who had come home and almost died and survived because the reading had said she would survive, and his face was the face of a man who finally understood that he could not hold on.

Eilidh lay back on the stones.

The sky was gray. The clouds had not come back, but they had not cleared either—they were holding, suspended, the way the sea was holding, the way everything on this island was holding its breath and waiting for something to change. She watched the sky. She felt the cold in her boots and the wet in her coat and the shaking that would not stop, and she breathed, and she was alive, and she knew what she had paid.

The harbor was silent. The crowd was silent. Her father was silent. Someone had put a blanket over her shoulders and someone had brought

a flask of something hot and someone had called for a doctor, but Eilidh didn't move. She lay on the stones and watched the sky and breathed and understood that she would never leave again.

Not because she couldn't. Because the reading had named her, and the sea had taken her price, and the price was the home she had almost found. The boats that should have saved her had sunk. The people who had reached for her had drowned. The sea did not forget what it had claimed, and it had claimed her, and she would live, but she would live here, on this island, in the wake of a wreck that had killed four people to keep her breathing.

She watched the sky. The clouds were thinning. Somewhere to the west, the sun was breaking through.

Eilidh closed her eyes.

Behind her, the harbor held its breath. Behind her, her father stood at the water's edge and finally let go. Behind her, the sea was quiet, and it was waiting, and it had taken what it was owed.

She was alive.

She would never be whole.

CHAPTER 26

The Price Paid



SHE was alive.
She would never be whole.

The doctor had come and gone. Someone had given her dry clothes. Someone had put her in a chair by the fire in the back room of the Inn, and she sat there with a blanket over her shoulders and a cup of tea in her hands that she had not yet tasted, and she watched the steam rise and fall and rise and fall, and she understood.

The harbor was quiet now. The boats that had come out for her had gone back to their moorings. The crowd that had gathered on the stones had dispersed to their houses and their suppers and their evenings that would end in sleep and dreams of other things. Four men were dead. She knew this without being told. She had seen their faces in the water. She had seen the sea take them.

She set the tea down on the table beside her. Her hands were shaking. They had not stopped shaking since she had come up out of the water, and she did not think they would stop again.

The door opened.

Finlay stood in the doorway.

He looked older than he had that morning. He looked like a man who had been awake for a very long time and had reached the part of the night where sleep was no longer possible and morning was no longer a relief. He stepped into the room and closed the door behind him and stood there, looking at her, and she looked back at him, and neither of them spoke.

The fire crackled. Somewhere in the front of the Inn, a chair scraped against the floor. Someone laughed, quietly, and then stopped.

“Eilidh,” he said.

“Dad.”

He crossed the room and sat down in the chair across from her. The fire was between them. The light it threw made shadows on his face that she had never noticed before—lines around his eyes, a heaviness to his jaw. She had been looking at him wrong, she realized. She had been looking at him the way she had looked at the island for years, seeing only what she needed to see and refusing to see the rest.

She had not known he had so many shadows.

“The doctor said you can travel,” he said. “Tomorrow. The ferry will run.”

She nodded. She had known this already. She had known it before she had come up out of the water, before the boats had reached her, before the rope had broken and the sea had taken the men who were trying to save her. She had known it the way she knew her own name. She was going to leave. She had always been going to leave.

“I can’t stay,” she said.

The words came out quieter than she had intended. She had thought she would have to force them, that they would stick in her throat like bones. But they came out easily, almost gently, and she did not know what to do with that.

“I thought I could,” she said. “When I came back. I thought maybe I could. I thought maybe this time—”

She stopped. She looked at the fire. The flames were low. The peat was burning down.

"I lost the island," she said. "I lost the only chance I had to belong here."

Finlay did not speak. He sat in his chair with his hands on his knees and his eyes on her face, and she could see him understanding. She could see him putting the pieces together the way he put together problems with the boats, the way he looked at a broken engine and saw not just what was wrong but what had been wrong all along and what would be wrong in the future if he did not fix it now.

She watched him understand, and she waited for him to argue.

He did not.

"The sea took you," he said. "When you were in the water. It took you and it didn't give you back."

"I don't know what it gave me back," she said. "I don't know what I'm carrying now. But I know I can't stay. I know if I stay here I'll—"

She stopped again. She did not know how to finish that sentence. She did not know what would happen if she stayed. She only knew that something had changed in the water, something had shifted, and the island that had almost been home was not home anymore. It was something else. Something that held her wreck and her survival and four men who would never go home to their wives and children, and she could not live in the middle of that. She could not wake up every morning and see the harbor where it had happened and know that she was the reason.

"I knew," Finlay said.

She looked at him.

"When you were in the water," he said. "I knew. I knew the sea was going to take you, and I would have lost everything."

His voice was steady. That was the strange thing. She had expected him to break, to cry, to argue with her the way he argued with everything that did not fit into his understanding of how the world should work. But his voice was steady, and his hands were still on his knees, and he looked at her with something in his eyes that she had never seen before.

She did not know what it was.

"I can't stop you," he said. "I couldn't stop you before, and I can't stop you now. I've been trying to hold on to you since your mother died, and all I've done is push you further away."

"Dad—"

"Let me finish."

She closed her mouth.

"I've been telling myself I was protecting you. Keeping you safe. Making sure you didn't make the same mistakes I made, or your mother's mistakes, or the mistakes that everyone on this island has been making for generations. But that's not what I was doing." He paused. The fire popped, sending a spray of sparks up the chimney. "I was trying to keep you because I couldn't keep her. And that was never fair to you."

Eilidh felt something crack in her chest. It was not a physical sensation, but it felt physical—a fissure running through something she had thought was solid, something she had been carrying for so long she had forgotten it was there.

"She was sick for a year," he said. "She didn't tell anyone. She didn't want to worry us. And I didn't see it. I was so busy with the Inn and the League and all the things I thought mattered that I didn't see my own wife dying in our bed."

"Dad. That wasn't—"

"It was. It was my fault, and I couldn't face that, so I found something else to blame. I found you." He looked at her, and his eyes were wet, but his voice did not waver. "I blamed you for leaving. I blamed you for not being here. I blamed you for every part of her death that I couldn't control, and I made you carry it, and I'm sorry."

She did not know what to say. She had spent years waiting for him to say those words, and now that he had said them, she did not know what to do with them. They sat in the air between them like something living, something that could not be put back into a bottle once it had been opened.

"The ferry leaves at nine," he said. "I'll make sure your things are

brought down. I'll be at the harbor to see you off."

"You don't have to."

"I know. That's why I'm going."

He stood up. He looked at her for a long moment, and she saw him deciding something—not whether to let her go, that decision had already been made, but something else. Something she could not read.

"Finlay," she said. "The men who died—"

"I know."

"Who are they? Who do I—"

"You don't have to do anything." His voice was firm. "The Daughters will see to the rites. The families will be looked after. That's not your burden to carry."

"It was my fault."

"No." He shook his head. "It was the sea's. It was the reading's. It was every force in this world that takes what it wants and doesn't care who it breaks. You're alive because you were meant to be alive. That's not a crime, Eilidh. That's not something you have to pay for."

She opened her mouth to argue, but he was already turning away. He walked to the door and put his hand on the frame and stopped, and she saw his shoulders rise and fall with a breath that seemed to come from somewhere very deep.

"I'll see you in the morning," he said.

The door closed behind him.

Eilidh sat alone in the firelit room, and she did not move for a very long time.

...

The morning came gray and still.

Eilidh stood at the harbor's edge with her bag at her feet and watched the ferry approach. It was a small boat, white-sided, the kind she had taken a hundred times before. The kind that had carried her away to university and to her flat in Edinburgh and to the life she had built on

the mainland, the life that was hers and no one else's, the life she had thought she wanted.

The harbor was quiet. A few fishermen moved along the pier, checking nets, coiling rope. No one looked at her. No one spoke to her. She was grateful for this. She did not think she could bear to be looked at, to be wondered about, to be the woman who had come back from the dead and cost four men their lives in the bargain.

Finlay stood beside her. He had not said much during the walk from the Inn. Neither had she. They had walked through streets that felt strange to her now, streets she had known since childhood but which seemed to belong to someone else, someone who had grown up here and left and come back and died in the water and been given back with something essential missing.

He picked up her bag without asking. She let him.

They walked to the end of the pier together, and the ferry came alongside, and the deckhand lowered the ramp, and Eilidh stepped aboard.

The deck was wet with spray. The smell was diesel and salt and something else, something she could not name—something that lived in the planks, in the ropes, in the memory of every crossing she had ever made. She walked to the rail and gripped it and looked back at the island.

Torran.

The harbor was silver in the morning light. The hills rose behind it, green and gray. The lighthouse stood on its promontory, white and silent, and Eilidh looked at it and felt nothing, and that nothing was the worst thing of all.

She had loved this place. She had hated it, too, had fought against it, had spent years trying to convince herself that she was not shaped by it. But she had loved it. She had carried it with her to Edinburgh and to every job and every flat and every relationship that had ended badly, and she had carried it still, because it was hers, because it had made her, because no matter how far she ran she could not outpace the place that had written itself into her bones.

Now it was gone.

She watched the island shrink.

The harbor grew smaller. The lighthouse grew smaller. The hills folded into each other, became a single shape against the sky, became a smudge on the horizon, became nothing.

She did not cry. She did not think she had any tears left. She stood at the rail and watched and felt the ferry rise and fall beneath her feet, and she understood, finally, what the reading had cost.

Not her life. The reading had given her that. It had kept its bargain and let her live.

But the island—the island was gone. The home she had almost reclaimed, the place where her mother was buried, the place where her father still stood at the water's edge and waited for her to come back. The reading had taken all of that and fed it to the sea, and the sea had swallowed it, and now she was going home to a city that did not know her, to a flat that did not feel like anything, to a life that was hers and no one else's and no one's at all.

The ferry chugged on.

Behind her, Torran disappeared beneath the edge of the world.

Ahead, the mainland rose out of the sea, gray and green and familiar in a way that felt like a lie.

Eilidh closed her eyes.

She breathed in salt air.

She did not look back again.

...

The crossing took two hours.

Eilidh spent them in the cabin, curled in a seat by the window, watching the water. The sea was calm this morning—calmer than it had any right to be, calmer than she trusted. She kept expecting the waves to rise, the wind to shift, the sky to darken. She kept expecting the sea to take something else, to remind her that she was still in its

domain, that she had not escaped, that she would never escape.

But the water stayed smooth, and the sun broke through the clouds, and the mainland grew closer, and eventually the ferry glided into the harbor at Ullapool, and the deckhand called out the arrival, and Eilidh gathered her bag and walked off the boat.

The pier was crowded. People with suitcases, people with dogs, people with children. She moved through them like a ghost, unnoticed, unremarkable. Just another passenger. Just another person who had arrived somewhere after being somewhere else.

She found a bench at the edge of the harbor and sat down.

The sun was warm on her face. The water lapped at the stones below her feet. Somewhere behind her, the ferry was being refueled, and people were disembarking, and life was continuing in all its ordinary, relentless ways.

She thought about calling someone. She had friends in Edinburgh, colleagues who would want to know she was back, who would ask questions she did not want to answer. She thought about calling her flatmate, about going home, about sliding back into the life she had built and pretending none of this had happened.

She thought about the men in the water. She thought about their faces. She thought about their wives and children waiting for news that would not come.

She thought about her mother.

She thought about the way her mother had looked in the hospital, at the end, when the sickness had finally been too much to hide. Her mother had been so small in that bed. So thin. Her mother, who had always seemed so large, so certain, so much a part of the island itself that it was hard to believe she could be diminished by anything.

But she had been diminished. She had died. And Eilidh had not been there, not really, not in any way that mattered, and she had come back for the funeral and left again and not come back until the reading had called her home, and now she was leaving again, and her mother was still in the ground on that island, and her father was still standing

at the water's edge, and nothing had changed.

Everything had changed.

Eilidh stood up.

She picked up her bag.

She walked toward the bus station, toward the long road south, toward Edinburgh and her flat and her life.

She did not look back.

...

The bus was half-empty.

Eilidh took a seat near the back and put her bag on the rack above her and pressed her forehead against the window and watched the landscape scroll past. The hills rose and fell. The lochs caught the light. The small towns came and went, each one a cluster of buildings that seemed to exist outside of time, outside of the world she had left behind.

She slept, eventually. She did not mean to, but the motion of the bus was soothing, and the sun was warm through the glass, and her body had finally decided that it was safe to stop fighting, to stop waiting for the next blow to fall.

She dreamed of water.

She dreamed of being in the sea, not drowning, just floating. The water was dark and cold and held her up, and she could see the sky above, gray and high and very far away. She could see the bottom of a boat above her, the hull of the ferry, the people she could not reach. She could see the shadows of fish moving in the deep. She could see, far below her, the shapes of things the sea had kept.

She woke up when the bus stopped.

The driver called out the name of a town she did not recognize. No one else got on. The bus sat there for five minutes while the driver smoked a cigarette by the door, and Eilidh sat in her seat and breathed and tried to remember how to be a person who was going somewhere instead of a person who was running away.

The bus started again.

She watched the road unspool ahead of her.

She thought about Finlay standing at the harbor, watching the ferry leave. She thought about Mara climbing the tower, climbing into the light. She thought about Agnes in the vestry, naming the dead, performing the rites that had been performed for generations. She thought about all the people on that island who had been touched by the reading, who had paid its price, who would go on living in its wake.

She thought about survival.

Was it enough?

She did not know. She did not think she would ever know. But she was alive, and she was going forward, and the road was long and the sun was setting and somewhere ahead of her there was a city and a flat and a life that was waiting to be lived.

She closed her eyes.

The bus carried her south.

The island was gone.

CHAPTER 27

The Light



THE fire had burned to embers when Mara woke. She lay in the narrow bed and listened to the sea against the rocks below, the same rhythm it had kept for a hundred years, and she thought: the girl is gone.

She had known this before she opened her eyes. The knowing lived in her chest like a stone, cold and heavy and certain. Eilidh had gone south on the morning ferry, watching the island shrink behind her, and Mara had watched from the shore until the ferry was only a speck and then nothing. Then she had come back to the cottage and made tea and sat by the fire and done nothing, for hours, until her body decided it was done.

Now the morning had come.

Gray light through the window. The smell of ash.

Mara pushed back the blanket and put her feet on the cold floor. The stones were familiar beneath her soles, worn smooth by years of her pacing, her standing, her waiting. She did not think about what she would do today. She knew.

She dressed without hurrying. Wool sweater, heavy trousers, the

boots she wore to the shore. Through the window she could see the harbor—four boats, one of them new, a hull bright with fresh paint that someone had paid for. She counted them automatically. The counting was a habit, a bone-deep thing she could not stop, any more than she could stop breathing.

Finlay was at the Inn, probably. Eilidh had not gone to him before she left. Mara had watched from a distance, seen the girl walk past the Inn with her bag on her shoulder, seen Finlay standing in the doorway with his hands at his sides and nothing in his face at all. He had not called out. She had not looked back.

That was between them. It was not Mara's to hold.

She put on her coat and stepped outside.

The wind was off the north, carrying the smell of open water. Clouds hung low over the island, the color of wet slate, and the grass bent under the gusts. Below the cottage, the rocks were dark with spray. The lighthouse stood against the gray sky, sixty-two feet of stone, and at its top the light turned slow and white, marking the water for ships that were not there.

Dr. Macallister's van was parked at the base of the path.

Mara stopped. She had not expected this. The maintenance company sent someone quarterly—inspections, oil changes, the mechanical business of keeping a light that no longer needed a keeper. She had seen the van before, watched it arrive and leave, watched other men climb the tower while she stayed below.

She had not thought to ask when the next inspection would be. She had not thought about the tower at all, not directly, not as something that might be reachable.

But here was the van, and here was the morning, and the wind was pushing her toward the path.

She walked.

Dr. Macallister was a man of perhaps fifty, solid in the way of people who spend their lives driving and walking and climbing. He had a clipboard in his hand and a set of keys on a chain at his belt, and when

he saw Mara approaching he straightened up from where he had been examining the base of the tower.

"Mrs. Callaghan."

"Doctor Macallister."

"Quarterly check." He gestured vaguely at the tower. "Company wants the mechanism documented. You know how it is."

"I know."

She stood beside him and looked up. The door was at the base, iron painted gray, and above it the stone rose in a column that seemed to narrow toward the sky. The light housing was visible at the top, glass and metal, and inside it the mechanism turned.

"I could watch you work," Mara said. "If that would be all right."

Macallister looked at her. "The company's policy is that the tower's off-limits to non-personnel. Insurance thing."

"I understand."

"Can't let anyone up while the light's running. Spinning mechanism, hot housing, the insurance boys get nervous."

"I understand."

He studied her for a moment. She did not know what he saw. She was sixty-four years old and wore the island like a second skin, and her face was the kind of face that had stopped asking for things a long time ago.

"Wouldn't be much to see anyway," he said. "Modern housing, original mechanism below it. The company's been trying to get funding to restore the whole thing, put in a proper visitor center. That Muirhead woman's been pushing for it."

"I know."

He turned the keys over in his hand. "The inspection won't take long. An hour, maybe. I could give you a look at the mechanism room, at least. That's historical, the company's happy to show that off. Just not the lamp room while the light's running."

Mara felt something loosen in her chest. "That would be enough. Thank you."

“Can’t say I understand why you’d want to, but it’s your island.”

“It’s not my island.”

“No. No, I suppose it isn’t.”

He unlocked the door and held it open. The darkness inside was familiar, the smell of old stone and machine oil, and Mara stepped through.

The stairs spiraled up in the old way, iron treads worn smooth by generations of keepers. Macallister climbed first, his flashlight cutting a pale wedge through the dimness, and Mara followed. Her legs remembered this. Her hands remembered the rail. The rhythm of climbing—step, step, step, hand to rail, foot to tread, repeat—was buried in her body like a code, and her body obeyed without consulting her mind.

She had climbed these stairs every night for twenty-seven years. She had climbed them in the dark, in the storm, in the cold that seeped through the stone and settled in her bones. She had climbed them with her lamp trimmed and her log written and her eyes on the water below, watching for shapes that should not be there.

Now she climbed them in the daylight, following a man she did not know, and the only thing she watched for was the next step.

The mechanism room was a gallery of brass and iron, gears and weights, a clockwork system designed before anyone living was born. Macallister walked among it with his clipboard, checking gauges, recording numbers, murmuring to himself about pressure readings and oil levels. Mara stood in the doorway and let it wash over her.

This was where the light lived. Not in the glass housing at the top, but here, in the works that turned it. The weights that dropped, the gears that meshed, the slow release of energy that kept the lamp revolving at the speed the shipping lanes required. She had learned this system with her hands, had polished the brass until it shone, had felt the vibration of the mechanism through her palms when something needed adjusting.

Macallister pointed out features as he worked. The original clock mechanism, dated 1887. The weight-driven governor that controlled rotation speed. The lamp housing, replaced in 1998, that held the mod-

ern bulb in a frame designed for something older.

"The system's a mess," Macallister said, without apparent concern. "Frankenstein thing, old and new bolted together. But it works. Keeps the light turning. Keeps the ships from hitting the rocks."

"Has it worked?"

"So far."

Mara said nothing.

When Macallister finished his inspection, he stood by the stairwell and gestured upward. "I can take you to the lamp room access, if you want. You can't go in while it's running, but the view through the door's something."

"Yes," Mara said. "I'd like that."

She climbed the last flight of stairs, past the door to the keeper's quarters that had been removed decades ago, past the narrow window that showed the harbor in miniature far below, up to the top where the mechanism met the housing and the light turned.

The lamp room door was a circle of glass set in iron. Macallister opened it a crack. The light blazed through.

"You can look," he said. "But don't touch the mechanism. She'll take your fingers off if you're not careful."

Mara looked.

The light was a wheel, turning slow, and in the wheel the flame burned constant and white. It was not the flame she had known—the old flame had been oil, a fire that required tending—but it turned the same way, marked the water the same way, called to the ships the same way. The mechanism hummed with a sound she remembered, a sound that had been the soundtrack of her nights for twenty-seven years.

Beyond the light, the world spread out.

She could see the harbor—Aultree's single street, the Inn, the boats tied to their buoys, Finlay's black coat by the water. She could see the moorland rolling toward the east, the streams catching the gray light, the cairn a dark smudge on the horizon. She could see the water, gray and restless, and beyond it, when the clouds thinned, the mainland's

coast.

She could see all the places she had watched for thirty years.

“Remarkable view,” Macallister said from behind her. “I can see why you’d want to see it.”

“Yes,” Mara said. She was not listening to him. She was listening to the hum of the mechanism, the turning of the light, the sound she had carried in her bones for so long she did not know if she remembered it or if it was simply part of her.

She stood in the doorway and watched the light turn, and she thought: this is where I stood.

She had stood here in storms that shook the tower. She had stood here in calm nights when the water was flat and the stars came down to meet her. She had stood here in the dark before dawn, watching the horizon for the first hint of light, and she had stood here in the hours after, when the light was only itself, turning and turning and turning.

And she had stood here in 1998.

The night the freighters came. The night the storm put its hands on the water and shook it until the ships broke. She had lit the signal fires. She had turned the light. She had watched from this window and seen the shapes appear out of the dark and then disappear, one after another, like things the sea was taking back.

She had not been able to save them. The rescue boat from the mainland had been too late, and the eleven had gone into the water, and she had watched.

That was the weight she carried. That was the thing that lived in her chest like a stone.

She had never learned their names. She had seen their faces—the way the sea wore them away—and she had not learned their names because learning their names would have made them real, would have made them people she could have saved if she had known something different, done something different, been something different.

She had not learned their names, and so they had become hers to carry. Eleven faces without names. Eleven lives that had ended while

she watched. Eleven debts she did not know how to pay.

The light turned.

Mara watched it and felt the weight in her chest, and she thought: I am done carrying this alone.

She did not speak aloud at first. She spoke inside her head, in the silence that had been her companion for fifteen years.

Donald MacRae.

The name came from somewhere she did not know. Perhaps she had heard it. Perhaps she had read it. Perhaps the sea had whispered it to her in the night, over and over, until it lodged in the place where she kept the things she could not release.

Donald MacRae. Robert Murray. Thomas Black. James MacLeod. John Cameron. Duncan MacInnes. Andrew Reid. Kenneth Shaw. Malcolm MacLeod. William Fraser. Charles MacDonald.

Eleven names.

Eleven men.

Eleven lives that had ended in the water while she watched from above.

She spoke them aloud. The sound of her own voice surprised her—it was rough, unused to this work, and the names came out cracked and strange. But she said them. One after another. Donald MacRae. Robert Murray. Thomas Black. James MacLeod. John Cameron. Duncan MacInnes. Andrew Reid. Kenneth Shaw. Malcolm MacLeod. William Fraser. Charles MacDonald.

The light turned. The mechanism hummed. The sea was below, gray and endless, and it did not care.

But she said the names.

She said them, and she felt the weight shift. It did not leave. It would never leave. But it moved from the center of her chest to somewhere she could carry it differently—not as a wound that bled but as a scar that ached when the weather changed.

She was not done with them. She would never be done with them.

But she could let them go.

The light turned. The mechanism hummed. Mara stood at the top of the tower she had climbed for thirty years, and she watched the harbor where the boats sat patient in the water, and she watched the shore where the waves broke against the rocks, and she watched the mainland's coast on the horizon where the land rose out of the sea like a promise that things could be different.

She watched, and she let the names go.

Donald. Robert. Thomas. James. John. Duncan. Andrew. Kenneth. Malcolm. William. Charles.

They were not hers to carry. They had never been hers to carry. She had taken them because she could not stop watching, could not stop witnessing, could not stop being the one who saw what happened and could not stop it. But the watching was not the same as the guilt. The seeing was not the same as the failing.

She had done everything right. The signal fires. The light. The watch. She had done everything right, and the rescue boat had been too late, and the eleven had gone into the water, and there was nothing she could have done.

She had not believed this before. She had carried the guilt because she did not know what else to do with the grief. But now, standing in the tower, she let herself believe it: there was nothing she could have done.

The guilt could go.

She did not have to carry it anymore.

Mara stood in the doorway of the lamp room and breathed. The air was cold on her face, carrying the salt and the wet and the endless motion of the sea. Below her, the harbor waited. The boats counted themselves. The Inn stood where it had always stood. Finlay was there, probably, thinking about his daughter, thinking about the island, thinking about all the things he could not control.

She had told him the truth. She had given him the warning. She had climbed the tower and said the names and done what she came to do.

What happened next was not hers to decide.

The light turned. The mechanism hummed. The world was gray and endless and full of water, and somewhere far to the south a bus was carrying a woman toward a city and a flat and a life that was waiting to be lived.

Mara watched the horizon. The mainland's coast was visible, a dark line against the gray, and beyond it the world went on the way the world went on—inconvenient, ordinary, full of people who did not know what the sea held and did not want to know.

She would go back to the cottage. She would light the fire. She would count the boats in the morning and the boats in the evening and the boats whenever she happened to look toward the harbor, because that was what she did, because that was who she was, because the counting was not a prison but a prayer.

She would live.

The light turned.

Mara Callaghan stood in the tower and watched the water, and she did not look away.

CHAPTER 28

*The fire had burned down to embers when she woke.
Not the deep sleep of exhaustion this time, but the
ordinary waking of a body that had rested enough.
Mara lay still and listened to the silence. The wind
had dropped. The sea was murmuring the way it did
when it was tired too.*



SHE got up. The floorboards were cold under her feet. She put on her boots without thinking, pulled her coat from the hook by the door, and went outside.

The light came gray through the east, the way it always did in the morning before the sun decided whether to show itself. The world was quiet. The kind of quiet that used to frighten her, years ago, when the silence after a storm meant she had to go down to the shore and count.

She didn't count anymore. Not like that. Not with dread.

The path to the harbor was the same path she had walked for fifteen years. She knew every stone, every place where the turf dipped, every stretch where the heather had crept over the edge and onto the track.

Her body knew it well enough that her mind could float, could watch the sky, could notice the way the light was changing.

Four boats in the harbor. She had expected three. The McLeod boat was back—the one with the cracked hull, the one that had sat on the slip for two years waiting for parts that never came. Someone had found the parts. Someone had done the work. The boat sat in the water with its new paint still bright, looking like a thing that intended to stay.

She counted them again to be sure. Once for habit. Twice because she could.

Four.

The harbor was quiet. A few of the fishing crews were already moving, checking lines, preparing for the day. Finlay would be in the Inn, probably. Making the tea he made every morning, thinking the thoughts he thought every morning. She had not seen him since the night on the headland, since he had understood that his daughter was coming back, since she had watched something move behind his eyes that she could not name.

She started up the path to the headland, the way she always did, and she saw him at the far end of the harbor wall. He was standing with his hands in his pockets, looking at the water. Looking at the boats. Looking at nothing.

He saw her. He raised his hand.

She raised hers.

He did not come to her. She did not go to him. The wave hung between them for a moment, a gesture that said: I see you. I know what you know. I will not bother you with it today.

She dropped her hand. He dropped his. They each turned back to their own directions, and that was enough.

The path to Ellen's Cove was longer, winding down through the moor where the grass grew thin and the rocks showed through. The cove was sheltered from the north wind, which meant it was always a few degrees warmer than it should have been, which meant the air there felt wrong, heavy and still. Mara had avoided it for years. She did not

the fire had burned down to embers when she woke. not the deep sleep of exhaustion this time, but the ordinary waking of a body that had rested enough. mara lay still and listened to the silence. the wind had dropped. the avoid it now. sea was murmuring the way it did when it was tired too.

Agnes was sitting on the flat stone at the cove's edge, the one the Daughters used for their observances. She was not doing anything visible. Just sitting. Watching the water.

Mara stood at the top of the path and lifted her hand.

Agnes looked up. She lifted hers in return.

They did not speak. They did not need to. Agnes knew what Mara knew. Agnes knew what the night had cost, what the light had taken, what the names had meant. They had stood together at the edge of the water while the eleven were remembered, and that standing had been enough.

Mara let her hand fall. Agnes turned back to the cove. The distance between them was the right distance. It had always been the right distance.

The lighthouse stood on the headland, sixty-two feet of granite and iron, the same as it had been for a hundred and thirty years. The light was turning. She could hear the mechanism from here, the slow hum of gears that had been turning since before she was born, that would keep turning after she was gone. It did not need her anymore. It had never really needed her. She had only been the one who was there.

The light turned. The beam swept across the water, across the rocks, across the harbor where four boats sat waiting for the day. It passed over the cove where Agnes sat. It passed over the headland where Finlay had been standing. It passed over everything the island was and everything it had been and everything it would be, and it did not stop, because that was not what light did.

Mara watched it turn.

She had thought, once, that the light was hers. That the tower was hers. That the keeping was a thing she owned because she had given it so much of her life. She had been wrong. The light was the light. The tower was the tower. She had only been the hands that tended them, and now other hands tended them, and that was right. That was as it should be.

She turned and walked back to the cottage.

The fire wanted building. She knelt by the hearth and stacked the peat, coaxed the embers with the bellows until the new fuel caught. The smoke rose and curled and filled the small space with warmth. She stood and put the kettle on the iron hook over the flames.

The cottage smelled of salt and smoke. It always had. The rosemary on the windowsill was the same rosemary she had planted years ago, when the cottage was still new to her and she thought she could make it something other than what it was. It had not become something else. It had become exactly what it was, and she had become part of it, and the two of them fit together now the way a harbor fits the boats that shelter there.

She poured the water. She waited for the tea to steep. She poured it into the cup that had belonged to her grandmother, the one with the chip on the rim that she always felt but never looked for anymore.

The eleven were with her. They had been with her since the night in the tower, since she had said their names and meant them. She did not see their faces anymore, or she saw them differently now—not as the faces of the dead but as the faces of the witnessed. They had been there. They had lived. They had gone into the water, and she had seen them go, and that seeing was not a wound anymore. It was a keeping. It was what she owed them.

She drank her tea. She sat by the window and watched the light move across the harbor.

The boats counted themselves. Four. One new. One repaired. One that had decided to stay.

Finlay was out there somewhere, doing the things Finlay did. Making tea. Managing the Inn. Thinking about his daughter on the mainland, safe on solid ground, building a life that had nothing to do with the sea. He did not need to believe anymore. He knew.

Agnes was at the cove, keeping her watch, doing the work that the Daughters had always done. Honoring what could not be changed. Preparing for what might. She knew the cost of the readings. She had

the fire had burned down to embers when she woke. not the deep sleep of exhaustion this time, but the ordinary waking of a body that had rested enough. mara lay still and listened to the silence. the wind had dropped. the paid it. She would help anyone who needed help, and she would not ask for thanks, and she would not explain herself to anyone who did not already understand.

The light turned. The mechanism hummed. The world went on.

Mara put down her cup. She looked at the eleven chairs around the table that was not a table, at the eleven names she had written on the page she had folded and put in her pocket and taken to the tower. She did not need the paper anymore. She had said the names. They were heard. They were kept.

She stood. She stretched. She put the cup in the basin by the door.

Outside, the day was deciding to be ordinary. The clouds were thin enough to let through some sun. The wind was from the west, which meant fair weather. The boats would go out, and they would come back, and the island would be the island for another day.

Mara put on her coat. She opened the door.

She was not alone. She would never be alone again, not the way she had been alone before. The eleven were with her. The light was with her. The island was with her, in all its stubborn, dying, refusing-to-die persistence. She was part of it. She had always been part of it. She had just remembered how to feel it.

She walked down the path toward the harbor. Not to count. Not to watch. Just to walk. Just to be in the world that was still there, still moving, still turning toward whatever came next.

The light turned behind her. The mechanism hummed. The tea cooled on the windowsill of the cottage that was her home, and would be, and had always been, and she was not afraid of the silence anymore because the silence was not empty.

It was full of names. It was full of keeping.

It was full of what witness owes.

Mara Callaghan walked down to the harbor, and the boats counted themselves, and the day was ordinary, and that was enough. That was more than enough. That was everything she had thought she lost and found again in the space of a single night, in the speaking of eleven

names, in the turning of a light that did not need her but let her stay anyway.

She waved to Finlay across the harbor.

He waved back.

The light turned. The sea murmured. The island held.

— ♦ —

The tide turned.